Preface

AD 50 Troas

17 years since the Crucifixion of Jesus

``Have you heard the news? The Good News that comes from God?

``Let me tell you, for I promise you that the time of fulfillment of the promise is *now*. The time has come and the promises are being kept.

``Jesus, a man, but truly the Son of God, who was born of a woman, as a human descended from the ancient Jewish King David and marked out as the Son of God by the Spirit of Holiness which enabled him to conquer all the ills of this world - even his own degrading death.

``All this, I tell you, was foreseen by the prophets of old time and is to be found promised by them in the Holy Scriptures.

``It is from this man, I say, that we have received the grace of God and are now saved - are indeed, in our own way, the children of God through adoption even as Jesus was his true Son.

``Who was then this Jesus?

``God sent many prophets to point the way of repentance to the people of Israel. Sometimes they listened, and often they did not. They came, they prophesied and those who listened repented of their sins.

``Thirty years ago, God sent another prophet, John by name, he who was foreseen by Isaiah: `The voice of one crying in the wilderness.' In the wilderness he preached; in the wilderness he baptised; and in the wilderness many repented of their sins.

``And many discussed among themselves whether this might be the Chosen One - God's son. But when they put the question to John he said `no, it is not I. But the time will be soon. Repent and hear the Gospel.'

``But one day came a man to John for baptism that John knew, for it was his cousin. And he denied him baptism, for, being a holy man of God, he knew that this was God's son, the one who, in his own words, would baptise others, `only not with water, but with the blazing fires of Heaven.

``But Jesus in humility insisted on baptism, that all the forms might be observed: that he might be truly ready to begin his own ministry.

``And what a ministry it was! Unlike others, he did not need to argue long details of the law, but he told the truth, the truth that came directly from God.

``Jesus did not come, as many thought he would, as a King, born into a Palace, with a royal robe and a diadem, but lived humbly, his early years spent as a journeyman carpenter, giving quality work for a fair price and treating no man unfairly or dishonestly.

``And he did not come to reinforce the prejudices of this world, to reward the rich and impoverish the poor. Listen to these sayings of Jesus:

`` `How happy are you who have nothing, for the Kingdom of God is open to you!

`` `How happy are you who feel hungry, for you will have plenty of nourishment!

`` `How happy are you who weep now, for you are going to laugh!'

``But Jesus did not come to teach, amazing as his words were. He came to change the course of human history.

``In proof of that, everywhere he went, people were transformed! Not just in their hearts, but in the bodies, too.

``Consider just two simple examples:

``One day when he was in Capernaum, a town in Galilee, he was teaching on the Sabbath day. And, as always, those who heard him were astonished, for his words had the ring of authority.

``There was a man in the synagogue under the influence of some evil spirit and he yelled at the top of his voice, "Hi! What have you got to do with us, Jesus, you Nazarene - have you come to kill us? I know who you are all right, you're God's holy one!"

``Jesus cut him short and spoke sharply, "Be quiet! Get out of him!" And after throwing the man down in front of them, the devil did come out of him without hurting him in the slightest. At this everybody present was amazed and they kept saying to each other, "What sort of words are these? He speaks to these evil spirits with authority and power and out they come."

``When he was in one of the towns of Galilee, he came upon a man who was a mass of leprosy. When he saw Jesus, he prostrated himself before him and begged, `If you want to, Lord, you can make me clean.'

``Jesus stretched out his hand, placed it on the leper, saying, `Certainly I want to. Be clean!'

``Immediately the leprosy left him and Jesus told him to go and show himself to the priest and to make the offerings for his recovery that Moses had prescribed, as evidence to the authorities.

``So, you might imagine that all the people repented of their wrongdoing and all was harmony.

``No!

``That day is coming; indeed, that day will very shortly be upon us. Christ will return in his glory, shown at the right hand of God himself and all will be judged! Woe to them who are found wanting when that day comes, for it will not be pleasant to have not repented on that day! They will be whittled from the wheat like chaff and only the righteous will remain.

``But no, those who felt threatened by the Truth, by the Son of God incarnate among them and telling it as it really is, they gathered together and tried to entrap him, and make a fool of him in front of the people, and discredit him.

``Ha! But they couldn't, you know, they couldn't. They tried and they tried, but they were mere men against the word of God. And the devices of men cannot stand against the word of God.

``Consider this:

``One of the Jewish rulers put this question to him, `Master, I know that you are good; tell me, please, what must I do to be sure of eternal life?'

`` `I wonder why you call me good?' returned Jesus. 'No person is good - only the one God. But surely you know the commandments - 'Do not commit adultery,' 'Do not murder,' 'Do not steal,' 'Do not bear false witness,' 'Honour your father and your mother'. Are these not enough to guarantee eternal life? '

`` `All these,' he replied, `I have carefully kept since I was quite young.'

``So when Jesus heard that, he said to him, `In that case, I see that there is still one thing you have missed. Sell everything you possess and give the money away to the poor, and you will have riches in Heaven.

`` `Then come and follow me.'

``But when he heard this, he was greatly distressed for he was very rich.

``And Jesus, when he saw how his face fell, remarked, `How difficult it is for those who have great possessions to enter the kingdom of God! A camel loaded down with goods could squeeze through the gate of a city more easily than a man weighed down with his riches could get into the kingdom of God.'

``So what did the dark plotters do? Did they see the error of their ways and repent? Hardly!

``Now the holy anger of God is disclosed from Heaven against the godlessness and evil of those men who render truth dumb and inoperative by their wickedness. It is not that they do not know the truth about God; indeed he has made it quite plain to them. For since the beginning of the world the invisible attributes of God have been plainly discernible through things which he has made and which are commonly seen and known, thus leaving these men without a rag of excuse. They knew all the time that there is a God, yet they refused to acknowledge him as such, or to thank him for what he is or does. Thus they became fatuous in their argumentations, and plunged their silly minds still further into the dark.

``Behind a facade of "wisdom" they became just fools, fools who would exchange the glory of the eternal God for an imitation image of a mortal man, or of creatures that run or fly or crawl.

``And they found one man, a disciple of Jesus', who they could corrupt into laying false charges against him and betraying him into the hands of the rulers of the Jews.

``And they did it late at night, when the crowds had gone home. Under cover of darkness, in the devil's hour, they did their work.

``Yet we cannot judge them, for we also are sinners: God is the only judge

``Now if you feel inclined to set yourself up as a judge of those who sin, let me assure you, whoever you are, that you are in no position to do so. For at whatever point you condemn others you automatically condemn yourself, since you, the judge, commit the same sins. God's judgment, we know, is utterly impartial in its action against such evil-doers. What makes you think that you who so readily judge the sins of others, can consider yourself beyond the judgment of God?

``Are you by your obstinate refusal to repent simply storing up for yourself an experience of the wrath of God in the day when, in his holy anger against evil, he shows his hand in righteous judgment?

``So they took him privately and handed him over to the Roman governor on charges of sedition and corruption.

``But even if this they failed - for the Roman governor himself could find nothing wrong with him! I ask you, would you be confident that the Governor of Asia would find nothing wrong with you? Indeed; their venality is a by-word. And yet, and yet, no fault at all could he find in Jesus.

``But they were not to be denied, these who so value their `faith' that they would deny the very Son of God! No, no! Faced with the refusal even of the Roman Governor to put an innocent man to death, they begged, pleaded and cajoled, even threatened to riot until they got their way.

``So the man Jesus was killed by the Romans, crucified like a common criminal. And the wicked ones were satisfied.

``But wait! God could not abide that death should be shown to be more powerful than His Will! By a mighty act, God did restore his son from the grave, as he has promised all will be raised at the end of days.

``He did not raise up a corruptible body, corruptible as the human body before death, subject to sin, suffering and death, but an incorruptible body, a body of light and glory.

``Yes, yes - a human body, to be sure - he was recognized by his followers and those to whom he appeared. But a body transformed through the resurrection! And yet, there are still those who say, `but there is no resurrection.'

``But let us be very clear on this point. God, by performing the resurrection of his son Jesus, did very clearly show that the resurrection is *real*. It is no longer a hypothetical. It is happening now.

``And I say to you that the ministry and resurrection of Jesus is just the first of fruits of the tree of the Spirit. The Messianic age is dawning. Before long, my brethren, Jesus will return in all his power and glory and will divide the chaff from the wheat. There will be great celebration in that day - and also great mourning. Who will you be in that day?

``Consider this parable which Jesus spoke before he was crucified:

``You must be ready dressed and have your lamps alight, like men who wait to welcome their lord and master on his return from the wedding-feast, so that when he comes and knocks at the door, they may open it for him at once. Happy are the servants whom their lord finds on the alert when he arrives. I assure you that he will take off his outer clothes, make then sit down to dinner, and come and wait on them. And if he should come just after midnight or in the very early morning, and find them still on the alert, their happiness is assured. But be certain of this, that if the householder had known the time when the burglar would come, he would not have let his house be broken into. So you must be on the alert, for the Son of Man is coming at a time when you may not expect him.

``You ask for proof? What further proof do you need than that I stand here? For I am a man myself who has seen these things with my own eyes! Jesus, being crucified and then restored to life by the grace of God, appeared to me, in person, in his restored flesh and showed me the wrong I was doing in persecuting his disciples in Antioch!

``The presence of the Holy Spirit in those who follow our Way is all the proof anyone could need? And yet, and yet you ask for more proof. Can there be certain knowledge for such as you, you doubters?

``But listen and hear and be converted, you wicked ones!

``Right now we are seeing the righteousness of God declared quite apart from the Law: it is a righteousness imparted to, and operating in, all who have faith in Jesus Christ. There is no longer going to be any distinction to be made anywhere: everyone has sinned, everyone falls short of the beauty of God's plan. Anyone who has faith is now freely acquitted in the eyes of God by his generous dealing in the redemptive act of Jesus Christ. God has appointed him as the means of propitiation, a propitiation accomplished by the shedding of his blood, to be received and made effective in ourselves by faith.

``Are we then undermining the Law by this insistence on faith? Not a bit of it! We put the Law in its proper place.

``Now if a man works his wages are not counted as a gift but as a fair reward. But if a man, irrespective of his work, has faith as righteousness, then that man's faith is counted as righteousness, and that is the gift of God. This is the happy state of the man whom God accounts righteous, apart from his achievements, as David expresses it: 'Blessed are those whose lawless deeds are forgiven, and whose sins are covered; blessed is the man to whom the Lord shall not impute sin'.

``Since then it is by faith that we are justified, let us grasp the fact that we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ. Through him we have confidently entered into this new relationship of grace, and here we take our stand, in happy certainty of the glorious things he has for us in the future.

``This doesn't mean, of course, that we have only a hope of future joys - we can be full of joy here and now even in our trials and troubles. Taken in the right spirit these very things will give us patient endurance; this in turn will develop a mature character, and a character of this sort produces a steady hope, a hope that will never disappoint us. Already we have some experience of the love of God flooding through our hearts by the Holy Spirit given to us.

``And we can see that while we were powerless to help ourselves, Christ died for sinful men. In human experience it is a rare thing for one man to give his life for another, even if the latter be a good man, though there have been a few who have had the courage to do it. Yet the proof of God's amazing love is this: that it was while we were sinners that Christ died for us.

``Moreover, if he did that for us while we were sinners, now that we are men justified by the shedding of his blood, what reason have we to fear the wrath of God? If, while we were his enemies, Christ reconciled us to God by dying for us, surely now that we are reconciled we may be perfectly certain of our salvation through his living in us. Nor, I am sure, is this a matter of bare salvation - we may hold our heads high in the light of God's love because of the reconciliation which Christ has made.

``Now, what is the Law of Moses, except a guide to avoid sin? Yet, though sin is shown to be wide and deep, thank God his grace is wider and deeper still! Sin used to be the master of men and in the end handed them over to death: now grace is the ruling factor, with righteousness as its purpose and its end the bringing of men to the eternal life of God through Jesus Christ our Lord.

``So, what do we do now? Shall we sin to our heart's content and see how far we can exploit the grace of God? What a ghastly thought! We, who have died to sin - how could we live in sin a moment longer?

``No, the act of baptism is a sign of purification - as bathing washes away the dirt and grime of the day or of travel, so the act of baptism washes away the sins of the world. Having washed them away, would you really allow them back in?

``Do not, then, allow sin to establish any power over your mortal bodies in making you give way to your lusts. Nor hand over your organs to be, as it were, weapons of evil for the devil's purposes. But, like men rescued from certain death, put yourselves in God's hands as weapons of good for his own purposes. For sin is not meant to be your master - you are no longer living under the Law, but under grace.

``Thus, no condemnation now hangs over the head of those who are "in" Jesus Christ. For the new spiritual principle of life "in" Christ lifts me out of the old vicious circle of sin and death.

``But you are not so trapped if the Spirit of God finds a home within you. You cannot, indeed, be a Christian at all unless you have something of his Spirit in you. Now if Christ does live within you his presence means that your sinful nature is dead, but your spirit becomes alive because of the righteousness he brings with him. I said that our nature is "dead" in the presence of Christ, and so it is, because of its sin. Nevertheless once the Spirit of him who raised Jesus from the dead lives within you he will, by that same Spirit, bring to your whole being new strength and vitality.

``All who follow the leading of God's Spirit are God's own sons. Nor are you meant to relapse into the old slavish attitude of fear - you have been adopted into the very family circle of God and you can say with a full heart, "Father, my Father". The Spirit himself endorses our inward conviction that we really are the children of God. Think what that means. If we are his children we share his treasures, and all that Christ claims as his will belong to all of us as well! Yes, if we share in his suffering we shall certainly share in his glory.

``The Spirit of God not only maintains this hope within us, but helps us in our present limitations. For example, we do not know how to pray worthily as sons of God, but his Spirit within us is actually praying for us in those agonising longings which never find words. And God who knows the heart's secrets understands, of course, the Spirit's intention as he prays for those who love God.

``Moreover we know that to those who love God, who are called according to his plan, everything that happens fits into a pattern for good. God, in his foreknowledge, chose them to bear the family likeness of his Son, that he might be the eldest of a family of many brothers. He chose them long ago; when the time came he called them, he made them righteous in his sight, and then lifted them to the splendour of life as his own sons.

``In face of all this, what is there left to say? If God is for us, who can be against us? He that did not hesitate to spare his own Son but gave him up for us all - can we not trust such a God to give us, with him, everything else that we can need?

``Who would dare to accuse us, whom God has chosen? The judge himself has declared us free from sin. Who is in a position to condemn? Only Christ, and Christ died for us, Christ rose for us, Christ reigns in power for us, Christ prays for us!

``Can anything separate us from the love of Christ? Can trouble, pain or persecution? Can lack of clothes and food, danger to life and limb, the threat of force of arms? Indeed some of us know the truth of the ancient text: 'For your sake we are killed all day long; we are accounted as sheep for the slaughter'.

``No, in all these things we win an overwhelming victory through him who has proved his love for us.

``I have become absolutely convinced that neither death nor life, neither messenger of Heaven nor monarch of earth, neither what happens today nor what may happen tomorrow, neither a power from on high nor a power from below, nor anything else in God's whole world has any power to separate us from the love of God in Jesus Christ our Lord!

``This, then, is the secret of faith; this is exactly what we are preaching, and it says, "If you openly admit by your own mouth that Jesus Christ is the Lord, and if you believe in your own heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved." For it is believing in the heart that makes a man righteous before God, and it is stating his belief by his own mouth that confirms his salvation. And the scripture says: 'Whoever believes on him will not be put to shame'.

``And when I say "whoever", I mean anyone, without distinction between Jew or Greek, free or slave, citien or non-citizen. For all have the same Lord, whose boundless resources are available to all who turn to him in faith. For: 'Whoever calls upon the name of the Lord shall be saved'.

``Are you with me? Will you be saved? Will you call on the name of our Lord Jesus Christ?''

1. Paul

AD 50 Troas

17 years since the crucifixion of Jesus

I sat in shock.

Lydia, my mistress, had sent me along on this trip to Troas for a number of reasons including my desire to consult with some of the medical experts over here in Asia. But without question, her most important assignment for me was to track down Saul of Tarsus, commonly called after his Roman name Paullus - or Paul - and hear what he had to say.

She had first heard of him many years ago from travellers coming from Antioch. We had heard of him numerous times since then as he travelled through the south-west of Asia. But only recently had we heard that he had come into the province.

Lydia was one of the 'god-fearers'. The Jewish religion was very exclusive; you didn't *have* to be born into it, but it certainly helped. Apart from anything else, they had any number of bizarre and unusual practices and restrictions all of which came under the general heading of "the Law of Moses" or, among themselves, simply "the Law".

"The Law" was the great stumbling-block to outsiders - or Gentiles as they were referred to by the Jews - becoming fully-fledged "adopted" Jews, or proselytes. The biggest single obstacle was the requirement for males to undergo circumcision, but even for females such as my mistress, the various complex dietary requirements made daily life outside of a specifically Jewish community almost impossible. And a trade such as purple manufacture - the business in which Lydia was occupied - with its smelly chemicals and noisome environment left one in a state of almost permanent "uncleanness" under the Law.

But there was no doubt that the Jews were sober, dependable and virtuous. In a decadent age such as this, that is unquestionably a good thing. Many wished to be closer to that, to hear how to live more like that, to be encouraged to live more like that; in short, how to be *like that* while at the same time not being subject to the apparently arbitrary other restrictions in the Law.

Paul, we had heard cryptically, preached an alternative to the Law. Exactly what it was had not been made clear by any of our interlocutors. They merely repeated that everywhere he went, he preached that God had come in person and had freed us from the Law. Somehow. But did that freedom just lead us back to the iniquity of the Romans? Whatever it was he was specifically preaching, we heard that in every community he visited, a division rapidly emerged between the Jews and the full Proselytes on the one side, and the 'god-fearers' like ourselves on the other. The Jews, it would seem, objected vociferously to the idea that their cherished Law - that they literally believed to have been given to their leader Moses while he stood on top of a mountain somewhere near Egypt - might be questioned, let alone be made obsolete. They saw themselves as "special", as "the chosen people" of their God, who, by rigid adherence to their code of laws, would be given the first place in line at the end of days when, they believed, rewards would be handed out by their God - or possibly one of his `agents'.

Some, we had heard, believed that this Paul either believed himself to be one of these `agents' or to be acting on behalf of one of them. But none of the stories had been clear. Nothing had really made sense. Which is why, hearing that he was just across the Aegean sea, Lydia had despatched me to hear him, talk to him and hopefully bring him over to Philippi.

I had come. I had heard. And now it all made sense.

Everything that everybody had said at one time or another clicked into place for me as he spoke. All those cryptic comments were a part of the truth, much as when you see a strange animal - such as Elephant - for the first time after hearing it described so many times. What Paul said was all of the things I'd heard - and yet was not constrained by them.

We were in one of the Jewish meetng halls scattered around the empire - synagogues they are called. To be clear, they are not to be confused with Temples - the Jews only have one Temple, and that is in Jerusalem and all their `true' religious acts take place there. The synagogues are places of instruction and teaching. The meetings proceed by having readings from their holy writings - the aforementioned Law of Moses, along with the various collected sayings of their prophets, and then having one or more of the congregation stand up and expound on particular points.

Paul had done more than expound on the readings. I understood why devout Jews could object so violently to his teachings.

And yet, and yet ... was this not exactly what my mistress Lydia wanted to hear? That the promise of a good life rewarded was available to all? That the contents of the heart mattered more that an adherence to an obscure law code?

To look at, Paul was not an impressive man. Short, pale and thin, in ordinary life he had a somewhat careworn and diffident appearance. A nervous, uncertain man who looked harried and tossed on the storms of daily life. But when he stood up to preach "his Gospel" - his account of the life, death and re-birth of the man he called Jesus - he was transformed; as if, in the act of standing, he was possessed by another. He literally seemed to grow taller, more imposing. His otherwise unsteady, reedy voice calmed down and boomed. He became, in short, the prophet that he seemed to claim to be.

After the meeting was over, many flocked around him, wanting to know more. Some, taking issue with his teaching, disputed whether he had the authority to preach as he did. Others wanted to know more and to join with this "Way" of which he spoke. Others just stood around listening to the discussion, trying to understand if this was truly a "new thing" - or if he was just a madman full of his own self-importance.

In consequence, it was more than an hour before the room had cleared out enough that it was worth my while approaching the small knot of men left in the room in the fading light from the almost-dead fire. The meeting had started late - the traditional meeting time being shortly after dark on a Friday - and just gone later and later. First, from the long and impassioned speech that Paul had given, and during which he was frequently interrupted and heckled. Then from the crowds mobbing him after the event. It was now past midnight.

There were probably only about five men left in the synagogue when I approached close enough for Paul to see me properly in the faded light. When he did, I was astounded by his reaction.

``You!'' he screeched. ``It is you who has been haunting my dreams! Tell me, tell me, are you not? You are from Macedonia, correct? And you implore me to come there because of your need for the gospel?''

I was struck dumb. How did he know? What did he mean about haunting his dreams? Had we met before somewhere and I had not known? His nervous demeanour had vanished again and he was staring at me intently; his eyes on fire with passion.

He reached out and grasped my arm, pulling me towards him for a closer look. ``Yes'', he confirmed to himself. ``You are the one, a slave from Macedonia. Tell me, what is it that you want?''

``My mistress,'' I stammered, finally recovering some limited power of speech and still in a state of shock, both from his earlier preaching and his apparent recognition of me.

I tried again.

``My mistress is among the God-fearers at Philippi. She wishes to be one of the elect, but cannot give up her business dying purple. She hears ... she has heard of you and that you preach a different deliverance - of the heart and not of the body. She wants ... she wants to know if you could bring this deliverance to Philippi. If you could `convert' her in a way that the Jews cannot.''

``I, myself, am a Jew,'' retorted Paul. ``Nothing can I do that cannot be done by a Jew. Jesus, also, was a Jew. A Jew born under the Law, subject to the Law, and who died according to the Law.

``But through his death and resurrection he showed the limits of the Law and the true Grace of the Holy One which transcends the Law. That Grace extends to all, regardless of nation, race, gender or status. She is free to accept the Grace of God.''

``But how?'' I mustered. ``I hear your words, but in Philippi we do not have any who can show us this way. We have heard of you from travellers, but the messages they bring are so garbled it is hard to make out what they might mean.''

``I am headed to Bithynia,'' Paul said. ``I must spread the word to all of Asia.''

``And what about Europe?'' I asked. ``Are we not worthy to hear the revealed word of God? We need your help.''

Paul stared at me as if struck.

``The very words!'' he exclaimed. ``The very words of the man in the dream. Tell me you are not him!''

How could I tell him who he had or had not seen in his dream?

After the others had left, we walked back to the lodgings my mistress had arranged for us.

Troas is built on the plain in front of the legendary old city of Troy. They say that Troy itself was built into the mountainside behind the city of Troas. I don't know about that, but there is a hill in front of the mountains that they say is the burial mound of Old Troy.

The modern town is a harbour town, built on the banks of the Maeander and flourishes on the trade through the Bosphorus, linking Cimmeria and Pontus with Bithynia and Greece. When the winds are northerly, whole fleets will end up watering here until the winds change direction, much as they say Agamemnon was forced to wait in Greece to cross the Aegean all those years ago.

So to say that we were staying `near the port' wouldn't really be very descriptive - not much of Troas was *not* near the port. But, understandably, captains and other with rank and wealth enough to opt not to stay on their ships while they are in port wanted to stay relatively close to them, and thus most of the lodgings for transients were within a hundred yards of the docks lining the Maeander. And that was where we stayed.

Six of us had come altogether, servants of my mistress, to negotiate for raw materials and other products for the dyeing business. That didn't include a ship and its crew; when the deals were done, we would arrange for carriage on suitable ships at an appropriate time.

Although it was early in the morning by the time we turned up at the hostel, nobody batted an eyelid. This was a port town and people came and went at all times. Although not Alexandria to have a giant lighthouse burning through the night, signal fires where generally kept burning on either side of the river to enable those trying to navigate the channel at night to do so safely.

Ganymede opened his eyes and looked at us as we came in, then rolled over in his bunk and went back to sleep. Life as a slave is like that: there are real risks, but once you've identified that something is not a threat, sleep is usually the better option. Whatever Paul might look like, he did not look threatening.

We sat down opposite on my bunk and continued talking in low tones so as not to disturb the others in the room more than necessary.

``How do you get by?'' I asked.

``I work, doing whatever comes to hand,'' he replied. ``Usually casual and manual things come easiest. Wherever there's a substantial army encampment, I'll generally work building tents or shelters for the army. They always need work and often find it hard to get people who want to work for them.''

''You work for the Romans?'' I exclaimed, louder that I really had intended to.

``What do the Romans matter?'' he replied, apparently in complete sincerity. ``Within a few years, all that we've known will be swept away and replaced with by the coming Kingdom of God. Claudius will be gone; Messalina will be gone; the wicked and corrupt governors will be gone. How could I delay this important work for a meaningless scruple about working for a doomed, idolatrous empire?''

When he put it like that, I didn't really see any point arguing. The way he saw the world was not just different, it was ... radical. Anything and everything came second to preaching the word of God to anyone who would listen - and often to those who had no interest in listening either.

``We've heard you've run into trouble a number of times,'' I offered, thinking that the tales we had been told were likely exaggerated.

``What of it? Yes, I've been beaten, stoned, thrown into jail. A few months back outside Derbe, I was left for dead after a beating and a stoning for `saying the wrong things'. But they just don't understand ... the Spirit burning within me is so much stronger than anything they can do. Even were they to kill me, I don't believe it would be the end any more than it was for Jesus.''

``You need to come with us,'' I blurted, unable to contain it any longer. ``We in Europe need you; need your words, your message, your conviction. I assure you that you will receive all the support you need from my mistress.''

``Well then,'' said Paul. ``When do we leave?''

``The others still have their business to complete. But by the middle of next week we should be ready to go.''

``That works for me,'' he replied. ``Can I sleep here? I don't have a place of my own.''

I looked at him blankly, and then stood up off `my' bed and let him have it. He probably needed sleep more than I did.

I needed to think.

2. Ananias

AD 50 Aegean Sea

17 years since the crucifixion

The sun came out and it was glorious.

I've met a number of men who are never happier than when on the sea. I am not one of them. I view it as a continual traitor, just waiting for you to make a mistake before swamping you, capsizing you, stranding you or running you aground on inhospitable rocks.

Paul said he had been shipwrecked before, but even that couldn't kill him. Personally, I had no desire to test the theory. Even without shipwreck and death, my skills as a doctor were in continual demand at sea with bruised and damaged fingers, broken limbs and all manner of other minor ailments that come from being stranded on something that doesn't stay still.

We had set off from Troas aiming for Philippi, but as any sailor will tell you, once you set off you don't have a great deal of control about where you end up; the only certainty is that you will sooner or later land *somewhere* - unless you are unfortunate enough to encounter a storm so violent that it sends you to the bottom of the sea before you make landfall anywhere.

To begin with, it had been `plain sailing' as they say, but after three days the wind turned violent from the south west, and pushed us back towards Asia and further north that we wanted to go. We battled the winds and the seas for a whole day and night, and when we came through the storm, we didn't really know where we were.

The wind backed up and came from the east, and we rode it as much as we could. The captain felt that while we were probably further north than we had intended, it was best to try and make landfall as soon as possible and then to `coast' down to Philippi. Naturally, I agreed enthusiastically - the sooner we were back on dry land the better.

In the meantime, I continued to quiz Paul about his life and adventures.

``Tell me more,'' I said, ``about how you became a follower of the Way. You say you used to persecute them.''

``Indeed I did,'' he replied with a wry smile. ``And I used to wonder at their stubbornness and pig-headedness in the face of persecution. But now that I know how they felt ... well, no wonder they went to their deaths singing hymns.''

``What happened?'' I asked.

``I Was in Damascus at the time. I'm from Tarsus, of course, but even then I used to travel a fair amount both in the interests of my family business and also to meet some of the eminent doctors of the Law and leading Pharisees.

``There were some who felt that maybe `this Jesus' - that was how we all used to refer to him: `this Jesus` - was a true prophet, and that he was in line with much of the teaching of the Pharisees. He had an open mind and an open heart and was obviously interested in the welfare of the poor and lowly, particularly in the hill country where the observation of the Law is not strict.

``It was bad enough back in the day, when the Maccabees ruled, and the population there was largely Samaritans and other folk who weren't truly Jews. But then after Pompey came and he and Caesar and that pestilential Elder Herod starting building Graeco-Roman towns, it really went downhill. Anyone who could truly preach the holiness of the Law there would be welcomed.''

``But he didn't?'' I asked.

``He did, but after his own fashion. He did it without respect for the form of the Law. It wasn't enough for him to follow the traditions that had been laid down; he wanted to overturn *everything*; as if there were no tomorrow.'' He paused, laughed at a private joke. ``Of course, that was probably *exactly* how he felt - how I feel now.''

``So what happened?''

``Well, you might have thought that once the leaders had had him crucified, the whole thing would die down. I'd only heard rumours of it from far away, and I was in Antioch at the time. But then the word spread that his followers claimed that he had been raised from the dead and was back amongst us - well, you know what they believed; you heard me preaching it the other night.

``The Way spread like wildfire. Within months, I'd met some of their followers in Antioch. I couldn't believe what they were preaching - even though I now preach it myself!

``Herod the Younger tried to clamp down on it all, of course. But even he - and even with the support of the Emperor - just couldn't get them to shut up. He tried jail - they escaped. He tried executing one of their leaders, Stephen, and that just made them even more enthusiastic. It was becoming a real danger to all of the Jews. What if Claudius were to react violently in support of his good friend Herod?''

None of this, of course, was anything I had really paid attention to. To be fair, at the time I was a young slave living in Philippi and apprenticed to a doctor. Did I care about trivial issues in far-off Judea?

But he was right. The consequences of rebellion anywhere within the empire were grim. As a consequence of which, most provincials had given up trying. That, and the Roman system of rewarding enterprising locals with the coveted citizenship among other benefits led to a bevy of locals who actively supported Rome against `their own' people. Herod Agrippa, presumably, being a case in point.

``As I say, I was in Antioch at the time, and I'd heard that there were a number of members of this Way up in Damascus, led by a substantial citizen of the Synagogue called Ananias. I'd known him for a number of years and I was going up there to plead with him to come to his senses and if not ... well, I was going to turn him over to the authorities for trial.

``But I never made it. On the contrary, he found me when I was led into Damascus blind from a truly life-changing experience I had while on the road there. We were walking along - energetically, to be sure - and hoping to make it into the city before the gates closed at dusk, when suddenly, I was struck with a powerful vision. At least, I assume it was a vision, since those who were travelling with me were not so afflicted.

``A dazzling light appeared in the sky and a big boom of thunder, and then there appeared to me this Jesus - in the flesh, as it were - and he came to me and spoke. He was calm; not angry, but intense. The feeling was overwhelming. I was not afraid, but I could not hold my ground against him. And then, and then ... it was like being threshed with fire. All my beliefs, my ignorance, my worldliness burnt off like impurities in a smelting fire.

``He looked at me with his eyes full of a bottomless, calm pity. Full of love and caring, but seeing right through me, down into the bottom of my soul.

``And the words ... the words he spoke ...

`` `Why, Saul, are you choosing to persecute me? What did you learn from your fathers that taught of hate and not pity? What did I ever do wrong that you should try and kill me and those whose eyes I have opened?

`` `Shall I open your eyes?'

``And then he left; the vision ended. Whether then or before, I don't know, but I must have fallen to the ground. When I came to, I was curled on the ground, hugging myself. Those around me had heard the voice, had heard me screaming, but seen nothing.

``And I myself could see no more. I was blind.''

It took me a few minutes to adjust to what he was saying. He had met Jesus in a vision and been rendered blind. Was such a thing even possible?

``I don't say he made me blind,'' countered Paul. ``Merely that afterwards I was, physically blind. But I had been spiritually blind up until that time, and given the choice, I would rather be physically blind that spiritually.''

``But you are not blind now,'' I commented.

``No,'' said Paul. ``After that, I was slowly led down the road to Damascus like a mule. Obviously, we didn't make it to the city gates that night; I was far too slow for that.

``It was all so difficult. But the physical discomfort was nothing compared to the pain I felt in the Spirit. It literally felt as if my skin was being flensed from my body. And all the time I was thinking ...

``It was like a metaphor. The physical blindness being compared to my spiritual blindness. Only through the act of losing my sight could I understand what I had done; where I had come from. And I saw a had a choice: although really no choice.

``I could carry on in my ignorance and blindness; or I could accept the will of God and move on, able to see both physically and spiritually. But then my whole future would be in pawn: I could only act as God directed me.

``For three days and nights, I was blind and fasted. I prayed diligently to understand the path I should follow and the vision came to me again, of a man ... Ananias.

``He who I would have turned in to the authorities, he it was that I saw coming to save me. I wondered how to reach him, given that he would know I wanted to betray him.

``And then the miracle occurred. He came to the house where I was staying and greeted me as a brother. He, too, had had visions and had seen me wrestling with the power of the Holy Spirit and had been charged to release me. Only through his faith and trust was my healing possible.''

``And then?''

``Like an old man with cataracts, I was healed. They came away and I could see again. Naturally, I immediately fell to my knees and praised God before all those present.

``And then at the earliest opportunity, I left and went into the desert.''

``Why?''

``The Lord led me. Ever since that day he has not ceased to be with me, to talk to me, to direct me. And, as I said when we met, he showed me a man, come from Macedonia, begging for help. You are that man.''

We continued talking for a while in this vain; I heard about his wanderings in the desert, coming to grips with the new teaching, and his return to Damascus, preaching in the Synagogue the words of Jesus for the first time - and the first riot.

Until suddenly a voice cried out from high up in the mast: ``Land! To the West! Land!''

All the passengers rushed forwards to see, but, as always, it was another hour before the first sight of mountains appeared over the horizon. By then, the eagle-eyed lookout had identified where we were. Further north than we wanted, to be sure, but not far from Samothrace. Land was land, and we could walk from there to Philippi. It was safer.

``I've only been to Jerusalem a couple of times,'' Paul confided as we walked down towards Neapolis. ``I think it's safe to say that basically nobody there knows me. After leaving Damascus I went to Jerusalem and met with the leaders of the Way there - Peter and James. It's strange, but they seem very inwardly focused. If Jews want to believe that the Messiah has come, they expound on the preaching, but if they don't, that seems to be fine with them. And as for Gentiles, `first they must become Jews and adopt the Law','' he mimicked. ``They don't seem to have the same pressing urgency about the coming endtimes that I see.''

``Or maybe they just care less that everyone is saved - as long as those who want to be saved are saved, maybe that's enough. After all, the rest of us are merely Gentiles.''

He looked at me, shocked. I don't think anybody had ever made that exact suggestion to him before.

3. Philippi

AD50 Philippi

13 years after the crucifixion

The Jews and the god-fearers gathered on the Sabbath by the riverside.

Lydia and those of us that shared her views had come down here for many years to take part in the sabbath-day teaching and singing. Some of those who didn't come thought that the slaves who did were just using it as an opportunity to shirk work for the day. I can't speak for the others, but for me it was a genuinely transformational experience.

But never as much so as when Paul was there.

Paul had insisted on taking lodgings in the town when we arrived, in spite of the fact that I had insisted that my mistress would love to have him come and stay with us - and also in spite of the fact that Paul's finances were at best penurious (a state I came to realize was neither unusual nor resented). My companions and I obviously went back to the house and to my mistress. She was pleased to see us, but disappointed by Paul's absence.

``Would he not come? Where has he gone? Why did you not insist on him coming?'' she demanded breathlessly before I had a chance to offer any explanations.

``They have come, mistress,'' I responded. ``They have taken up lodging in the town. I did my best to persuade him that he should stay with us, and believe me, he could use the support, but he point-blank refused. And a more stubborn man never was born.''

``And you should know,'' she responded mockingly. It is true that I have something of a reputation, possibly undeserved, for being stubborn. I prefer to think of myself as not easily discouraged.

``When will I see him then?'' she asked, relieved that he was at least coming, but disappointed at the further wait.

``He will be at the riverside gathering on the Sabbath,'' I replied. ``He says his mission is to all mankind, but that he must work through the established Synagogues unless and until they reject him.''

``Then we shall be there also,'' she replied. ``The man was not born who can gainsay me.''

Probably true. Certainly true in my experience, but then I am just a mere slave in her ownership.

The following two days dragged by.

I had a number of urgent cases to attend to that had been `looked after' in my absence by some local associates, but I'm not sure that I entirely approve of their methods. Either way, the individuals concerned perked up just on seeing me returned from my travels.

Lydia herself was somewhat crotchety and irritable over the two days and kept finding fault with all manner of minor details, many of which did not really concern her. But since she was, in general, such a kind and benevolent owner, most of us simply overlooked the harsh words and minor criticisms and got on with our work as best we could.

Finally the sabbath arrived and those of us going to the prayer-meeting made sure we were ready and in our finest - but nevertheless sober - clothes to attend. It's an interesting thing, but the Jewish rituals call for a strange blend of respect yet quiet demeanour when contemplating God. The brash rituals of the Greek or Roman religious celebrations are nowhere to be seen. I hear it is different at the temple in Jerusalem - where animals are sacrificed and the air is heavy with the smells of incense, but as a non-Jew I would never be allowed closer than the Court of the Gentiles - the outermost court around the Temple precincts. In my experience, as I say, it is a solemn and sober occasion, infused with a great deal of humility and respect.

When we were all ready, we left the main house and proceeded down the streets to the South Gate. The gate was open, of course; bandits only generally attack during the night and there hasn't been a war in this part of the world in my lifetime. You can blame the Romans for a lot that is wrong in the world, but the Pax Romana is a great blessing.

As always, there was a throng of people in the streets. People are always going somewhere for some reason or another. Apart from the Jewish rituals by the riverside, other events were going on - sacrifices at the temples, shows at the theatre, probably some events on at the games field. On top of that, people had all sorts of reasons for being out and about, from eating and drinking to their daily business and social meetings.

The Jews are ritually constrained in their movements on the Sabbath. This day, they say, was set aside by their Lord (and their Law) for rest and contemplation. Among the other constraints, they are not supposed to travel more than `necessary' on the Sabbath, a somewhat vague measure that has, in recent times, come to mean substantially less than a mile. In consequence, many of the Jews live near the South Gate: in order to be close to the place of prayer come the morning.

So, as we came closer to the gate, we saw more and more people headed our way, ready and attired for the prayer meeting. We walked out of the gate and down to the river bank. Three of us spread out the matting and my mistress and her sisters sat on it. We slaves kneeled behind.

When everybody had gathered, one of the elders of the Jewish church stood up and read from their holy books. The readings are, of course, in Hebrew, a language which all of the `real' Jews know but is completely foreign to us. Having said that, most of them seemed to know not just the language but the entire text of their scriptures. Once the reading was complete, the elder sat down again and another began to expound on the theme they had chosen: the time of exile when the followers of God were banished from Judea and had to spend years in Babyonia (now part of the Parthian Empire, far to the East), until they repented of their sins and came back to the bosom of God.

He then introduced Silas, one of Paul's travelling companions, `a Jew of good standing from Jerusalem and Antioch', to read the Second Reading. Silas read from the book of the prophet Ezekiel about the return from exile and the coming of the Kingdom of God.

And then he turned to Paul to expound it.

4. Kerygma

AD 50 Philippi

17 years after the crucifixion

``The coming of the Kingdom of God.

``The dream of the ages. All men will repent and we will come home to God. It has been preached and taught by all the prophets.

``Jeremiah said, `And I will write my law in their inward parts and they shall *all* know me, from the least unto the greatest.'

``But do you? In your inward parts? Do you feel the burning fire of the Holy Spirit as a daily force in your life?

``I am here today to show you that what has previously been nothing more than prophecy and promise is today fully realized in the life, death and resurrection of the promised Messiah.

``Yes, you may gasp and be shocked. You may even cry `blasphemy', but answer me this: Can it really be blasphemy to say that the promises are true? If not now, then when? Can we say that the endtimes have been promised but it is blasphemy to say that they have come? How does that make sense?

``And yet, if the time has come, and the promises are to be fulfilled, who are we to try and dispute that? Who are we to try and oppose the will of God?

``Wait, wait and I will get there. We have all day, good people of Philippi. Surely the news that tells of the arrival of the endtimes is worth giving over a few hours to? Nothing will ever be the same again!

``We have heard inspiring readings this morning. Readings that tell of sin, exile and restoration. Let me tell you more of this: stories of sin cured, of an unwonted death, and of a resurrection! And then see if you do not agree that the Messianic age has dawned.

``There was a preacher, sent from God named John. He went into the whole country round about the Jordan proclaiming baptism as a mark of a complete change of heart and of the forgiveness of sins, as we just heard the prophet Isaiah say - 'The voice of one crying in the wilderness: Prepare the way of the Lord, make his paths straight. Every valley shall be filled, and every mountain and hill brought low; and the crooked places shall be made straight, and the rough ways made smooth; and all flesh shall see the salvation of God'

``And great crowds would come out to be baptised by him, and he would see them and question them as to their integrity. `Who warned you, you serpent's brood, to escape from the wrath to come? See that you do something to show that your hearts are really changed! Don't start thinking that you can say to yourselves, 'We are Abraham's children', for I tell you that God could produce children of Abraham out of mere stones! The axe already lies at the root of the tree, and the tree that fails to produce good fruit is cut down and thrown into the fire.'

``And he preached and prophesied by the River Jordan as did the prophets of old. And some who came truly repented of what they had done, and desisted from their habits, and were baptised and followed a new path.

``And others went away, thinking in their hearts that this was a madman who had fooled even himself into believing that he was a special one.

``And some asked whether he was, in fact, the promised one, the Messiah, the Christ, who should come to purge Israel of her sins and found the Kingdom of God. `No,' he declared, `that is not I; that is one greater than I; but before the day I die, he will be revealed unto you in his glory.'

``And one day came Jesus, a carpenter of Nazareth, to John and asked for baptism. But John, being a prophet and knowing who asked, at first denied him baptism, but later consented that all the prophecies might be fulfilled. For here was a man born without sin.

``Now sin is the great scourge of the age - indeed, of any age. And you here today who know his plan, and are able through your knowledge of the Law truly to appreciate moral values, can, therefore, confidently look upon yourself as a guide to those who do not know the way, and as a light to those who are groping in the dark. You can instruct those who have no spiritual wisdom: you can teach those who, spiritually speaking, are only just out of the cradle. You have a certain grasp of the basis of true knowledge. You have without doubt very great advantages. But, prepared as you are to instruct others, do you ever teach yourself anything? You preach against stealing, for example, but are you sure of your own honesty? You denounce the practice of adultery, but are you sure of your own purity? You loathe idolatry, but how honest are you towards the property of heathen temples?

``Is there any advantage then in being one of the chosen people? Yes, at least to an extent - you have only to think of one thing to begin with - it was the Jews to whom God's messages were entrusted. Some of them were undoubtedly faithless, but what of it? Can you imagine that their faithlessness could disturb the faithfulness of God? Of course not! Let us think of God as true, even if every living man be proved a liar. Remember the scripture? 'That you may be justified in your words, and may overcome when you are judged'.

``So then, if those who know the Law cannot avoid sin, what hope is there for the Emperor Claudius and his harlot who do not know the Law? And so, having sent many prophets to emphasize the Law and to instruct in the Law, he went a step further and sent Jesus, to call all sinners to repentance that in their repentance they might usher in the day of salvation.

``But what happened? In the mortal sphere, it would seem that sin overcame the power of God! This man, a man in whom even the prophet John saw no sin, was taken by the chiefs of the very people he was trying to save and was found guilty of trumped-up charges and handed over to the Romans for execution!

``And not just any execution - the demeaning and horrible crucifixion meted out to rebellious slaves! The very representative of God on earth! How could this be? How could God stand for it?

``A good question, my friends. A very good question. And the simple answer is that God *did* not stand for it. He allowed Jesus to be taken, it is true, and he allowed men to think that they had killed him, true, but after three days he took him and brought him forth from the tomb and showed him to his followers and many others as a sign of the resurrection which is to come at the end of time!

``Indeed, indeed there may be some here who subscribe to the party of the Sadduccees and deny that there is any resurrection in the body. I myself was raised a Pharisee and believe in the resurrection. But this is no longer an open question to be debated! God has offered an infallible proof in the risen Jesus.

``And that can only mean one thing, my friends. If the resurrection has started, we must be in the endtimes! We must now be in the days of which the prophet Jeremiah said, `And I will write my Law in their inward parts and they shall be called my people.'

``Now is the time, my friends, *right now* is the day of salvation! You are called on to believe in the power of God and the sacrifice of his messenger, the Messiah Jesus.

``What does God ask of you, my children? What has he ever asked of you? To love good, and to abstain from evil. To be good, to love your neighbor, to show kindness to all.

``What then has changed? Just this: through this one, immense sacrifice of a man unquestionably good; a man who came to save all of us but was himself killed; through this, I say, the rules of the game have changed overnight.

``Previously, the Law was like a giant scoreboard. You obeyed this law, you disobeyed that one. Sin and goodness were in perpetual warfare. But now God freely pours out his holy spirit on all who will receive it - accept this holy spirit and be free of sin, of temptation, of evil - and of the need to be scrupulous in your every action to make sure it accords with the Law!

``It is not the Law has changed, or been abrogated. How could that be? But rather, that by accepting the spirit of Christ - the spirit of God - you raise yourself up onto a plane where the sin can no longer tempt you and you follow the principles of the Law as unthinkingly as you currently follow the dictates of Sin!

``Now, when you receive baptism - a regular baptism, the baptism that John would offer you - it signifies a change of heart, a desire to move in a different direction. That is what we mean by baptism: washing away the collected sins of the world and making a clean slate.

``But the new baptism - the baptism of Jesus, the baptism I am offering you today - is more than that. The baptism of Jesus is not water on the outside, washing away past sins, but fire on the inside, scourging the sinful members.

``My friends, this is the time prophesied. This is the time to repent and return to God! This time it really is Now or Never! There is so little time left for second chances!

``God will always be the victor.''

5. Lydia

AD 50 Philippi

Thirteen years after the crucifixion

For a while after Paul ceased preaching, there was a stunned quiet.

While he had been in full flow, there had been a bevy of questions, comments and a certain amount of heckling. But as he reached his peroration, the crowd realized that not only was he deadly earnest, but that he might even be right. The enormity of that dented the self-confidence of even the holiest among us - a title I would certainly not have claimed for myself! And that, in turn, caused a gradual hush to settle on the crowd: a hush that was lost in Paul's booming, strident tones while he continued, but then shocked with its depth when he suddenly ceased talking.

After the readings and the speeches, the normal flow of events led to more singing of Psalms, composed by a poet-King of the Jews called David. Eventually, order restored itself, the Psalms were sung and the meeting, formally, came to a close.

Some wandered off, returning to the homes for quiet contemplation for the rest of the Sabbath, but for most of us, such a course of action was unthinkable. I had the advantage of not only having heard Paul preach before, but of having spent the past fortnight in his company. For others, the ideas he preached were not just novel, they were *revolutionary*. And immediate. This was a man who was *literally* saying that the end of days will come in your lifetime and the number of days left to prepare for that is very limited.

Faced with that, you really only have two choices: to dismiss the man as a lunatic or a fraud, or to earnestly consider how to spend every remaining minute of your life.

For myself, I could never have dismissed Paul as a fraud: he was simply too intense, too wrapped up in what he was preaching. I could see him as a lunatic, but as many as I've met in my life - and as a doctor, I see a fair few, most of them incurable - none have been half as lucid either in daily life or in their rantings. No, while he might be a lunatic, he was a different kind of lunatic to any I'd previously met.

And that only really left one possibility: as uncomfortable as it might be, Paul genuinely believed, for very good reasons, that the end of days were near, if not upon us, and that the immediate consequence of a failure to repent and put your life in order would be to be eternally cast outside of God's final plan for the human race: to be the child eternally cast off by their parents.

As in Troas, small groups, mainly men, started to gather around Paul and push and probe with questions: what was the authority for his claims? Had he met this Jesus? Did the Sanhedrin approve his mission? What actual proofs could he offer that he was telling the truth?

Lydia and most of our party waited patiently in our space. The day was sunny and warm, and there was no pressing need to be elsewhere. Some of the workers and slaves excused themselves and went back to get on with their various tasks.

Slowly the sun crept down in the sky until dusk was approaching. Paul dealt with all of his questioners and seemed never to tire of preaching, disputing, philosophizing, helping. Always and ever putting the case that God had offered infallible proof of his love and care, not only by the outstanding act of raising Jesus from the dead, but through the gift of the holy spirit to all those who subsequently believed because of that. That gift, he promised and repeated, was available to any today who would soften their hearts, believe, repent and _hear the gospel - *actually* listen_ to the words God spoke, not in the *hearing* of men but in their *hearts*.

The last of the doubters gone, still disputing in their little groups, Paul came over to our party and greeted me as a fellow-traveller. And then greeted Lydia.

``Good Lady, you must be the Lydia of whom I have heard so much from your devoted servant, Luke. Tell me, how may I be of assistance to you today?''

``You already have,'' she replied, ``merely by being here. We are by the river; what impedes me from being baptised this day?''

``Are you ready, good lady, to take that step with the fulness of your heart and spirit?''

At her affirmative, he continued: ``then nothing, good lady is between you and God. Let us proceed to the river.''

We walked down to the river almost in a procession: Paul, my mistress Lydia, and a group of seven of us slaves who felt the spirit move us to be baptised.

When we reached the river, Paul called us to attention and made it clear that this was no easy step.

``I need to repeat that this is not a simple outward ritual; this is merely a physical sign of the inward renewal in your hearts.

``To go forward from here is a lifetime commitment. Up until this point, you have lived your life as you have chosen and the consequences have been as they have been, but they have been yours alone.

``Jesus died for us; Jesus rose for us; from this day forward, everything you do you do in Christ. By this act of baptism, you are, as it were, born anew: not born in the ordinary generation of men, but born of the spirit, with God as your father and Jesus as your brother. You will all become brothers and sisters in Christ who died for us.

``If any of you are unready for this step, now is the last minute to say so. When you claim the baptism and rebirth that is in Christ, you will no longer be ignorant as other Gentiles are, but you will be adopted into the family of God himself. Think carefully! Is this what you want, or do you wish to back away?''

He paused, and gazed at each of us in turn. I cannot speak for the others, but I felt rent through. I was ready to turn tail and run away; but I had glimpsed in small measure the truth that was on offer here; I had to know more.

In the end, two of my fellow slaves turned and left; not in shame or disgrace, but in recognition that they were not ready. None jeered or rejected them; some were ready, others not.

``If you are ready, then it is time. Remove your outer layers of clothing and step down into the river. Open your heart to receive the blessing that comes from joining the brotherhood of Christ.''

Slowly we undressed and walked along the bank and down into the river. I know from long experience that the waters there are cold even in the height of summer, but on that occasion I did not even notice.

As Paul reached up and poured water over me and said the words of blessing, I felt transformed - just as he had promised. From the pit of my stomach I felt a sensation welling up and overcoming me. The force of it was so strong I nearly fainted right there in the water.

I looked around at the others and they seemed transformed: I nearly didn't recognize any of them! Each of them was glowing as if a lamp had been placed inside them, and on their faces an expression of peace and joy, what I think might be called *rapture*. I knew, right there and then, that I would never be the same again. And that, whatever I did, I could never repay Paul for this priceless gift. But I knew I would never stop trying.

``But I insist.''

After returning to the river bank and dressing, Lydia had continued with her original plan to try and convince Paul to come and live with us. For whatever reasons, he felt that was not what he wanted to do. It had almost become a battle of wills at this point. I don't know how she did it; I felt incapable of anything, just surrendered to the amazing feeling of the rebirth.

Paul continued to insist that he could find work and afford lodging and did not want to be beholden to anybody for anything - except Christ. Feeling as I did, I could understand his desire to not let anything come between him and his mission. But still Lydia persisted.

``I have work; plenty of it. Not all of it is that which a Jew would consider unclean. It would be possible for you to work for me and lodge with me and to pay for your lodging out of the wages I would pay you for your work.

``And you would still be free to do your real work. I would not require you to work on the Sabbath, and you could be here preaching. I, myself, would come and listen and break bread with you.''

Paul sighed.

``You make it impossible for me to refuse, your ladyship. The ability to work for my living and still to keep on the mission on which I know I have been sent is all I can ask. And, as you say, I can lodge with you as easily as anywhere else, especially if I am going to work for you. Just, I pray, give me no special favours or dispensation that you do not give your other workers.''

``That is easily done,'' she replied. ``Let us consider that a bargain struck. And now let us return to my house that we may be ready to start work in the morning.''

``In the morning,'' said Paul, ``early we must break bread in commemaration of the risen Christ, who rose from the dead early on the first day of the week and was seen in the Garden by Mary.''

``Let us break bread early,'' agreed Lydia. ``Those of us that are in the brotherhood. And then let us work God's work willingly until dusk.''

``Agreed,'' said Paul.

And we went home. Just not the same people that had left in the morning.

6. Paul at Work

AD 50 Philippi

17 years after the crucifixion.

Paul was a hard worker.

Extracting true purple dye is a tricky business involving shellfish. It is not only tricky, it is slow, expensive and requires an enormous amount of shells to extract a small amount of dye. At Tyre, which has been the centre of the industry for as long as anyone can remember, the harbour and sea front are covered in the stinking, discarded shells of the used mollucs.

As a consequence of the expense and rarity of genuine purple dye, it was the almost exclusive province of kings, emperors and roman senators.

We did not make genuine purple dye, but a similar colour for those with exotic tastes - and merely a great deal of money.

The process we used depended on extracting a range of dyes from plants through crushing, then a chemical extraction involving urine. The resulting gloop was then passed through some filters and heated until a purple substance emerged.

Most of these steps would be considered unclean by a Jew.

Paul preached the risen Christ who forgave sins and made all who accepted him into their hearts as above those who merely obeyed the law. But for Paul himself, he insisted on following the Law scrupulously and could not engage in `unclean' practices. His one exception was that while Jews would not, in general, associate with or eat with Gentiles, Paul observed that God had shown him that there were not really Jews and Gentiles, but only children of God; brothers and sisters in Christ.

But for every step in our process that involves handling unclean materials, there are many supporting steps that do not. Paul could have worked selling the dye, or working the logistics that moved it from our factory to the four corners of the empire. Personally, I think he would have been good at either of those.

But he preferred what he called "honest work": something that you did with your hands and you could stand back and admire at the end of the day. So he cast amphorae. Not big amphorae, since our quantities were small. All morning long, he would sit at the potter's wheel, turning out elegant pots, then put them in the oven to fire them, then spend the afternoons decorating them and firing them again. Although the pot would be discarded once used, he felt that the vessel was the container that held the precious product and should be just as precious.

And while he worked he preached.

I did not work alongside Paul in the main. My duties as a doctor tended to take me all over the factory and estates, and often to our neighbours who were in need of medical assistance. But whenever the chance presented itself - if somebody in the factory needed help, or I just had a little time to myself - I would go down to where Paul worked, just to watch him and to listen to him.

``This pot,'' he was saying one time when I visited, ``can be used as a metaphor for the body. That which is truly valuable is what is on the inside - the soul. But the body, for as long as it lasts, for as long as it is needed to hold the soul, is valuable too.

``It must be taken care of, and should be as elegant and beautiful as possible. It should not be abused, or taken advantage of, just because it is not the soul, any more than the pot should be chipped just because it is not the dye.

``What then, if your soul has been saved through your knowledge of Christ? Shall you then abuse your body because your soul is safe? Surely not! Imagine if you were to chip away at this vessel with abandon. Could it not spring a leak? What then? The dye would escape and there would be nothing left.

``And so it is with the body and soul. What good if your soul is `saved', if it is allowed to leech away through the depravity of your body?

``It is not enough to say to yourself, `I do good when I can', but rather you need to live a wholesome life at all times.

``Listen to these words of Jesus which he spoke in the hills of Galilee:

``Love your enemies, do good to those who hate you, bless those who curse you, and pray for those who treat you badly.

``As for the man who hits you on one cheek, offer him the other one as well!

``And if a man is taking away your coat, do not stop him from taking your shirt as well. Give to everyone who asks you, and when a man has taken what belongs to you, don't demand it back.

``Treat men exactly as you would like them to treat you.

``If you love only those who love you, what credit is that to you? Even sinners love those who love them! And if you do good only to those who do good to you, what credit is that to you? Even sinners do that, and if you lend only to those from whom you hope to get your money back, what credit is that to you? Even sinners lend to sinners and expect to get their money back. No, you are to love your enemies and do good and lend without hope of return. Your reward will be wonderful and you will be sons of the most high. For he is kind to the ungrateful and the wicked!

``You must be merciful, as your father in Heaven is merciful.

``Don't judge other people and you will not be judged yourselves. Don't condemn and you will not be condemned. Make allowances for others and people will make allowances for you. Give and men will give to you - yes, good measure, pressed down, shaken together and running over will they pour into your lap. For whatever measure you use with other people, they will use in their dealings with you.''

``Paul,'' I said when he reached the end of this recitation, ``Lydia would like to see you when you have a convenient moment.''

``Do you know what it is that she wants?'' he asked.

``She wants to talk about the shipment of dye to the fullers' at Brindisi,'' I replied.

``And why are you the messenger,'' he asked.

``I'd hoped that we might be able to talk a little as we walked there.''

Paul tidied up his work fastidiously and made sure everything was ready for his return and that nothing would spoil in his absence. He looked at me watching him.

``Good measure, pressed down and shaken together,'' he said. ``Not just words, Luke, not just words but a philosophy for life.''

``Was Jesus a philosopher?'' I asked, only half seriously.

``What is a philosopher?'' Paul countered. ``I never met the man myself, but many of the things he said would have graced the lips of a Socrates, an Aristotle or a Seneca, don't you think? ``Just simpler and easier to understand.''

``Let us go to see the Lady,'' he said and started walking. ``What were you hoping to talk about?''

``I feel a burning need to do more,'' I confessed. ``Ever since my baptism, I feel a tearing hurry to be about God's work. This life - the only life I've ever really known - seems bland and - colourless, I suppose. Does that make sense?''

``I, too, feel a burning need to be about God's work,'' he replied. ``But is that not what I am doing here? I am bringing the word to the people of Philippi.''

``I don't know,'' I said. ``It seems so slow, so, *piecemeal*. I realize you're preaching as you work, but few people come by and hear it. And the preaching on the sabbath reaches so very few and they largely seem unwilling to listen to you.''

``I know; it is much the same everywhere I go. Small groups grow up - as with you here - around the core of the preaching and a few individuals - as you yourself - are infused with the Holy Spirit and can keep up the ministry when I am gone, but the majority of the Jews find the message that the Christ - for whom they have waited oh, these many years - has come to be unappealing. And, truly, I do understand, for once I was the same.''

True enough; his ardent espousal of the cause frequently caused me to forget his early days as an equally ardent opponent of the Way, but when he made comments like this, the whole story of his persecution of the Christians and his conversion in Damascus came flooding back. *Of course* he would relate to the Jews who opposed him: his former self had been one of them.

``So will you move on?''

``When the time comes, the Spirit will move me on,'' he replied, cryptically. ``We cannot know the times or the seasons, but God knows, and he will direct our paths.''

``Can I come with you?''

``Only time will tell, Luke. It is not for me to say, not least because you belong to another. Silas, along with Timothy and the others will come with me, so it is probably better that your place is here as one of the leaders of this community.''

We walked around the corner and up a short flight of steps into the main house building. We continued in silence around the colonnade to the atrium where Lydia would be waiting. As we parted, I made a final comment.

``I sense there is a better way.''

Paul looked at me, intently and inquisitively.

``A better way of spreading God's word than to go to people, meet them, share the gospel and demonstrate through your own life's actions the power of the word?''

Put like that, it was hard to come back to the point that I had been trying to make. But I was just about up to the task. I may only be a doctor, not an orator, but I like to think I have always had a way with words.

``Not necessarily better in that sense, but ... more efficient. A way of reaching more people in less time. And time, I feel, is of the essence.''

``I feel that too,'' he concurred. ``If you think of anything, let me know. But in the meantime, I must meet with the mistress of the house.''

7. Breaking Bread

AD 51 Philippi

18 years after the crucifixion

Paul looked up to heaven before he broke the bread.

Friday nights were `feast nights' in the Way. All who were members of the Way in any given locality would meet at a house of one of the members - here in Philippi that was always at Lydia's, which was certainly convenient for me. All the members would bring what food they had and would share among all equally. In Jerusalem, Paul said, many members of the Way lived holding everything in common, caring only about spreading the Word.

Here in Philippi we maintained our individual wealth, in Lydia's case quite great; mine less so. But when we came together on Friday nights, the rigid social caste of the week was left behind and we were all brothers and sisters in Christ.

``Remember,'' intoned Paul, ``the words of our master before he was crucified, when he ate the last meal with his students in Jerusalem.

``Those of you who have memorized these sayings, say it with me.

``Jesus said to them, `With all my heart I have longed to eat this Passover with you before the time comes for me to suffer. Believe me, I shall not eat the Passover again until all that it means is fulfilled in the kingdom of God.'

``Then taking a cup from them he thanked God, and said, `Take this and share it amongst yourselves, for I tell you I shall drink no more wine until the kingdom of God comes.'

``Then he took a loaf and thanked God.

``Then he broke it and gave it to them, with these words, `This is my body which is given for you: do this in remembrance of me.'

``So too, he gave them a cup after supper with the words, `This cup is the new agreement made in my own blood which is shed for you.' ''

Paul paused and looked around. ``This bread,'' he said, ``is broken as the Lord's body was broken. This wine is split as his blood was spilt. But as you eat and drink, think not of daily sustenance but of the spiritual sustenance for which he gave his life.

``The new agreement was made in his blood. He died for us, and he rose for us, that we might, through his atonement for our sins, be reborn in him to a new life, to a life eternal and glorious, one with the angels.''

And he was off. Another one of Paul's impassioned, beautiful, vigorous proclamations of the coming of the Kingdom of God was underway. And it was impossible to sit back and listen; I was completely gripped and wrapped up in the experience.

One advantage of many of having the meeting in "our" house was that it was not far after the meeting broke up that we had to go to get to bed. For Paul, of course, it was a long time before he could shed his crowd of admirers, questioners, interlocutors.

But eventually we moved away. I didn't always wait for him; he was perfectly capable of making it back to his own room. But on this occasion, I had seen *it* very clearly, while he was in the middle of one of his stories about Jesus.

``I've figured it out,'' I told him excitedly when we were finally alone.

``Figured what out?'' he asked.

``How we can spread the word more quickly; more efficiently,'' I replied.

He looked at me blankly. For me, this had been a pressing need ever since my baptism. Clearly, for him, the idea of spreading the word more efficiently had been blown to the back of his mind and forgotten there.

``It came to me when you were telling that story about the son who ran away and then came back,'' I began. He nodded, remembering the story only too well - one he had probably told countless times.

``Stories like that really make the coming of the Kingdom apparent. You don't want to be caught in the far-flung deserts of depraved living when the King arrives, do you? We could publish a scroll of stories, the Jesus-stories, along with some of his other sayings and doings, and send copies around the empire.''

``To whom would you send them?'' he asked. ``You see the opposition I receive from Jews who could hear those stories and believe. To Gentiles, they would be just that - stories. Why would a Gentile listen to a story like that and think that God was real? It would mean nothing to them unless, like you, that had had an encounter with the Spirit of God.''

I felt a little deflated. I had felt I was so right; no, I knew deep in my bones that I was right. But his logic was unanswerable: who would pay attention?

``Do your communities in Asia have them?'' I asked. ``We have heard many of your sayings, and some we have learnt, but we do not have all of them. Maybe I should at least write them all down so that we will have a copy of them all when you leave us.''

``I am not sure that it is possible to collect all of them,'' he replied, ``but I cannot stop you writing the words of God if that is your pleasure. And if it is your mistress' pleasure to give you the time to do so.''

``I'm sure that will not be a problem,'' I countered, knowing well that nothing would give her greater pleasure than to be able to help with the work. But I knew I would have to talk to her.

``What would the purpose be?'' she asked earnestly when I raised the idea with her the following week.

``I have two ideas in view,'' I replied. ``In the first instance, I feel sure that Paul will not be with us much longer. When he leaves, we will be left without a source of inspiration, a teacher or a guide. What will we do?

``And secondly, if there were such a scroll, we could publish it and share it with other communities. Initially, communities in Christ, but later we could share it with other communities - communities that have not yet heard the Word.''

``A scroll to keep the words of the preacher alive,'' she mused. ``Much as the Jews already keep the words of their Law and the words of the prophets.''

``Exactly,'' I agreed. ``But these would be the living words and stories from God's appointed redeemer. Told with the vision and passion that Paul brings to them.''

``How would you go about it?'' she asked and my heart leapt! For her to ask this question, I knew she had agreed in her heart and it was just a question of making it happen. I tried to leash my excitement but failed.

``Many of the stories I have heard. I can start with those and write them down in my own time. Then I can spend time with Paul as he works and listen to more stories. And commit those to paper too. And, in the fulness of time, try and put some structure to it.''

``You mean put in one of those flowery introductions so popular in Greek prose? `To Governor Felix, who made this possible by not randomly executing me because I didn't bribe him enough'?''

I smiled. Her turn of phrase was ever amusing. Not to mention her sense of the ridiculous.

``No,'' I replied sweetly; and then inspiration struck. ``I would dedicate it to you, of course. You are the one who would make it possible.''

``To a woman?'' she mocked. ``That would not be seemly, Luke. Better to dedicate it to a slave.''

``We could use an alias,'' I improvised quickly. You and I would both know who was meant, but the forms would be observed.''

``Lydius?'' she smiled, still mocking me.

``Maybe something more about your position, in the scheme of things,'' I suggested. ``A sponsor, an interested party, a lover of new things.''

``Or a lover of Godly things,'' she countered. ``Theophilus - it has a certain ring to it.''

``And it constrasts nicely with how the Jews see us, as God *fearers*,'' I added.

``O Theophilus,'' she declaimed, ``on account of your great beauty and interest in things spiritual, I dedicate to you this work on the life and sayings of Jesus, known as the Christ, come to save the world?''

``Something like that,'' I said. ``But that is for the future. The most important thing is to capture the words of Paul while he is with us.''

``I sense you feel that will not be long,'' she inferred.

``I sense that he senses it,'' I replied. ``I don't know, but it feels like a few months at most.''

In fact, it was less than two weeks, and I had hardly started to gather stories from him in that time.

8. Arrest

AD 51 Philippi

18 years after the crucifixion

The girl cried out: "These men are servants of the most high God, and they are telling you the way of salvation."

This wasn't the first time this had happened. And it was starting to become a little irritating, even if I had to acknowledge that it was true.

Paul generally did a good job of ignoring this sort of thing. I think he was used to it from his previous travels and, moreover, I think he suspected that she was something of a fraud: that she had, in short, been paid to say this by our detractors in the city.

It was the Sabbath, and we were on our way to the riverside when Paul finally snapped. She was walking behind us with her minders, and calling out her usual refrain, when one of the members of the crowd around us addressed her.

``Are you truly able to see into the other realm?'' he asked her.

Paul turned as if burnt.

``Of course she isn't,'' he snapped. ``It's simply the spirit of the devil in her trying to prey on the minds of the simple and wayward to draw them away from the true path of holiness.''

``If that's so,'' countered the man, ``and you are the followers of Jesus, who was known for casting out these kinds, why don't you do something about it?''

I could see the leashed expression on Paul's face. He wanted to retort, but knew that arguments like this could not be easily won. Instead he turned to the girl.

``Do you wish to be cured?'' he asked her gently.

She looked up at him, a strange expression on her face, almost curious, as if underneath the confident exterior expressed by the evil spirit the girl's true spirit shyly looked out at him. She smiled ever so slightly and thinly.

Paul observed her for a few moments more.

``In that case,'' he said, talking to her, or possibly beyond her, ``if the girl has spoken, you must obey. I command you in the name of Jesus who is Christ to come out of her!''

The girl's face contorted momentarily and then relaxed. Where before the girl's expression had generally been harsh and contemptuous, it now returned to the lines you would expect of a little girl. Her masters would take no more advantage of her.

At the riverside, our weekly prayer meeting was in full swing.

Silas had read the opening readings and Paul was expounding the scriptures in his own inimitable fashion. He assured me that the Jews of Philippi were relatively tolerant to allow him to keep preaching so long: in most places he had been in Asia by now he would have been excluded from the synagogue.

It was probably helped by the ever-growing number of converts he had recruited over the weeks. A significant number of the Jews in the audience - and just as many Gentiles - had become part of the `Paul party' and staunchly defended him against the attacks of `the traditionalists'. But it was not clear how much longer this would be able to continue.

Paul was in the middle of describing the acts of Jesus - and I was listening carefully in order to later commit his words to paper exactly as he recited them - when a group of armed men approached from the town.

``Silence!'' the centurion in front shouted. ``We have warrants here for the arrest of Saul of Tarsus, commonly called Paul, ahd his associate Silas of Antioch. Where are they?''

As I looked at them I saw that one of the prophet-girl's handlers was with them and, with a sinking heart, I knew what had happened. Disappointed at their inability to gain from the poor girl's suffering, they had decided their only course of action was to have Paul arrested and then to try and extort money from him through the courts or the notoriously corrupt provincial justice system.

Paul stood up at once, and walked towards them. Silas copied his example, stood and followed him to where the soldiers were standing. Unused to this - most miscreants tended to run when faced with arrest - the centurion looked at him uncertainly.

``You are Paul?''

``I am. And this is my associate, Silas of Antioch,'' he replied with more than a touch of mockery. ``And you are arresting us for the crime of healing a girl sick with an evil spirit, acting in accord with your corrupt lusts.'' This last being directed at the girl's handler. ``I pray that your eyes may be opened to the truth before it is too late. Shall we go?''

If the centurion was surprised before, he was astounded now. Paul seemed to *want* to be arrested and taken to jail. Did he truly not know what awaited him there?

As if able to read his thoughts - and possibly he was; almost nothing surprised me about Paul any more - Paul answered him aloud.

``Of course I know what the inside of a Roman jail looks like. Every few months some malcontent or another arranges for me to be incarcerated out of petty spite or jealousy. The capacity for human lust for power has long since ceased to surprise me.

``But what is surprising is the outcome I foresee. For I will suffer but transiently, but in the morning - you will be a new man.''

``What do you mean by that?'' retorted the centurion. ``Are you threatening me?''

``I carry none of the world's weapons,'' replied Paul softly but firmly and raising his arms wide to show he was unarmed. ``But there is a power that exceeeds anything you or I are capable of. When you see that power, you will yield to it, as I had to, for there really is no choice. A blind man may not see the light, but once cured of his blindness, can he really go back?''

The centurion realized he was losing this metaphysical battle and dragged Paul and Silas off to jail.

The riverside meeting broke up shortly after.

Some of us - our party, obviously, but many of the other converts as well as many of those who had not been converted - were distressed by the morning's events and wanted to leave quickly to find out what had become of Paul and Silas.

Others were merely aggravated by having had their meeting disrupted but felt, more or less openly, that Paul had had it coming by his insistent manner of teaching and harping on about the resurrection and the coming days. Indeed, some openly admitted that had he not been reported to the authorities by somebody else, they might well have done it themselves.

We walked back to the city hurriedly, and Lydia dispatched one of the slaves to find out what had happened to Paul and Silas while the rest of us returned to the house to plan our next move.

The slave reported soon afterwards. It had been fairly easy to track Paul an Silas' whereabouts: they had been taken to the jail in the square and confined to custody there until such time as the city's duumvirs could hear their case, probably in two days' time.

In the meantime, we had figured a plan for this, the most likely eventuality. We would gather together lamps and food and go and camp out in the city square by the jail, both to show solidarity with Paul and to be in contact with him.

The nature of the jail was such that, while completely secure, its outer walls fronted onto the main square. The windows, placed high up in the walls, were barred to prevent entrance or exit, and the heavily studded gates were barred from the inside.

By camping outside, we would be able to communicate with Paul, albeit only if we or he were to shout and provided there was no background noise.

The moment the slave had finished his report, Lydia rattled off her orders. She, herself, was going to go and find the duumvirs and see if she could explain the situation and head off any possible trouble and meet us there later.

We all went about our appointed tasks.

In the meantime, Paul would have to look after himself.

9. Kerygma in Prison

AD 51 Philippi

18 years after the crucifixion

``Who dares to accuse us, when God has already chosen us to be his messengers? The judge of all the world has himself declared us free from sin.

``Who then dares to set himself up in a position to condemn? Only Christ could even think to do that, but it was Christ himself who died for us, the very Christ who rose for us, and since Christ reigns in power for us, Christ prays for us!

``Who are these mere men who thus think they can come between us and the work to which we have been appointed?

``I ask you, my friends, is it possible that anything can come between us and the love of Christ? Can trouble, pain or persecution? Can lack of clothes and food, danger to life and limb, the threat of force of arms?

``No, my friends, it is not possible. We should every day that in all these things we win an overwhelming victory through Christ who has proved his love for us through his death and resurrection.

``And I am absolutely convinced that neither death nor life, no angels or demons, not the emperor himself, the events of today or tomorrow, nor anything else you could possibly name has the power to separate us from the love of God in Jesus Christ our Lord!

``How could it be otherwise, my friends? Consider, if you will, a world in which God was not the most powerful being. How would that even work? If the emperor could tell God, the God who made the world and everything in it, what to do? How would that make sense? Surely the world would come to an end!

``But, you say, here we are, the elect of God, locked up in a Roman Prison! Is God treating us unjustly?

``Never! God said long ago to Moses: 'I will have mercy on whomever I will have mercy, and I will have compassion on whomever I will have compassion'.

``It is obviously not a question of human will or human effort, but of divine mercy. The scripture says to Pharaoh: 'Even for this same purpose I have raised you up, that I might show my power in you, and that my name shall be declared in all the earth' .

``It seems plain, then, that God chooses on whom he will have mercy, and whom he will harden in their sin.

``You may retort: "If this is so, and God's will is irresistible, why does God blame men for what they do?" But the question really is this: "Who are you, a man, to make any such reply to God?" When a craftsman makes anything he doesn't expect it to turn round and say, 'Why did you make me like this?'

``The potter, for instance, is always assumed to have complete control over the clay, making with one part of the lump a lovely vase, and with another a pipe for sewage. Can we not assume that God has the same control over human clay? May it not be that God, though he must sooner or later expose his wrath against sin and show his controlling hand, has yet most patiently endured the presence in his world of things that cry out to be destroyed? Can we not see, in this, his purpose in demonstrating the boundless resources of his glory upon those whom he considers fit to receive his mercy, and whom he long ago planned to raise to glorious life? And by these chosen people I mean you and me, whom he has called out from both Jews and Gentiles. He says in Hosea: 'I will call them my people, who were not my people, and her beloved, who was not beloved'. 'And it shall come to pass in the place where it was said to them, You are not my people, there they will be called sons of the living God'.

``And Isaiah, speaking about Israel, proclaims: 'though the number of the children of Israel be as the sand of the sea, the remnant will be saved. For he will finish the work and cut it short in righteousness, because the Lord will make a short work upon the earth'.

``Let us have no imitation Christian love. Let us have a genuine break with evil and a real devotion to good.

``Let us have real warm affection for one another as between brothers, and a willingness to let the other man have the credit.

``Let us not allow slackness to spoil our work and let us keep the fires of the spirit burning, as we do our work for God.

``Base your happiness on your hope in Christ. When trials come endure them patiently, steadfastly maintain the habit of prayer.

``Give freely to fellow-Christians in want, never grudging a meal or a bed to those who need them ... as for those who try to make your life a misery, bless them. Don't curse, bless.

``Share the happiness of those who are happy, the sorrow of those who are sad.

``And remember, never take vengeance into your own hands, my dear friends: stand back and let God punish if he will. For it is written: 'Vengeance is mine. I will repay'.

``These are God's words: 'Therefore if your enemy hungers, feed him; if he thirsts, give him a drink; for in so doing you will heap coals of fire on his head'. Don't allow yourself to be overpowered with evil. Take the offensive - overpower evil by good!

``And remember, that God always answers our earnest prayers, often even before we ask. So let us now give thanks unto the Lord most high, eternal in the heavens who will bring our deliverance this very evening.

``My brothers, let us sing from the Psalms ..."

10. Deliverance

AD 51 Philippi

14 years after the crucifixion

Paul's faith was unquenchable.

He kept at it, preaching the word of God in the prison all day long and throughout the first two watches of the night. We joined in with singing the Psalms when we knew them, especially the Psalm of the Shepherd, which seemed appropriate for this occasion, with its reference to walking within the very shadow of death.

Around midnight, when Paul was once more giving thanks for the deliverance he knew - or at least sincerely seemed to believe - was coming that night, the ground started to shake. At first gently, then with increasing force, a violent earthquake hit Philippi.

But unlike most such earthquakes, very little damage was done to most of the buildings: most, but not the prison.

With one almighty bang, the gates swung loose from their hinges and a great shout went up from within as the prisoners chains fell from the walls. Amazingly, they were all free to leave!

Outside, we were trembling with fear at the onset of the earthquake. An earthquake strong enough to topple the prison doors would surely knock over statues, bring down buildings and generally cause the kind of destruction that could put those of us out in the town square at risk of life and limb.

But Paul remained calm.

``Do not leave,'' we could hear him instructing the other prisoners. ``Although God has sent the earthquake to release us, it is simply a sign that we are not to be held responsible for the crimes of which we are accused. Let us wait here and await the magistrates, who will surely release us.''

The centurion had been in the barracks when the earthquake began and, being woken up by the violent shaking rushed out into the square and across to the prison, two other guards in his wake. I'm not quite sure what he expected to find when he arrived - the guards were still on duty inside the prison, although I suppose they could have been incapacitated.

But he certainly didn't expect Paul to be sitting there calmly and smugly with an `I told you so' look on his face.

``How, how ... how is this possible?'' the jailer asked.

``It is no secret,'' said Paul, ``and it is this very thing which I have been preaching openly - never in secret! - and for which I find myself here in jail. God the creator of the world, and all that is in it, does not accept the rush to judgment which has been made here in which innocent men have been thrown in jail.

``We have been delivered by the power of God, the power that underlies all the `powers that be' in the world. Indeed, your very authority comes from the ultimate authority of God, and you cannot gainsay him.

``When you choose to act against the will of God, you will always find, as you do today, that God's judgment will overturn the lesser judgment of men and cause them to seem foolish. For the wisdom of this world is indeed foolishness in God's eyes.''

The centurion looked at him aghast. Did this man really have the kind of power he claimed? The power to cause earthquakes and destroy the prison of Philippi?

``No, no,'' corrected Paul. ``I am not claiming any powers for myself. I am not a Wizard or Mage or suchlike. I am merely doing God's will, and it is God's will that I should be prevented from preaching the coming Kingdom of God on earth. When you stand in the way of that, bad things will happen.

``But never fear, the earthquake has passed and will not return. None will lose their lives in Philippi tonight.''

``You must come away from here,'' the Centurion commanded. ``Come to my house and my wife will bathe your wounds. I would like to hear more of this God you preach.''

``I have been preaching him openly this last half-day,'' said Paul. ``Were you not listening?''

``No,'' said the centurion. ``Loud as the noise you were making was, I tried very hard not to listen. I thought you were just trying to rile me.''

``Well,'' said Paul, ``fortunately I never tire of telling people of the coming Kingdom of God. Let us repair to your house and see what can be done by way of a meal, and I will open the gospel for you.''

``What then stands in the way of my baptism?''

Paul and his party had all been fed, and Lydia and I had been allowed to join them. The rest of our group had returned to their houses singing praises to the Lord of Heaven. Paul had not ceased in preaching the risen Christ and his deliverance from all sins.

Day was now very nearly breaking, and the Centurion and his family had been converted. As the Centurion himself realized, only the formalities remained.

``Nothing,'' replied Paul. ``When I am free to leave, we can go to the river and you will be baptised.''

``You are free to leave,'' responded the Centurion. ``Apart from anything else, it is clear that no prison walls will hold you.''

``I am not going to run away!'' replied Paul haughtily. ``I was arraigned through due process and I will be discharged through due process. Nothing less that a complete exoneration by the city's duumvirs will be acceptable!''

``But they were not to hear your case until tomorrow,'' replied the Centurion. ``How can I keep you until then if you are not guility?''

``I suggest that you summon them at once to their tribunal,'' said Paul. ``They cannot be ignorant of all that has passed in the night, and I'm sure that their sleep was disturbed. If for no better reason that an unfounded fear that further disturbances might plague their city, they should want a rapid resolution to this situation.''

The Centurion saw the logic of that at once and send one of his servants to go to the magistrates and tell them what had happened and ask for their advice.

Within minutes, the servant returned.

``They say the prisoners are free to go.''

The Centurion was pleased and beamed at Paul. ``All settled,'' he said. ``You and your colleagues are free to go. I will come with you as far as the river.''

``Not so fast,'' contradicted Paul. ``My arrest was open and public, in front of many witnesses of unimpeachable standing. My release needs to be just as formal. I insist on a hearing, in the public square, and for all the charges to be officially dropped.''

``You can't just tell the city magistrates what to do,'' complained the Centurion. ``They are as likely to throw you back in prison for impudence!''

``They are welcome to do so,'' countered Paul. ``They tried it once and it did them no good at all. You yourself observed that the prison itself will not hold us. No. The situation is very clear. The authority which the duumvirs have is entrusted to them from above, and they have been clearly told that this miscarriage of justice will *not* be tolerated. They will formally acquit me.''

The square was crowded.

Word had spread through the city of Paul's stand on his integrity; and not a single person had not felt the earthquake during the night. All who could manage to escape their daily activity had gathered in the square to see how the magistrates would deal with this unprecedented situation.

They had first gone to examine the damaged prison and assess how much effort it would take to repair. Then they had walked to their tribunal and summoned the Centurion and, when he appeared, told him to bring the prisoners.

Paul and Silas arrived in front of them, heads held high.

``You are brought here on a charge of disturbing the peace,'' the senior duumvir intoned. ``And yet, when we lock you up in prison, you choose to destroy it.''

``I am not careful in speaking to you,'' interrupted Paul. ``For I fear neither man nor spirit. It was not I who caused the earthquake, but God himself. And against him, your so-called justice cannot stand.''

The magistrates eyed him wearily. The people had seen a miracle, and this convinced them that these men were in the right. But the magistrates knew that he *was* a troublemaker, and that the last thing the Romans wanted was men in authority who could not manage to keep the peace. It was beyond them to do anything in the current situation except figure out a compromise and moved these men on to some other town where they could cause their trouble and heartache to another magistrate.

``Even so,'' he declaimed slowly, ``the fact remains that you have disturbed the peace, and in these times that can carry quite severe penalties. It has been made clear to us that however noble your intentions may be, and it certainly seems to us that you are only acting from the best of motives and with a genuine desire and regard for the well-being of our citizens, your presence here is a lodestone for trouble.

``We observe that none of your party are citizens of Philippi - although you have clearly gained some followers in your time here who *are* noble citizens - and thus we feel the most appropriate course of action is to release you and ask you to leave our fair city. We are told that you are somewhat itinerant, so in other words, maybe this is just your god nudging you to move on, eh?''

``If God wills that I should move on,'' replied Paul stiffly, ``then move on I shall. By midnight I will be gone from among your dwellings, but the grace of God will remain in your presence by the will of those whose hearts are open.''

``The prisoners are released, under penalty of being exiled from the city. If they are found within the city walls after daybreak tomorrow, they will be considered outlaw.''

The baptism at the riverside felt sombre.

The Centurion and his family went into the river and emerged rejuvenated and filled with the Holy Spirit. Like so many of the rest of us, he asked Paul if he could share in his travels and leave with him, but Paul denied him - as he had me - on the grounds that the branch of the Way in Philippi was still young and needed all the nurturing and assistance that was to be had.

Lydia and I waited on the riverbank, knowing that we would probably never see Paul again. In spite of the gifts that he had brought - and was leaving with - us, the world would seem less bright without his personal presence.

The sun was moving down in the sky by the time all the rituals were over and Paul came back to us. He looked at us as if unclear as to why we were waiting there, but apart from anything else, a baptism is always a beautiful and moving experience.

``I do need to keep moving,'' he said. ``This is but one small corner of Europe, and I have much to do. Thessalonica is just down the road, then Athens, Piraeus and the stews of Corinth! Then moving on up to Delphi and across to Italy: Syracuse, Naples and Rome!''

``Beware of Rome,'' said Lydia with a shudder. ``I sense that no good will come to you there.''

``I have heard of other members of the way visiting Rome already,'' said Paul. ``It is said that Claudius is relatively open to Jews and was friends with that snake Herod. But in any case, it will be a few years before I make it there; and even that is only a stepping stone on the way to Spain and the Gauls.''

``And Britain?'' I joked. None of us really had much of an idea what was there, but it had been a half-dozen years before that Claudius - with great fanfare - had announced his conquest of the island. A conquest that, we heard, had subsequently become bogged down in minor scuffles against painted tribesmen. Paul's mixture of Hebrew myths and speculative philosophy would probably not go down well there.

``Why not?'' retorted Paul. ``The end days are coming! Should the painted Britons not also be allowed to partake in the general salvation at the end days?''

``Prepare to close the gates.''

A few hours later, as dusk was settling, we were by the South Gate again. Paul, Silas, Timothy and the rest had just left, carrying their few possessions with them. We had remained by the gate, watching until they were moving out of sight over the hill.

And now the guards were sealing the city as they did every night; locking out the brigands and marauders who were not enough to literally threaten the town, but who could do mischief if allowed inside overnight.

The gates closed and banged, and darkness fell.

We walked back home.

11. Kerygma in Troas

AD56 Troas

23 years after the crucifixion

``Now, my brothers, I want to remind you of the Gospel which I have previously preached to you, which you accepted, in which you are at present standing, and by which, if you remain faithful to the message I have given you, your salvation is being worked out - unless, of course, your faith has no meaning behind it at all.

``For I passed on to you first and foremost the message I had myself received - that Christ died for our sins, as the scriptures said he would; that he was buried and rose again on the third day, again as the scriptures foretold. He was seen by Peter, then by the twelve, and subsequently he was seen simultaneously by over five hundred brothers, of whom the majority are still alive, though some have since died. He was then seen by James, then by all the messengers. And last of all, as if to one born abnormally late, he appeared to me!

``Now, it may be the case that I am the least of the messengers, and indeed I do not deserve that title at all, because I once persecuted the followers of God. But what I am now I am by the grace of God. The grace he gave me has not proved a barren gift. Yes, yes, you may say that I have worked harder than any of the others - but then was that really me or just this same grace of God within me? In any event, whichever person may have done the work, this has been the message and this has been the foundation of your faith.

``Now if the rising of Christ from the dead is the very heart of our message, why has it come to my ears that some of you deny that there is any resurrection? For if there is no such thing as the resurrection of the dead, then Christ was never raised. And if Christ was not raised then neither our preaching nor your faith has any meaning at all. Further it would mean that we are lying in our witness for God, for we have given our solemn testimony that he did raise up Christ - and that is utterly false if it should be true that the dead do not, in fact, rise again! For if the dead do not rise neither did Christ rise, and if Christ did not rise our faith is futile and our sins have never been forgiven. Moreover those who have died believing in Christ are utterly dead and gone. Truly, if our hope in Christ were limited to this life only we should, of all mankind be the most to be pitied!

``But the glorious fact is that Christ did rise from the dead: he has become the very first to rise of all who sleep the sleep of death. As death entered the world through a man, so has rising from the dead come to us through a man! As members of a sinful race all men die; as members of the Christ of God all men shall be raised to life, each in his proper order, with Christ the very first and after him all who belong to him when he comes.

``Then, and not till then, authority and power, hands over the kingdom to God the Father. Christ's reign will and must continue until every enemy has been conquered. The last enemy of all to be destroyed is death itself. The scripture says: 'He has put all things under his feet'.

``Nevertheless, when everything created has been made obedient to God, then shall the Son acknowledge himself subject to God the Father, who gave the Son power over all things. Thus, in the end, shall God be wholly and absolutely God.

``Further, and you should consider this very carefully, that if there is to be no resurrection what is the point of all this? Why should I live a life of such hourly danger? I assure you, by the certainty of Jesus Christ that we possess, that I face death every day of my life! And if, to use the popular expression, I have "fought with wild beasts" over the past year, what is the good of an ordeal like that if there is no life after this one? 'Let us eat and drink, for tomorrow we die!'

``Don't be taken in! Remember that while there may be men who have plenty to say, that doesn't mean they have any knowledge of God! And you ask, "How is the resurrection achieved? With what sort of body do the dead arrive?" This is what I mean when I say you are talking but not using your minds! In your own experience you know that a seed does not germinate without itself "dying". When you sow a seed you do not sow the "body" that will eventually be produced, but bare grain, of wheat, for example, or one of the other seeds. God gives the seed a "body" according to his laws - a different "body" to each kind of seed.

``So there are bodies which exist in this world, and bodies which exist in heaven. These bodies are not, as it were, in competition; the splendour of an earthly body is quite a different thing from the splendour of a heavenly body. The sun, the moon and the stars all have their own particular splendour, while among the stars themselves there are different kinds of splendour.

``These are illustrations here of the raising of the dead. The body is "sown" in corruption; it is raised beyond the reach of corruption. It is "sown" in dishonour; it is raised in splendour. It is sown in weakness; it is raised in power. It is sown a natural body; it is raised a spiritual body. As there is a natural body so will there be a spiritual body.

``Trust me, brothers, it is utterly impossible for flesh and blood to possess the kingdom of God. It's just plain ridiculous to think that the transitory could never possess the everlasting.

``Listen, and I will tell you a secret. Not all of us here today are going to die before the time comes! Suddenly, one day, when you least expect it, we will be transformed! The moment will come and the dead shall be raised beyond the reach of corruption, and we who are still alive shall suddenly be utterly changed. For this perishable nature of ours must be wrapped in imperishability, these bodies which are mortal must be wrapped in immortality.

``And when the perishable is lost in the imperishable, the mortal lost in the immortal, this saying will come true: 'Death is swallowed up in victory' 'O death, where is your sting? O Hades, where is your victory?'

``It is sin which gives death its power, and it is the Law which gives sin its strength. All thanks to God, then, who gives us the victory over these things through our Lord Jesus Christ!

``And so brothers of mine, stand firm! Let nothing move you as you busy yourselves in the Lord's work. Be sure that nothing you do for him is ever lost or ever wasted.

``What is it if I am said to be eloquent or gifted with speech? So what if I speak with the eloquence of men and of angels, but have no love? What is that? It is much like a blaring brass or a crashing cymbal. It's noisy, but it doesn't help anybody. Or if I were to have the gift of foretelling the future and hold in my mind not only all human knowledge but the very secrets of God, and if I also have that absolute faith which can move mountains, but have no love, does that help the world? Supposing I were to be very rich and give all my money to the poor, but do it without love in my heart, does it even achieve anything?

``What then is love? The feeling of a man lusting after a woman? God forbid. True love is slow to lose patience - it looks to help, not condemn. It is not possessive: it tries to bring up, not to push down.

``Love knows no limit to its endurance, no end to its trust, no fading of its hope; it can outlast anything. It is, in fact, the one thing that still stands when all else has fallen.

``Love exceeds all other gifts my brothers; compare, for example prophesy: one day they will be fulfilled and done with; if there is knowledge it will be swallowed up in truth. For our knowledge is always incomplete and our prophecy is always incomplete, and when the complete comes, that is the end of the incomplete.

``In this life we have three great lasting qualities - faith, hope and love. But the greatest of them is love. Follow, then, the way of love, while you set your heart on the gifts of the Spirit.

``Remember too the love of our Lord for all of us. Remember the ultimate act that he performed for us. Christ died for us, so that he could rise for us in order that we might be saved through his forgiveness of our sins.

``And during the final meal which he had before his death, the passover meal at which he was the lamb of the passover, he took a loaf, broke it and said `do this to remember me ...'

``Let us, now, then, break bread in remembrance of our Lord.''

Thud!

``Let me through, I will see to him. Here, let be. Don't be alarmed! ...

``One minute! Don't be alarmed, the boy is unharmed; he is still alive.

``Luke? Yes, Luke, you help the boy. He will be fine.

``Here is the bread of our remembrance. Let us pray.

``Father whose name will be ever honoured, let us be here when your kingdom comes! Each day give us the bread we need and that we here break and share in your name; forgive us our sins, even as we ourselves forgive others; and, now that we are free of sin keep us clear of temptation.'

``The preaching of the cross is, I know, nonsense to those who are involved in this dying world, but to us who are being saved from that death it is nothing less than the power of God.

``It is written: 'I will destroy the wisdom of the wise, and bring to nothing the understanding of the prudent'.

``Would you not agree that God has destroyed the wisdom of this world? For it was after the world in its wisdom failed to know God, that he in his wisdom chose to save all who would believe by the "simple-mindedness" of the Gospel message. For the Jews ask for miraculous proofs and the Greeks an intellectual panacea, but all we preach is Christ crucified - a stumbling block to the Jews and sheer nonsense to the Gentiles, but for those who are called, whether Jews or Greeks, Christ the power of God and the wisdom of God. And this is really only natural, for God's foolishness" is wiser than men, and his "weakness" is stronger than men.

``Look at your own calling! You don't see among you many of the so-called wise men, neither many from the ruling class or many from the noblest families, all of whom have what they want in this world. But God has chosen what the world calls foolish to shame the wise; he has chosen what the world calls weak to shame the strong. He has chosen things of little strength and small repute, yes and even things which have no real existence to explode the pretensions of the things that are - that no man may boast in the presence of God. Yet from this same God you have received your standing in Jesus Christ, and he has become for us the true wisdom, a matter, in practice, of being made righteous and holy, in fact, of being redeemed. And this makes us see the truth of scripture: 'He who glories, let him glory in the Lord.

``In the same way, my brothers, when I came to proclaim to you God's secret purpose, I did not come equipped with any brilliance of speech or intellect. You well know that all I do is to keep on harping on the same theme: Jesus Christ and the fact of his death upon the cross. As a matter of fact, in myself I never feel strong; I'm nervous and rather shaky. But what I preach had none of the attractiveness of the clever mind, but it was a demonstration of the power of the Spirit! Plainly God's purpose was that your faith should not rest upon man's cleverness but upon the power of God.

``Remember, then ...''

12. Troas

AD 56 Troas

23 years after the crucifixion

Paul had been away for six years.

And now he was back. Well, in a manner of speaking.

In the past few years, he had travelled around Greece and spent a year or more in Corinth, before turning around and sailing back to Antioch in Syria.

We only heard from or about him occasionally, usually from friendly merchants who had seen him and spoken to him and brought us news. We received a couple of highly prized letters from him and his associates, and Timothy briefly passed through on his way to Asia. We put him up for two nights and then he was off, careful not to cause a disturbance and anxious not to be recognized.

Then last year we had had a terse note from him, explaining that he was collecting money for famine relief in Judea, which had been particularly badly hit by the recent string of droughts. Obviously, we were delighted to collect money from our surplus to assist, and understood that he would be coming shortly to collect it.

But then his plans changed again and he asked us to meet him at Troas, the very place where I had first met him. Lydia had prepared to leave at once, and I had prepared my begging story as to why she couldn't manage without me.

But I never had the opportunity to use it.

``You will be coming with me to Miletus,'' she said imperiously. ``Bring everything you would need for a long trip. I sense that you will not be returning any time soon.''

Cryptic words to be sure, but not worth analysing too closely in the frantic relief of realizing that I was not going to have to get down on my knees and beg to be allowed to go with her. It was all I could do to stop myself from screaming out loud.

We had spent the passover in Philippi, preparing for our trip, gathering up the collection money we had raised and making sure everything else was able to carry on without us.

Then, once the passover was behind us and we had celebrated the rebirth of Christ on the following Sunday, we had set sail for Troas. A short, simple journey delivered us to the rendezvous after five days and we were reunited with Paul, Silas and Timothy with great rejoicing.

We had spent the week in Troas, and Paul's plan from there was to go overland to Assos and then on to Mitylene and from there to hop the coast to various places he had preached in the past on his way to Caesarea and Jerusalem.

But before leaving Troas at the end of the Sabbath, he said he would preach one more time to the faithful and we would break bread together in commemoration of the life and resurrection of Jesus. Since we were going to sail to Assos and pick him up from there, we would not be leaving until the following day.

Paul can certainly talk. I'll say that much.

I'd forgotten how much he could talk and how wrapped up in his own arguments he could become when he found his flow. And he'd been away so long that he obviously felt he had so much to tell us. And the experiences he had had had obviously changed him. Much of that was in his preaching that night, but much of it was not.

We'd rented the lecture hall for the night, and people had come from all over to hear Paul speak. So, even though the hall was huge, it was filled to capacity with people crowding into the upper lofts.

I'd first seen the young man - Eutychus was his name - sitting in the front row of one of the upper lofts when he started to become drowsy around midnight. I was concerned, not so much that he would fall, as that he might disturb the others around him.

As Paul announced that we would break bread, a great shout of `Amen' went up and jerked the boy awake with a start. As he started, he lurched forward and slithered over the railing. The men on either side of him tried to pull him back but could not hold their grip and he fell to the ground below; there, a group of brothers tried to catch him, but he evaded their best efforts and landed heavily on the floor, winded.

As a doctor, I naturally rushed over to him as quickly as I could; the situation looked grave, but not necessarily fatal. Quick as I was though, Paul was quicker and seemed almost to translate himself across the floor. He bent over the young man and called out to God for mercy. That mercy came, and by the time I arrived on the scene and took his pulse, he was already in much better shape than anybody who had just fallen from the third loft of a lecture hall had a right to expect.

I was enjoying listening to Paul preach, and certainly wanted to be there for the breaking of the bread, but I knew my place. Quickly organizing a few of the brothers around me, we improvised a litter and carried Eutychus to one of the anterooms off the main hall.

I gave him some water and sat by his side for a long while. He was breathing normally and seemed to be able to move but shortly dropped off into a sleep that seemed fairly natural - not all that surprising given that he had found himself in this predicament on account of falling asleep during Paul's raucous preaching!

From the anteroom, I could still hear some of what Paul was saying, although not at all clearly. His voice carried well, but lost definition through the stone walls of the hall. Outside, it was just starting to become light when Eutychus sat up suddenly and looked around.

``What happened?'' he asked. ``I remember ... but was it a dream? How did I end up here?''

``No,'' I assured him, ``it was not a dream. You nodded off while Paul was preaching and then woke up too suddenly when everybody acclaimed the rising of the Christ. You slipped and fell ...''

``But...,'' he said. ``I was so high up; I couldn't have survived that.''

``I don't know,'' I replied, ``other than that you clearly did. Paul came and prayed for God's mercy on you; by the time I arrived you seemed remarkably fit for a man who'd just fallen. I'd say that you are an incredibly lucky man.''

As we spoke a hubbub arose outside and I realized that Paul had finished preaching. He was now working his way through the crowd and leaving the building with Silas and Timothy who were going to Assos overland with him. As usual, a crowd of people were walking with him, trying to say something, ask something, take in some of his presence. I knew how they felt; I'd been there myself.

``Do you need a hand up?'' I asked Eutychus; he seemed fine now and probably needed to get back home to be ready for his day's work.

``No, I think I'm fine,'' he replied. ``But thank you for all your help. I'm Eutychus, what's your name?''

``I'm Luke,'' I said. ``I first met Paul here six years ago, and it's strange to be back. Was this your first time?''

``It was my first time hearing Paul,'' said Eutychus. ``Although I've heard a lot about him. I've been a Brother of the Way for two or three years now. The first brothers here were all converted by Paul - probably around the same time you met him. I'm disappointed I fell asleep. I've heard so much about him and what he was saying was fascinating, but he did go on, didn't he? I thought we'd be out of here a lot sooner than this.''

He stood up and we walked out into the crush. It wasn't long before someone recognized him and called his name.

``Eutychus! We were so worried about you. I saw you fall and tried to grab you, but there was nothing that we could do!''

At this, some of the others turned around and came towards us, recognizing the man who had fallen in their midst. Soon we were the centre of a second eddying whirlpool in that crowd.

``A miracle of our own! Not quite a resurrection from the dead, but a man who should have died, didn't!''

Paul was long gone before I had the opportunity to catch up with him.

<< also Lydia sold me to Paul >>

<< this section needs expanding and elaborating >> << cf Acts 20:13-16 >> When we reached Samos, Paul had another vision from God. He refused to speak of it to us privately, but said we should send for those brothers who could come from Ephesus and the surrounding areas and they should meet us at Meelitus and he would address us all there.

The mystery and drama added a sense of tension to the final leg of the journey to Miletus.

He had decided to end with the coast-hopping and was now going to set sail directly for Caesarea. He had taken a Nazirite vow of abstention and wished to make it to Jerusalem in time to discharge it by Pentecost.

And then, when everybody was gathered, he addressed us and it was clear what had changed.

13. Miletus

AD 56 Miletus

23 years after the crucifixion

``Greetings, oh faithful of Ephesus, whose names are written in the book of life and will be saved. And thank you all for making the journey here today to see me for what I earnestly feel will be the last time that we will see each other face to face.

``You know how, not so long ago, I lived among you in Ephesus. And you will certainly remember the troubles that led me to leave you a year ago.

``And you are doubtless aware that these troubles were not unique to Ephesus, but have dogged me everywhere since I left Antioch. They have accused me of many things; things of which you can be my witnesses I am not guilty.

``They have accused me of overweening pride; but you know that since I first arrived in Asia, I have always humbled myself before the cause of serving the Lord.

``They have accused me of falsehoods; but you know that I have never shrunk from telling the truth, even when it was unpalatable and difficult even for you to hear.

``They have accused me of denying God; but you know that I have never done anything but urged repentance of sins on all men, be they Jew or Gentile.

``They have accused me of violating the Law; but you know that while I deny the necessity of strict observance of the Law for justification, I have never myself transgressed so much as one of the provisions of the Law.

``They have accused me of covetousness and a desire for self-enrichment; but you can attest that in all the time I was with you I took nothing for my own gain that I had not earned. And that this collection which you have raised and brought to me here today is not for my own benefit, but for the benefit of the poor, needy and hungry in Judea.

``They have accused me of living my life without respect to the demands of God; but you today will witness with what heaviness I take on the next task that God has laid before me.

``For, brothers, the Spirit compels me to go to Jerusalem, as it compelled Jesus before me. And as he was betrayed and died there, I know that I too will be betrayed and sent to be killed there.

``But I also know, brothers, that in the same way that their oh-so-cunning human trap misfired and redounded to the greater glory of God, that their traps will rebound on them again and God will be the victor. Because you know that God always gives us the victory through our faith in his son Christ Jesus.

``Indeed, indeed, it is a fair question. Does the Holy Spirit tell me that my life is in danger, or is it just practical experience? A fair question indeed.

``Well, let us review the evidence. I have been beaten and left for dead; I have been chased out of cities; I have been arrested and hauled in front of magistrates more times than I care to remember, including with you in Ephesus.

``What then does this tell us about the nature of our foes? That they are persistent; that they continue to ignore the clear signs of the times; that we can only continue to pray for their repentance and deliverance.

``And I do, honestly, know from the Spirit that not one of you among whom I have moved as I preached the kingdom of God will ever see my face again in Asia.

``But my conscience is clear: I have taught you well, and you yourselves have proved out the faith which I had in you, and God has delivered hundredfold fruit in you.

``And I know now that as I move on from this theatre to others - whether to live or to die - that you are no longer the sheep needing to be fed, watered, folded and carded, but are the shepherds, ready to gather your own flocks and you are now the guardians of the brotherhood in Asia, even at the cost of your own blood.

``For it will not be an easy ride for you, brothers and sisters! Oh, no! Never think that because I leave you all the strife and discord will suddenly go away, as if I were the cause of it!

``But no! The cause of the discord is as it ever has been; the root cause of all evil is the devil at work abroad in the world. While I am here, I am the figurehead and they will do everything they can to unseat me. But when I am gone, to be betrayed and slaughtered elsewhere, then they will turn their attentions on you, my brothers.

``Like ravening wolves they will come among you, taking you for sheep. And if sheep, they will trap you and kill you and the word of God, God's glorious word of repentance and hope given unto us through the death and resurrection of his son, and even more so by the life and teaching of the man Christ Jesus, this teaching I say, they will try to blot out from the earth.

``But you are not sheep! Not you! No, you are the shepherds of Asia, ready to stand against the evil one. And I know that you will protect each others and you will protect those among the nations who are still sheep and need your strength.

``And you will be strong, brothers! You will be strong for all those who need you to be strong.

``But when the direct attacks fail, they will try more subtle means to subvert they faith. They will come among you and tell you that they are also followers of the Way. They will come among you and tell you that they are your brothers. Lies! Heinous Lies!

``But how will you tell? For surely you have other brothers, and they will, from time to time come among you, and they will tell you the truth - that they are your brothers. And the lies will sound like the truth and the truth will sound like the lies.

``But the Spirit knows, my brothers. The Spirit can always distinguish the Truth from the Lie. And if the Spirit of Truth is in you, then you will know the Truth, and you will see the lie and you will be strong in those days!

``While I was with you for all those months, I never failed to take an opportunity to make sure you were instructed and grounded in the faith. And I ensured that you were baptised and had received the Holy Spirit. And now you have received the Holy Spirit, it will tell you what is true and what is not true.

``Remember that you have repented! Remember always that you are saved and that your names are written in the book of Life! The end times are now, my brothers, and like Christ before me, I go to Jerusalem thinking that this could be the one event that brings about the final Day of Judgment.

``And where will you be on that Day, brothers?

``This, more than anything else, is the one question which I want you to ask yourselves and to ask each other daily: where will I be on Judgment Day?

``Where will you be? You have been saved. You have believed now in the revelation of Christ Jesus. You have taken the baptism of the faith. You have taken the first steps on the road to complete freedom. And there is no going back.

``And thus, in parting with you all for the last time, I commend you to the care of the Holy Spirit, in whose hands are the outcomes of life. In His hands you are secure. In the knowledge and love of Christ Jesus you are saved.

14. Journey to Caesarea

AD 56 Judaea

23 years after the crucifixion

I can't speak for anyone else - although I can certainly imagine how they felt - but I was in shock after this speech.

I had just been sold from the only mistress I had ever known into the hands of a man I loved dearly and would follow to the ends of the earth - only to find he was hurrying to meet his betrayal and death!

After Paul's address ended, I went down to the harbour and boarded our ship. We were due to set off at first light and try to make it directly to Cos. From there, Paul was hoping that he would be able to board another ship that went straight from there to Caesarea, but no matter what, he was going to keep going.

Paul remained in the town for a long while and parted with old friends one by one. Emotional as the moment was for me, I could only imagine what it was like for him.

Around me was a hive of activity. Apart from our own baggage - and the collection from Ephesus - that was being brought on board, the shipmaster was still loading his main cargo, and other passengers eager to make an early run from Asia to the far end of the Mediterranean were boarding along with their possessions. In the dark, lit only by guttering torches, the clamour of the stevedores seemed preternaturally loud. And that, set against what Paul had just revealed ...

Paul boarded almost literally as they were pulling up the gangplank and preparing to cast off. Even so, he complained that he had to hurry away from some of the brothers he still considered lifelong friends - even though by his own admission he would never see them again.

The morning was bright and we had a firm breeze blowing us offshore. The captain assured us that with any luck the wind would hold and we would make good time to Cos.

As long as there wasn't a storm.

The sentence that any good sailor - and certainly and good captain - utters almost reflexively the moment they have expressed any opinion about what the notoriously fickle sea may choose to do. None of us wanted to lose our lives this night.

Paul was leaning over the port rail when I finally plucked up the courage to ask him what he thought he was doing.

To put it bluntly, he looked at me like I might have gone mad.

``I am going to Jerusalem to fulfill a number of vows.'' He started to enumerate them.

``I have sworn a Nazirite vow, and little though that may mean to you, trust me, it is a very serious matter and I must go to the temple to discharge it.

``Secondly, I must deliver the monies that I have collected from across Asia and Greece to help the poor and needy brothers in Jerusalem.

``Thirdly, Silas has business in Jerusalem and he, too, must go to the Temple to make an offering.

``And finally, and quite unanswerably, I go because that is where the Holy Spirit sends me.

``Do you really think that anything I do is done of my own free will? You think you know me, Luke, because of the time we spent together in Philippi. But that is but a small slice of my life and experience. It may feel threatening to you to go to Jerusalem knowing that they will try to kill me. But remember, that everywhere I have already been they have tried to kill me. What makes Jerusalem different? Only that it is where the head of the snake is. Cut that off, and we are free!''

``And do you think you can defang the snake in Jerusalem?'' I asked. Nothing I had heard so far suggested he had a firm belief in his own survival, let alone such a stunning victory.

``No, I do not,'' he responded. ``I am not so arrogant as to believe that I can accomplish what Jesus could not. But I know that everything that happens, happens at the direction of the Spirit.

``And the Spirit cannot want that it should die out from the world and that none should be saved. So if I need to go to Jerusalem and give my freedom - or my life - for the greater good, I will go and give whatever is demanded of me. And I will go always testifying to the Truth as it has been revealed to me. And perhaps I will escape the trap, or perhaps I will turn it on them, or perhaps just in failing I make a difference that saves one more soul.

``Remember, Luke, that there will be more rejoicing in Heaven over just one sinner who repents than a thousand righteous men who followed the Law and did not need to repent! My life for the redemption of a sinner? How could I say no?''

I looked at him and knew that he was sincere. I knew also that my fate was tied to his - and had been since that first fateful night in Troas. In reality, it had been since long before that; since we had first heard those whispers of a new doctrine coming out of Judea, bringing with it hope of the resurrection among men. If he was going to Jerusalem, I was going to Jerusalem. And if he was going to die there, there was an above-evens chance that I would die there, too.

There were no ships sailing directly from Cos to the East, so we had sailed on to Rhodes as the most likely place to find such a ship.

We didn't, but the harbourmaster directed us to a ship bound for Patara, where he said that the Phoenecians would have a number of ships heading for Tyre, and from there it would be easy to find a coastal lugger going to Caesarea or we could avoid the vagaries of the sea and just travel overland.

We'd followed his advice and were now south of Cyprus heading for the ship's home port of Tyre. Day by day we continued in our practices, rituals and traditions and broke bread together and prayed for understanding and repentance. Paul had given over preaching for the course of this journey for reasons that he kept to himself. It certainly wasn't for fear, but it was almost as if he were retreating inside himself.

After the morning prayers, Silas dared to ask one of the questions we were all wondering. ``Why the great rush?'' he asked. ``Why is it so important to reach Jerusalem by Pentecost?''

Paul looked at him intently; then sighed deeply.

``I do not know,'' he replied. ``I only know that I am guided by the Spirit; I am driven by the Spirit; I am constrained by the Spirit. And the Spirit impels me forward and shows me that something will be happening at Pentecost and I need to be there.

``And if the Spirit knows that I need to be there, it will make it come true. And if I am not there, that too will have its reasons. But it is not given to me to know or understand the reasons and so I cannot pass that on to you. But I sense that I must do all in my power to be in Jerusalem by Pentecost.''

And that was all there really was to say on the subject. We were bound to the will of the Spirit.

We had an easy journey to Tyre and still had three weeks left before Pentecost. One of the brothers in Tyre had a ship doing the coastal run through Caesarea and down to Alexandria and offered us passage leaving in a week. Since the journey would be about a week and it was only a couple of days from there to Jerusalem we agreed eagerly, especially since it gave us a week to spend with a community that knew Paul well and were keen to catch up with him after he had been away for many years.

On the Sabbath we had our weekly prayer meeting and offered thanks to God for our deliverance from sin through the intercession of Christ Jesus. When Paul had spoken at length, others rose to speak and one after another stood and prophesied that if Paul were to step within the Temple he would never taste freedom again.

Eventually Paul snapped. Always irritable and ready to rush to judgment, this was not what he wanted to hear right now.

``What use is it to prophesy the same thing over and over?'' he demanded. ``What do you want me to do? If it be the end of my life; if I be tortured; if I be arrested and held in a dungeon; what is that to me? They can destroy this body of my earthly habitation but I will not let them corrupt my soul by running away from the Truth that has been revealed to me by the Holy Spirit.

``I confess that you have heard the words of the Spirit, and I too know that no bodily good will come from this trip, even though it be a trip of mercy for those who would persecute me. But tell me, what can I do? I can no more run away from the demands of the Spirit than you can contain these prophecies. Enough! I am content that in all things I have been honest and high-minded with you; that I have told you all the truth as it was given to me; and that when I am no more, you will hold to the truth in your community.

``And if I go to Jerusalem and do not return, then we will see each other in the day of the glory of the Lord when he returns for us.''

He paused and looked around the room; then as soon as the temper had flared up, it settled down and he calmed himself and sat down again.

``I'm sorry,'' he said. ``Please continue, but know that no matter what anybody says or does, I am bound for Jerusalem. I have no choice, come what may.''

Two days later we left Tyre and sailed via Ptolemais to Caesarea where we left the ship. As we walked to the harborside in Tyre, all the brothers had come with us, wanting their last glimpse of Paul. As at Philippi, they knew they were never going to see him again.

Caesarea was a centre of the Way unlike any I had seen before.

Our small community in Philippi was little more than an extension of Lydia's household. In Troas, the meetings I had attended had had forty or fifty men present, but many of those were not believers but others that were curious or that Paul was trying to convert. In Ephesus, there were maybe twenty or thirty brothers who had made the pilgrimage to Miletus to see Paul when we had passed through.

Here in Caesarea, you could be forgiven for thinking that almost the whole city belonged to the Way. It wasn't true of course, but the fact that most of the `real' residents (as opposed to Roman officials or Greek merchants) were Jews meant that there was a much wider pool of potential converts to draw from. And a lot of drawing had gone on.

In many of the original `Jesus stories', the primary characters were fishermen. I'd not been to Galilee - this was the first time I'd visited the province of Judea, in fact - but it made sense that in preaching to a group of rustics who mainly made their living farming or fishing and selling to the big Roman towns like Sepphoris, he would have used metaphors and stories grounded in that lifestyle.

And it made sense that that terminology would have been preserved and passed on and amplified even after the communities spread to the big cities - Jerusalem and Caesarea being the biggest in Judea proper.

The community here was led by a man called Philip, a man with a certain reputation in the community of the Way - enough that, much like Peter and James - I had heard of him. He was not one of the original disciples who had followed Jesus from his earliest days, but had been a convert early on when John was still baptizing by the Jordan. He had been a follower of John and then, when John was arrested, had gone to see Jesus preach and been impressed with the stylistic differences. John had been a fire-breathing prophet who could almost have walked out of the pages of the Holy Writings; Jesus was a very calm, understated man but one with an undeniable authority. It was like meeting the nobleman's son or one of the great Roman commanders. He didn't rant or rave or demand obedience, he merely told you how it was with complete authority and self-confidence. From there, it was all but impossible to argue with him. I'd heard - and I was to hear much more over the coming years - that in his presence it was all but impossible to hold to former, `sinful' beliefs. It wasn't that he told you to repent; to be in his presence *was* to repent. Anything else just felt like madness.

15. Arrested

AD56 Jerusalem

23 years after the crucifixion

Now that we were on dry land and the risks of a sea voyage were behind us, the journey time was more predictable and Paul was calmer, knowing that come Pentecost he would be in the Temple. What would happen there, nobody could be quite sure, but there was general agreement that, humanly at least, it would not be a pleasant experience.

And when I say, general, I mean *everybody* was in agreement.

Philip, the deacon with whom we were staying, had four grown daughters. Each of them had the gift of prophesy but, as we had observed in Tyre, when you are heading straight into danger, prophesy feels like anything but a gift.

And then, the day before we left, a man called Agabus came up from the back-country beyond Jordan to see Paul; wanted to see him by name. Agabus was not a brother of the Way; he was a Jew, and a prophet among the Jews. What did he want with Paul? Was it a trap; one of the `leaders of the Jews' sent to entrap Paul into saying or doing something that he shouldn't. But Paul was confident this was a true prophet, a man sent from God, and such men could not be suborned by human will. Eventually we conceded to Paul's wishes and let the man in.

He was the perfect stereotype of the old-testament prophet, like others before him such as John the Baptist: wild-eyed, wild-haired, unkempt and looking as if he were hunted. He came in, and, without so much as a pause to ask which of us *was* Paul, walked straight up to him and demanded he give him his tunic. Paul, in shock, removed it and handed it over. Agabus promptly sat down on the floor and started to truss himself with it in the same way that pigs are tied - except nobody in Judea keeps pigs, judging them to be unclean animals.

We all stood there amazed at this performance. We still didn't even know who this man was, but he clearly knew - or otherwise recognized - Paul and was proceeding to embarrass him in some way or other.

``Amen, Amen, Hear ye the words of the Lord,'' he suddenly cried out, his eyes rolling up in his head leaving the whites exposed.

``Thus says the Lord of Israel, the man who owns this tunic will come to be hog-tied, even as I am hog-tied with his tunic. That man will be trussed up and taken captive by the leaders of the people in Jerusalem, and then they will hand him over to the Gentiles for punishment! Woe unto him, I say, who dares to go to Jerusalem!''

The silence was so profound you could have heard an owl ruffling its feathers. Agabus sat on the floor, tied hand and foot in Paul's tunic while Paul stood there bare-chested just staring at him.

Philip was the first to start moving again. He did not move to address or reprove Agabus, but seemed to take his prophecy to heart. ``Please, Paul, reconsider. There is no hope for you if you go up to Jerusalem. Now is the last chance to change your mind. Sail away. From here you can go anywhere in the Empire! You've always said you want to take the word to Rome, Spain and the Gauls! Go now! Do it and live! Spread the word while there is still time!''

Once Philip had said his piece, we all joined in, begging and pleading with him to abjure his journey to Jerusalem and continue doing the work of God in the open fields of the West. But he was adamant.

``What is the meaning of all this? We have been through this again and again! What difference does it make what I want? What difference does it make what any of you think is humanly a good idea? Does it matter if Paul lives or dies? No, it matters *how* Paul lives and dies. If I am to run away, then it says I admit I am in the wrong. If I go to Jerusalem and they crucify me, I follow in the footsteps of my master, and have hope that I will rise with him again at the end of days; and I remind you those days are not far off now.''

Agabus responded for all of us: ``The Lord's work will be done, whatever Paul or any of us should wish.''

In Jerusalem, we met Peter and James.

This whole trip was starting to feel like a journey backwards in time. I was half-expecting that our next stop would be to hear Jesus himself preaching, but that of course was impossible, at least in the flesh.

Given the purpose of this trip - to bring aid to the brothers in famine - our reception was surprising lukewarm. But given the aura of despair that had settled in the past couple of weeks, it was unsurprising at best.

``You should not have come,'' said James. ``You are not anybody's favourite person right now. And the fanfare which has announced your coming - everybody has been talking about the aid collection you have been raising across Greece and Asia - means that those who would plot against you have advance notice and have all the advantages. Even the brothers ...''

``The *brothers* are plotting against me?'' Paul asked, shocked.

``No of course not. What *they* say, they say openly. But it is not positive about you, brother.''

``What do they say?''

``The usual. That in bending to accomodate the legitimate issues raised in spreading the word you have gone apostate. That you wish to be the leader of our Way, and to do that you wish to collect more followers, more money ... as if the Spirit could be bought with mere money.''

``But you know those rumours are untrue! I follow the Law scrupulously in my own regard, except for the requirement to live apart from Gentiles ... an impossibility if you are on a mission to the Gentiles. And even so, I make it a rule to never actually live with Gentiles who have not converted to the Way.''

``What we know and what they say are neither here nor there. And in any case, your bigger issue is with those in the Temple who are not brothers but who plot against you. They are waiting for their moment to strike. You can be sure that they know you are here already and are probably laying their trap for you. You should not have come. I don't think you'll be able to leave alive.''

``Maybe not. That is for the Spirit to decide. Certainly all the prophets seem in accord for once that if I ever leave this city, it will not be as a free man. But this is where Jesus died for us. The least I can do is to follow his example to the end. How do you manage?''

``We, brother, live entirely within the Law. The early days when certain men prosecuted us because we preached Christ risen have passed. Some believe and join us; others do not and avoid us. But all of us continue in the Law and the traditions of the fathers. We are, as it were, considered a sect akin to the Pharisees and the Sadducees. And the fervour in these days is with the Romans. And many predict the destruction of Jerusalem. Is that a sign of the end times? How can we tell? Jesus was so vague ... just that the end times were assuredly coming.''

Paul sighed and thought.

``What then to do? I have come for two reasons. Yes, I could have put the collection in other hands, but the Spirit guided me not to. And I had sworn a Nazirite vow that I would not rest until I had personally ensured the money was in your hands. And so now I need to be in Jerusalem for the seven days of purification and discharge.''

Peter and James looked at each other. ``You're going to be here for *seven days*?'' said Peter. ``And do they know that?''

Paul looked at them askance. ``I'm not in the habit of keeping secrets,'' he responded. ``And even if I were, a Nazirite vow is not the easiest thing to try and keep secret. Of course I swore it publicly, and of course everybody knows. I'm surprised you didn't know.''

``Well, that answers one question at least,'' injected James. ``We have four brothers who went into debt and swore that they would live as Nazirites until they could find a way to repay their creditors.''

``Some of your brothers went into debt and the others did not help?'' said Paul. ``What happened to holding all in common?''

``You have been all around Asia collecting for us and yet you do not understand the gravity of the situation here? There is very little to be had. To say that some of our brothers are in debt is really just to distinguish those who have borrowed from those who have struggled to get by without borrowing.

``But here is what I propose. From the money you have collected you could settle their debts and then the five of you could go every day to the Temple to praise God and perform the necessary sacrifices. And our brothers would see you being holy, and being in the presence of those of our brothers that they know to be holy, and would know that the rumours that you have apostasized are simply untrue.''

Paul thought about this for a moment, pondering.

``And what you are not saying is that while I am here walking the streets of the city I will have a bodyguard of four men of impeachable character, well known to the authorities. And that snatching me away to the Sanhedrin under cover of darkness would be just that much harder.''

``It might be a side benefit,'' agreed Peter. ``But not what we will, but what the Father wills.''

``Indeed,'' agreed Paul, resigned.

I didn't go up to the Temple after the first day.

Obviously I'd wanted to see it, but to say that they make you feel like an outsider is an understatement. I don't imagine I'd feel any more out of place if I went to the Senate building in Rome - which is always known for its exclusivity. On top of which, I didn't feel comfortable drawing attention to the fact that Paul was surrounded by non-Jews. Timothy went with him, of course, but Timothy had not only joined the Way as a Gentile, but had gone `the whole way' and actually converted to Judaism, including having been circumsized.

That didn't mean to say that we weren't to be seen together around the city, and obviously our enemies whispered this and that against us: they said, rightly, that we were not circumsized and, wrongly, that our presence defiled others. Those `others' kept themselves pure by not living with us, bathing with us or eating with us. Being here was a shock given the frequent refrain of Paul's ``now there is neither Jew nor Gentile, slave or free man but we are all brothers in Christ who died and rose for us.''

On the seventh and final day of the purification, Paul had gone to attend the final purification ritual in the Temple, and I was at Peter's house when a messenger came running from the Temple to say that there had been a commotion and he thought Paul had been arrested by the Temple Guards.

``You *think* he's been arrested?'' Peter demanded. ``Why are you not sure?''

``The purification ritual had just been finished, and the five of them were walking out into the court of the Gentiles, and Trophimus was there waiting for them, and at that moment, some men dragged hold of Paul and Trophimus and started shouting `Blasphemy' and that Paul was defiling the Temple by bringing in foreigners and calling for the guards.

``And you know how it goes when a riot starts. If you don't get out quickly, then you often don't get out.''

Trophimus was one of our party; he was from Ephesus and had joined us at Miletus as the man responsible for bringing the Ephesus collection to Jerusalem and meeting with the brothers here. I hadn't seen him for a few days, but he wasn't one of the `inner circle', as it were. Our party had over twenty men in it and obviously not all of us were together all the time. But it was understandable that he had wanted to see Paul in his purified state. But would he really go into the parts of the Temple where Gentiles were forbidden?

``Without doubt, he stayed outside in the Court of the Gentiles where he was permitted,'' the messenger confirmed when Peter asked the question. ``But the facts are not that important in a case like this. He will testify, and I will testify that he was outside. But you can be sure that they will have a line of unimpeachable witnesses who say that he went inside. And who can know the Truth?''

``And was there a riot?'' interposed Peter's wife, concerned that the city might be overturned again by the rash of hot-blooded zealots on the loose for some kind of religious misdemeanour.

``Again, I do not know,'' the messenger demurred. ``My main concern was to escape and bring you the news before the riot started. But you know how these thing unfold: a man shouts `blasphemy', others tear their clothes and then all the old injustices and hatreds come out and before you know it the young hotheads are throwing stones and punching people at random. Then the guards come up to restore order and it becomes serious. And then if somebody decides to call the Romans out of the barracks ...''

``Right,'' said Peter. ``But we need more information. If there is a riot, the easiest thing would be for them to have Paul die `accidentally' in it. Otherwise there will probably have to be an arrest and a trial. I suppose they might want that, but probably they just want to get rid of him.

``Let's split up and find out what's happened. But Luke, you need to stay here. The last thing we want is them dragging you into it saying that you were defiling the Temple as well. That will be much harder for them if you're here.''

So I sat and waited. It was torture.

16. Sanhedrin

AD56 Jerusalem

23 years after the crucifixion

``Men and brothers, I have lived my life with a perfectly clear conscience before God up to the present day. I keep faith with God's Law as revealed by Moses, and I abide by the words of the prophets. I praise God with the psalms, and I revere the unique history that has been gifted to the Jewish people. And thus, my brothers, have I lived my entire life.

``It is not to be supposed that because I have gone and preached the salvation of the new revelation I have received through Jesus Christ throughout Asia and Greece to Gentiles as well as Jews that I reject our heritage; nor is it reasonable to say that I would profane the Temple or the customs of our people.

``Of what, then, am I accused? Of trumped-up falsehoods? You know as well as I do that I did *not* bring any Gentiles into the Holy Spaces of the Temple. God forbid that I should do such a thing.

``Am I perhaps accused of spreading God's word to the Gentiles? Is that a crime? To spread the word of God to those who have not had the opportunity to hear it previously?

``Or is it possibly the crime of saying that these people are now welcome in the province of our God and can be saved?

``Once there was a man named Abraham. Before God promised to make nations out of his children, he was just a man, uncircumised as the Gentiles. But God found him through his faith - faith by which he came out of the land of his birth and his idols. And after God found him, he led him to the land which was promised him - and then has been promised to us as the children of his inheritance.

``How, now, then are the Gentiles of today in a different position to Abraham centuries ago? They, like he, know nothing of God. Like he, they are uncircumised. But what if they, like he, are prepared to emerge from the cities and leave their idols and their superstitions and come home to have faith in the one true God?

``You may say it is a sweetheart deal! But if the Law chafes on you so strongly, ask yourselves why you think that is. Was man made for the Law or the Law for the man? Maybe you should consider giving up your hope of salvation and apostasising as you accuse me of doing?

``Of course it is hard to obey the Law! If it were so easy everybody did it all the time, it wouldn't be `the Law' but just natural habits.

``And it was because of how hard it is to follow the Law that God sent Jesus to call his lost sheep to repentance and a deeper understanding of the Law. Remember the words of the prophet Jeremiah:

``And the day will one day come when I will cease this stupid repetition `obey the Law' for in that day I will write the Law into their very bones, and then they will all be my children, and then it will truly be the case that I will be the God that they worship.

``But in the days of Jeremiah that was not the case and God had to punish them again and again because they drifted away from his words again and again. And today? How is it any different today? Your very argument that it is hard to obey the Law tells against you! It is not written on your inside; you simply obey it from the outside, as an imposition of a cruel and unjust God!

``Arrgh! For striking me, God will strike you, you empty-headed idiot!

``So what did God do? He sent Christ Jesus to show you the effortless nature of obeying the will of God, and to pour out on all willing to receive it his Holy Spirit, that should infuse them and carry out his promise to write the Law on their insides.

``And how did you respond? By crucifying him! The very man that had been sent to call sinners to repentance, you murdered as a sinner himself!

``No, no I cannot claim to be truly innocent. No, I was not hear when Jesus himself was crucified. No, I applauded the actions taken against his followers in the early days. I applauded when Stephen was taken and stoned. I, myself, prosecuted, argued and disputed with followers of this Way across Syria from Antioch to Damascus.

``And then the miracle occurred. Jesus himself appeared to me as to one born out of the due course of nature. And his Spirit fell upon me, and baptised me and purified me of my self-belief and sin that was blinding me. And in humility, I accepted the words of God and repented of my sins and changed my ways.

``How then could I help myself but to preach this to others, still living in the blindness from which I had escaped? How could I hold fast to myself the blessings I had received while others languished in the darkness?

``Tell me, how!

``And yes, I preached that Jesus died for us and that Jesus rose for us, because I know first-hand that he did! Yes, I do! Because he appeared unto me, and how could that be if he were not risen from the dead!

``Indeed that is true, you Sadducees deny the resurrection in all its forms. But I am a Pharisee, a son of Pharisees and of generations of Pharisees, and I say unto you that the resurrection is real, the bodily resurrection is real and all will be resurrected in the final day for judgment, and _that day will not long be delayed!

``And I perceive that in truth, it is this for which I am on trial! It is for my hope in the resurrection of the dead and my preaching of it!''

17. Claudias Lysias

AD56 Jerusalem

23 years after the crucifixion

The messenger had not exaggerated the danger.

I was finally able to see Colonel Claudias Lysias, in charge of the Roman Regiments in Jerusalem, two days after Paul's arrest and obtain the full story of what had passed. It seems that Colonel Lysias had saved Paul's life not once but twice in the intervening time, and when I met with him was preparing to save it for a third time.

When he had arrived on the scene, he explained to me, Paul was on the verge of being ripped bodily limb from limb.

``I don't understand this city, I don't mind admitting,'' he told me once I had won his confidence and reassured him that I was not spying either for the Governor or the Jewish leaders but was a concerned friend of Paul's who honestly believed that he was innocent of any crimes. ``Give me some good Germans or Thracians any day. At least up there on the border you know who the enemy are and what you need to do to achieve your goals. Bash a few heads and kill a few tribesmen and the rest run away with their tails between their legs.

``But here, I don't get it. They have so many different divisions and so many different perspectives, it makes me head spin. And all about something so abstract, how can you even know what the truth is? Give me a good body of flesh and blood rather than this ridiculous religious speculation.

``Anyway, it seems they were having some argument about the nature of the God. A lot of the shouting was in Aramaic, and I just don't know that. My Greek ain't too bad, but basically I'm a Roman and I speak Latin. So simple concepts in Greek is one thing, but a religious discourse in Aramaic. I ain't a clue.

``But I know one thing: when twenty men are pummelling one, he probably needs my protection. So I ordered my men and we waded in - just shields, you understand, no swords drawn and pulled him out of there and off to the barracks.''

I have to day, where Paul's safety was concerned, I'd personally rather he had drawn his sword and killed a few of the blighters attacking him, but I saw his point. I've seen enough riots to know that drawing swords just leads to mindless death and more riots the next day ... or the day after. This was clearly a man who had reached his position through skill and experience and not just by political favour - so often the case in this decadent age.

``At first, I mistook him for one of those zealots. You know, once of those professional troublemakers who go around causing trouble. We had a guy here not so long ago from Egypt who'd raised almost a legion of rabble and tried to raise the countryside. We put that down of course, right sharpish, but the ringleader escaped. From all accounts, he looks like this Paul of yours. But when I interrogated him, it became clear that he wasn't one of these Alexandrian Jews who are all uppity since they helped out the Great Caesar a hundred years ago - Jupiter bless his memory! - but from Tarsus, which, as he was at pains to point out, while not Alexandria, is still a city of reputation.''

``I was going to have him scourged and let him go, but apparently he has connections somewhere up or down the Imperial chain through his family back in Tarsus, so I figured that we'd better do things by the book. And here, that means first and foremost putting him on trial before the local authorities. Since this seemed to be some kind of religious dispute, I decided to take him in front of the Sanhedrin.''

The Sanhedrin! A bigger snakepit of Paul's dedicated enemies could hardly be found. There was no chance that they would have acquited him - after all, they were basically the very people who had set him up in the first place. Why set him up if the didn't plan on following through and finding him guilty?

``They can be very touchy and with all their restrictions and everything is often very hard to arrange a trial. They won't come here and we can't go there and all that. So eventually we managed to find one of their leaders' houses that was sufficiently `profane' to allow us in with the prisoner while still being acceptable for their meeting.

``And again, they went off into Aramaic, and I'll be confounded if I'd could understand the process. No lofty oratory, just a lot of confused shouting, and a couple of times they just struck the prisoner when he said things they didn't like. In the end, he said something that threw them all into consternation, and half of them seemed to be ready to acquit him while the other half seemed ready to rip him limb from limb on the spot like the mob the day before.

``So I had no choice, did I? I had to intervene and pull him out of there. You can ask him yourself about it, but basically he said they were arguing about the afterlife. Seems dumb to me ... was he planning to get himself killed just to find out what happens after?''

``So can I see the prisoner?'' I asked.

``Sure, follow me,'' he replied.

Paul seemed brighter than I'd expected when I finally saw him.

But then, I had to realize that being reviled and beaten was hardly a new experience for this man. In the short time I'd been with him, I'd probably seen it three or four times. And now this.

``But at least the worst is over!'' he enthused when I greeted him. ``The prophecies have been fulfilled and I am still here to witness for the Lord!''

It was true that he was still alive but `here' being the Roman prison on the outskirts of Jerusalem, I'm not entirely sure it's where I'd aspire to be.

``The Lord Jesus appeared to me again last night,'' said Paul.

What? Jesus had returned to the city of his death and I'd missed it! No wonder Paul was so uplifted!

``He stood where you are standing and reassured me, that while I may be a captive here, I will not die here. But that I will be taken to Rome - and reach there alive!''

Taken to Rome? For what purpose? What was Paul talking about?

``Slow down,'' I reproved him. ``I'm not sure you're making any sense. Let's start at the beginning. What happened at the Temple.''

``We had made our final offering to discharge our vow,'' he began, frowning as he tried to recollect the events. We had walked outside, and I was in the court of the Gentiles when Trophimus - you know, the representative from the Ephesus brotherhood - came up to me and congratulated me. Of course, he's not circumsized, he doesn't follow the strict Law. He's allowed in the Court of the Gentiles, but not in the Temple. But then some fool came up yelling he'd been in the inner Courts of the Temple when I'd been discharging my vow. Ridiculous, of course!

``But it was enough for a crowd of men to come around and start grabbing and attacking me.''

``And yelling `blasphemy','' I added, recalling what the messenger had said at Peter's house.

``Indeed,'' conceded Paul. ``It was cunningly done. I don't know if they knew that Trophimus was going to be there - or if they somehow even managed to plant that thought in his mind. But they certainly knew enough to take advantage of the situation when it arose.

``The Romans intervened of course - I'm not really sure whether to be grateful about that or not - and carted me off here.''

``And then sent you to the Sanhedrin for trial.''

``Trial? A farce. Those buffoons think they can intimidate me, and into what? I really don't understand where they're coming from. I think they are in fact most scared of the thought that Jesus might have been what we preach him to me - literally the Son of Man, come to announce the end times and the beginning of the judgment.

``And so much of what they think and do is based on the essentially human aspects of their job. They love the status, the sense of feeling better than their flock. And they probably reasonably fear for the day when not only will they no longer be better than the others - for we shall all see each other as adopted sons of God - and not even better than the Gentiles! - but will themselves be judged; and how could they not be found wanting?''

``How did you manage to avoid execution?''

``I tried to convince them of the error of their ways, and tried once more to witness to them the truth of Jesus dead and raised. And when I brought up the subject of the resurrection, all the party of the Sadducees ripped open their blasphemy straps and yelled that there was no resurrection. And then it struck me!

``Much of the persecution we face is not because of the fear of apostasy, but simply because there is a large group of priests who deny that there will be a resurrection at the last day.

``And when we preach that not only is the hope of resurrection extended to all Jews, and beyond that all Gentiles, but that our faith is based on the evidence of our own senses that one has risen from the dead *already*, their entire world view is threatened. How can they continue to claim that there *is* no resurrection, when one has stood amongst us, resurrected in incorruptible flesh?''

``And for this they would kill you?'' I was incredulous.

``For this, and for so much more,'' he responded. ``They fear the truth and the promise of God. They fear the mercy that I preach. They fear the Gentiles and the possibility that their institutions would be overrun by newcomers ...''

``Another visitor for the prisoner,'' shouted the guard on duty and the messenger I'd seen at Peter's house a couple of days before came in.

``Hello, nephew,'' said Paul, with his familiar greeting to all those to young to truly be called `brothers' in the faith. ``What's wrong?''

``More bad news, I'm afraid,'' the boy replied. ``They won't stop, you know that, don't you?''

``Who? The Sanhedrin?'' asked Paul.

``Well, the younger, more radical ones,'' the boy said. ``I was in the market square this morning and a group of them came by. At that time, it was suspicious that they were there, so I followed them - discreetly, you can be sure - and tried to overhear what they were saying. It was difficult to make out, but the basic plot appears to be that they want to arrange for a second hearing and then grab you and kill you en route into the city. You need protection.''

``Well, there's only one place that's going to come from,'' I said. ``That's the Romans. Colonel Claudius Lysias seems to think you worth preserving. I've formed something of a relationship with him; I'll go and advise him to make sure he puts a decent bodyguard on you.''

Paul's `nephew' came with me to see the Colonel. First-hand reporting, even of the somewhat vague kind, is always worth having. We had to wait to see him, as he was meeting with someone else. Finally we were admitted to this office.

``Colonel,'' I began, ''at some point this morning, you should expect to receive a request from the Sanhedrin to examine the prisoner Paul again.''

``Do you just say this because the High Priest's representative has just left and you are guessing at his motives, or do you have independent information?'' he asked.

I pointed to the boy, who spoke up.

``I heard them discussing a plot to take Paul's life,'' he said. ``The plan is to demand Paul's summons to the Sanhedrin and then attack the understrength body of guards on the way up the hillside. In the fracas Paul dies. And then I think they intend to pass off the blame on us.''

``I smelt something fishy when that man was here. He wouldn't answer my questions directly, and avoided my gaze. On top of which, I'm not sure that this religious court has jurisdiction over this case - if there is a case.

``I may not know Jewish law, but I understand Roman law and practice. It's more than my job's worth to not inform the governor. And I think at this moment the right thing is to send the prisoner with my message.''

``Scribe! Come here!''

The scribe quickly came according to the summons and he started dictating his message to Governor Felix. ``Take down this message and make fair copies for the archives and to send to Rome.

``Claudius Lysias to the Governor Felix. Salutations! I am sending this message with a prisoner whom I arrested for his own safety at the Temple of the Jews in the midst of a riot when he was on the point of being murdered by the mob. Since then, I have had the opportunity to interrogate him and he does not appear to be a subversive or to have committed any crime recognized under Roman law. He claims citizenship of Tarsus in Asia and to be connected to eminent - Roman - citizens there. Wishing to find out what the accusation was that they were making against him, I had him brought down to their Sanhedrin. There I discovered he was being accused over questions of their laws, but they had no charge against him which deserved either death or imprisonment. Now I have received that there is a plot against his life. This all goes above my authority and thus I am sending him to you without delay. My recommendation is that you release him, but at the same time I have notified his accusers that if they wish to continue their prosecution of him they must come to Caesarea and make their charges against him in front of you.''

While the scribe was taking down this dictation and slowly reducing it to perfect copy, he made all the other logistical arrangements with a precision and division of intellect which I found amazing. With individuals like this in charge of their military machine, it's not surprising that the Romans have conquered the world.

He summoned one of his centurions in charge of the infantry battalion and told him to prepare an escort for Paul.

``I want you to put 200 men on the job. I don't imagine for one minute that there are anything like that number of Jews in on this plot, so just that number will be a big deterrent. You shouldn't have to fight. But on top of that take another seventy skirmishers ... slingers or something like that in case they decide to try and just take out Paul without a pitched engagement.''

Then he summoned the centurion in charge of the cavalry, which Romans generally despised as a military arm but he recognized they had their uses:

``How many men have you available right now for a trip to Caesarea? Good. Take seventy of them and spread them out along the column, but put at least a dozen around the prisoner to shield him. Make him walk until you're out into the open country, then you can mount him up to make better time. Space the others out so as to be ready to charge down anyone trying to hit and run. I don't want to start a riot, but if it means that much to these criminals I'll give them a fair fight. Rules of engagement: don't start anything but be sure to appear menacing and the moment anything happens, I want you to respond with overwhelming force. I pre-idemnify you against any locals that may be trampled if the prisoner makes it to Caesarea, but it's probably your job if he doesn't make it. Clear? Good.''

He made sure that everything was clear, and in between continuing his dictation to the Governor finished up the logistical directions.

``Take the day to plan and prepare. Then set off just before dark and head to Antipatris. You should get there tomorrow morning. Leave the prisoner in the barracks there and come back here. I'll send covering orders for the garrison there to take him the rest of the way. Clear?''

And when the scribe had finished the dictation to the governor he dictated his second message to the Colonel in Antipatris.

Within less than an hour everything was in readiness and I went back to see Paul in his cell.

``They are going to send you to the Governor in Caesarea with a recommendation to release you there. Hopefully we will be able to sail directly from there back to Asia or Europe. There doesn't seem to be a case against you that will stand up in any Roman court.''

``It would be nice to think so,'' responded Paul, ``but I don't think so. The prophecies and visions have been quite clear. I am to be taken to Rome in chains. If I leave Caesarea by ship it will be as a prisoner. But if I can testify in front of both the governor here and the Consuls in Rome it is a small price to pay for being a prisoner - even to be executed! Rome is an apple rotten at its core with maggots and ready for repentance, redemption and salvation.''

``And you are the man to bring it to them,'' I said, mildly challenging.

``Who else?'' he responded, tartly. ``I am appointed missionary to the Gentiles. And who could argue that the Roman consuls are anything except Gentiles and chiefs of the Gentiles? It is to them that I must go and I must preach to them.''

And from that position he would not be budged.

Because of the haste and secrecy of the mission, I and the others of Paul's companions were not allowed to go with him - and indeed, were not allowed out of the prison until after Paul had left that evening.

Loath as I was to be parted from Paul, I recognized that this was the safest strategy and said good-bye to him as he left. He made it to Caesarea early in the morning of the following day, having spent a day sleeping in Antipatris.

I made my way separately back to Caesarea at a more sedate pace with Timothy, Trophimus and some of the others. Titus wanted to stay longer with the brothers at Jerusalem and said there was no hurry - Roman justice moved slowly and it was unlikely that Paul's case would be heard, let alone decided, for months.

It was over a week before I would see Paul again.

18. Felix Defence

AD56 Caesarea

23 years after the crucifixon

Tertullus was a Jewish lawyer versed in Roman law.

``Your excellency, Governor Felix: we owe it to you personally, that we Jews here enjoy lasting peace, and we know that it is due to your foresight that our nation currently enjoys improved living conditions compared to past times.

``While we acknowledge these things with the deepest gratitude, I must beg you to give us a brief hearing with your customary kindness. The simple fact is that we have found this man a pestilential disturber of the peace among the Jews all over the world. He is a ringleader of the Nazarene sect, and he was on the point of desecrating the Temple when we overcame him. But you yourself will soon discover from the man himself all the facts about which we are accusing him.''

Felix was a typically rapacious Roman governor, who saw every situation through a single lens: how could it enrich him personally.

``His desecration of your Temple is neither here nor there as far as I am concerned, except inasmuch as his actions disturb the peace. And yet, by your own account not his actions, but yours, disturbed the peace. We have had words about this before: your religion is at odds with the Pax Romana and if it cannot bend, we will have to break it. The recommendation I have is to release him and, if I understand all parties correctly, he will leave this province and go back to his home province which, again, if I have the correct information - is Cilicia. This would seem to suit all parties well, since he cannot `defile' your Temple if he is five hundred miles away ...''

``Your excellency, this man is a danger wherever he may go. The creed he spouts undermines the Pax Romana by preaching an alternative emperor who wishes to usher in a new Kingdom sweeping away the existing order and replace it with his own order with this man he claims to follow - Jesus of Nazareth - as the uncrowned emperor of the entire world.''

``But am I not right in thinking that you, too, pray for the day when your `God' will come down from his habitation and rip up the world order and replace it with his own Kingdom? In this sense are you and he not on the same side? What then is your point of dissent?''

``It is true, your excellency, that we look for the times when our God will come and cause all men to repent of their sins and come home to righteousness and bring light and mercy to all men. But that does not mean that we wish to support a violent overthrow of the emperor. We accept the separate domains of state and religion and the modus vivendi where you handle the profane affairs of our people and we deal with their spiritual welfare and religious activities.

``And while we continue to accept those who seek out a deeper faith and connection to the Mysteries of the World, we do not aggressively try to undermine the fabric of society in the way that this man does and subvert law-abiding Romans to become freeloaders and debauchers.''

``So, this is your charge against this man: that he is trying to subvert the fabric of Roman society. For his own ends? Or for others? In short, remember the great sobriquet of the lawyer Cicero: cui boni? Who benefits from his disruption of society? If you cannot answer that, I say with the Great Advocate: `you have no case and I move to dismiss with prejudice'.''

``Your excellency is quite astute. That is indeed the most compelling aspect of the whole matter. This man is one of the most self-possessed and arrogant men you will meet. Of course, that in itself is no crime. Many men are such.

``But when you couple it with his actions, it is clear that his motivation is self-aggrandizement and the man that benefits is this man himself as he draws to himself the power and prestige that comes from his setting himself up as the head of this Jesus cult and drawing to him and putting under his power all those poor, weak, defenceless souls who hear his sublime preaching - beware the magic in his speech when he conducts his defence, your excellency; his rhetoric is up there with that of the Great Advocate himself! - he intends to create a force that, spread across the entire empire, will one day receive the message to overthrow the emperor and his cohorts.

``If not stopped, this man will overturn the entire empire.''

``A serious charge indeed. You accuse this man, then of the crime of `Hostis' - of serious treason and being an enemy of the empire. Such a charge, if proved, would of course carry the death penalty, served immediately. This would no doubt suit your ends, but what proof can you offer of such a charge?''

``Your excellency. The proof is all there for the seeing. You will hear it from his own lips when you cross-question him in his defence. He openly preaches that the end times are here; that his leader Jesus, who was himself executed for treason by your predecessor Pontius Pilate, has been brought back to life by God, and that he is just waiting in the wings to sweep back into power, displacing all legitimate authorities.

``That, in the process of preaching this, he has gathered large communities around Asia and in Greece, mainly drawn from Jews and fellow-travellers, who subscribe to his viewpoint and will follow his commands implicitly, and all of whom are implacably opposed to accepting the overlordship of the Roman government system.

``In short, he has the motivation of setting himself - or this Jesus if he is truly alive - as the supreme ruler of the world; he has the capability through the believers he has subverted; and he has the opportunity presented through the resentment felt by many around the empire against his excellency the Emperor and his government.''

``Granted. There is clearly a case here which needs to be investigated and answered. It is also a case which, given that it involves both a charge of Hostis and an alleged Empire-wide conspiracy, may only really be tried in Rome. It may be that our verdict will be that he will be sent to Rome for trial in front of the Emperor. In that case, if you wish to pursue the case, you will need to find the resources to take your prosecution in front of the Emperor. I tell you this now because you will know as I do of the ruinous expense of such a course of action. If you wish to admit now that this is simply a malicious prosection and drop it, I will let you go with no more than a warning to stay away from my courts in future. But if you proceed, you will need to stay the course, however long, drawn-out and expensive it may be. Do you understand? Do you wish to reconsider?''

``No, we do not, your excellency. This man is a danger to all of us and we cannot cease prosecuting him any more than you would be able to cease serving the Emperor faithfully.''

``Very good. So, Paul, eminent citizen of Tarsus in Cilicia, what defence do you have in answer to these charges of Hostis, the most serious crime in the Roman Law Code?''

``As much as my opponent in this case, I am well aware that you have been governor of this nation for many years, and of the peace, prosperity and justice that you have brought us. I feel no reservation therefore in putting the whole of my case in front of you and feel that the facts speak for themselves.

``Since I landed in this port and started to Jerusalem not more that twelve days ago, you can easily verify with the harbour master, the citizens with whom I lodged and others with whom I met that I was here and did not in any way disrupt the peace.

``You can then send to Jerusalem and make enquiries there. I will provide your agents with all the details of places I stayed, people I met and the actions I took. You will see that I have kept a low profile both here and there.

``I was never found arguing with anyone, either in the Temple in Jerusalem, or in the synagogues here, or anywhere else. Neither will you find that I was gathering crowds together in any location. If I was truly trying to gather personal followers for a revolution, would I not do that?

``Likewise, if I was trying to gather an army, would I not be found meeting with subversive types and secretly recruiting them? I defy your agents - or my accusers', for that matter - to find any evidence or witnesses who will support the charges they are now making against me. At least, you will not find any who are still prepared to do so when you threaten them with scourging if you catch them in a lie.

``I will freely admit to you, however, that I do worship the God of our fathers according to the Way which my accusers call a heresy, although in fact I believe in the scriptural authority of both the Law and the Prophets, even as they do. We believe in the same God, the same scriptures and the same prophecy of the End Times. I have the same hope in God which they themselves hold, that there is to be a resurrection of both good men and bad in those final days. With this hope before me I do my utmost to live my whole life with a clear conscience before God and man.

``So, you ask, if not revolution, what would it be that would make me come to Judea? As you wisely note, I am a citizen of Tarsus and Cilicia and have spent the past few years in Greece. It has in fact been many years since I last visited our Temple in Jerusalem. Well, I will tell you the truth, and it is so not sinister that it may even be suspicious.

``As governor, you cannot be ignorant of the issues with drought and famine that have afflicted your province. And I am aware of many of the remedial actions which you have taken to try and alleviate the suffering of your people. And I know that all of those who have benefitted from your wise rule appreciate your efforts and your forethought.

``Well, in my own small way, I was about much the same charitable work. Our brothers in the Way in Asia and Greece had collected a small amount of money which they dedicated to the purpose of buying provisions for the benefit of starving brothers here in Judea. As a man absent for many years, I felt it incumbent upon me to go to the Temple of my Fathers and to discharge a vow of personal service that I had made some months ago. In doing that, I went with a number of brothers who had made similar vows for deliverance from debt. Since I was the vehicle of their discharge, we chose to go to the Temple together.''

``So you freely admit that you brought money here to buy friends and followers?''

``I freely admit that I brought money from Asia to Judea. As far as I am aware that is not a crime. Trophimus - from Ephesus - has all the records of the monies received and disbursed. He is here in my party today. You can obtain from him all the records; they are all open, nothing is hidden. You can then send your agents to track down those who received the money - along with those in Asia who gave it, if so be your desire - and enquire of them of my motivations and the terms of my gift.

``It was in the middle of these religious duties in the Temple that my accusers found me, a man purified in the Temple. I did not raise a mob and I did not start a disturbance. There was, in short, nothing happening except a few men going about their religious duties in the Template until some Jews from Asia came and attacked me.

``In my opinion, if they had a legitimate charge to lay against me, they should have come before you and made their accusation. But wait! At that time, as far as I can tell, the charges they lay against me had nothing to do with the Emperor! They did not accuse me of inciting treason, but of defiling the Temple.

``Now, what, you may ask, does it mean to defile the Temple? First and foremost, I was accused of taking a Gentile into the inner courts of the Temple. Now, when we say `Gentile', I think we can all agree that the Emperor, may he have a long life!, would be classified as Gentile, not Jew. So if I had taken the Emperor into the Temple, that too, would have been defiling the Temple, and they would have stoned him. Am I not right? You know the story of how Pompey came into the Temple with his guards searching for gold - and how the priests of the day screamed sacrilege and would have stoned him.

``In which case, surely, it is they who would be guilty of Hostis, not me. Or are we now saying that it is acceptable to stone Roman citizens - of any rank - without trial?

``So what it comes down to is that they are clearly aggrieved at me for some reason, but not any of the reasons that they have stated. It cannot be that I am plotting against the Empire - for a start, I'm not - and we have established that if anyone were plotting against the Empire, it would be them.

``The competent Colonel Lysias in charge of the Jerusalem garrison investigated the charges and sent his report to you along with my person. When he interviewed me, he was left confused as to what even the charge was against me. You are surely not suggesting that such a one would be confused about the charges to be levelled against one who was actively plotting against Rome? No! He would have empanelled a jury immediately and I would have been crucified as an example before the end of the day!

``If he had felt there would be lesser criminal charges to be levelled against me, he would again have put me on trial himself, or else - as he has eventually done - referred the case to his superiors.

``But in fact his first action was not any of those. He convoked the Jewish religious court and took me for trial before them. Why? Because the *only* crimes he could see that I could possibly be guilty of were religious ones under the Jewish faith, and those are `crimes' which do not come under his competence. In other words, he recognized that I had done nothing criminal under Roman law, and this was purely a local, religious matter, for which the Jewish religious court could recommend lesser sentences but not confinement or the death penalty.

``This then, is what happened in front of the Sanhedrin. I was accused of defiling the Temple. I provided my defence - a simple one, that I did not - and they did not have, and could not produce, any credible evidence that I did. And that I was on trial for one thing, and one thing only, which was to preach that the God of Israel had shown, through the infallible proof of raising a man from the dead, that he had come in his power to show us the way forward in Truth.

``You see these men arrayed in front of you, accusing me? This is not the whole of the Sanhedrin. Reasonable enough, you may say; it is an expensive business sending dignitaries across the country and one or two can do the job of thirty.

``True enough, but in the same way that the Roman Republic had its *boni*, *optimates* and *populares*, we Jews have Sadducees and Pharisees. All these men are Sadducees? So what, I hear you ask.

``I am a Pharisee.

``As a Pharisee, I believe that in the final days all men will be raised bodily from the grave. Now that body will not be the same body that is put in the ground, any more than the wheat which you harvest is the same wheat you plant as seed. But we will be raised up in bodies incorruptible before our God. And I believe that all men, both good and bad, will be raised up to appear before God as I appear before you. And then all will be judged.

``As Sadducees, they believe none of this.

``So what? A trifling religious difference. Not so if I preach - and I do! - that one has already led the way by appearing amongst us, bodily resurrected by God. If true - and it is! - then it completely undercuts their position that this is *simply not possible*.

``For, if one man be raised from the dead, _how is it possible to say there is no resurrection of the dead_?

``And thus I must be suppressed. By violence - they tried that in the Temple; by plotting - they tried that as I came here; or by outright lying about my actions - as they do in front of you today.

``Here I rest my defence, and request an immediate verdict of *ABSOLVO*."

19. Caesarea

AD56 Caesarea

23 years after the crucifixion

Paul's defence was masterful to watch.

He had been dragged into the judgment hall in chains, and lined up opposite half a dozen members of the Sanhedrin, all of whom, Timothy told me, were part of the Sadducee party who had insisted on Paul's guilt when the Sanhedrin had split on party lines at Paul's previous trial.

He was looking a bit the worse for wear after a week in detention, but the fire was still burning deep down inside those eyes that I remembered so well from the first time I had heard him preach: the burning passion of the Spirit within him.

They had organized their case cleverly, well knowing that a Roman governor would be not the least interested in Jewish theology, argued that Paul was plotting against the Empire. A charge no governor could possibly ignore, and many would have taken the safer option of just executing him `in case'.

Felix allowed them to make their case, prosecuted by their patron Tertullus who, although to the Jews was `just a lawyer', was, by dint of being a Roman citizen, outranked all of them in the eyes of a regularly-formed Roman court.

He was well-versed in the forms of Roman law and practice, and presented probably the strongest case that could be presented against Paul in the Premio Actio. He argued that Paul had caused a riot and was plotting the overthrow of the Empire.

But Paul's defence - by harping on about the petty jealousies at play, and downplaying the number of riots which he had caused over his career - managed to make it sound like a very minor religious squabble. And advanced a long line of witnesses for the Governor to consider in his defence.

When Paul called for the immediate verdict after the Premio Actio - in other words, suggesting that his opponents had so failed to make their case that they should not be allowed to proceed, I could almost see him itching to do so. Romans are very efficient with their justice - not always just, perhaps, but very efficient - and to deal with the case promptly by dismissing the charges and then banning Paul from ever returning to Judea seemed very appealing to Felix.

But more appealing to Felix than justice was money. And he had a good nose for where there was money to be made in court cases.

Obviously the practice of bribing officials for verdicts was illegal; and therefore extremely widespread. This case had all the elements of a valuable case: the plaintiffs clearly had funds; the defendant appeared to be well-connected too. Nobody would really criticize Felix if he overreacted and put a man to death if he might be plotting against the Empire; and yet the evidence was so flimsy as to be non-existent and so an acquittal would also be a completely reasonable verdict. In such a situation, a bidding war would decide the outcome.

Eventually Felix spoke.

``I cannot at this time see that the prosecution has a case, and I am tempted to move as the prisoner requests for an instant dismissal; especially since, as he points out, that was also the verdict of my Colonel in Jerusalem who was on the scene at the time of the original incident.

``At the same time, these charges - although unsubstantiated - are of a very serious nature. I would not like to be the man who let Spartacus escape.

``I am going to adjourn this trial for a week. In the meantime, I will send for Colonel Lysias and some of the other witnesses whom you have named on both sides. When they arrive, we will begin the Segundo Actio. But be warned! Your evidence had better be compelling against this man, for I am well aware of your dissentions and divisions, and if your only charge against this man transpires to be that he is a member of this Jesus-sect you are going to make me very angry! And you do not want to be dealing with an angry governor for the next year or for however long the Senate continues to prorogue me!''

One of the reasons Felix knew so much about the internal disputes between the various sects of the Jews, including the Way, was that he had married a Jewess whose esteemed father had been made a Roman citizen for services to the Empire and had taken one of the then-Emperor's names in respect and homage and become `Drusus'. In accordance with Roman tradition his daughter Rebecca was known in Roman circles as `Drusilla', in much the same way that Saul was known as Paul or Simon the Apostle was known as Peter.

When she had heard about the trial of Paul, she remarked that she had heard much of this man and his preaching of holiness and expressed a desire to hear his defence. Although contrary to normal Roman practice, women were not actually *barred* from appearing in a court, and Felix was able - as he had in times past - to argue that her expert knowledge, combined with lack of bias - made her an invaluable aid to him in getting to the bottom of the case.

When the week was up, and the various witnesses had presented themselves to Felix' clerk, the trial was resumed.

``I say again, that the only `crime' for which I am being persecuted is the crime of saying out loud that God loves us, God has forgiven us, and that he sent Jesus into the world to suffer for us, to die for us, and then to rise again to foreshadow for us the things that are yet to come.

``Let us be clear. I am not saying that here and now anybody should rise up and oppose the Empire. But all things come to an end, and the times of this world are passing away and the end times are coming when we shall all be resurrected and brought in front of God for judgment as I appear before you today. In those days, there will not be Romans and non-Romans, Greeks and Jews, Metics and Persians. We will all just be people in front of God. And when called to the bar of justice, what will we answer?

``There are many possible answers.

``One may say `I did as I pleased, without reference to Law or Man, and I stand today as I lived, confident in my power and glory.' Woe to that man in that day, for he shall see what it means to live by power.

``A Jew may say, `From my youth, I have kept the law. I have fasted on fast days, feasted on feast days, eaten the things approved, avoided the things not approved, kept myself free from pollution, and stoned the defiler.' That man must be careful in that day, for while the outward appearance may be of piety, God does not look simply on the outward appearance as man does, but will look deep inside him and will know the contents of his heart.

``And God will ask him, `and did you love your fellow-man?' And when he confidently says, `Yes, Lord!' the Lord will show unto him images from his life: Gentiles spurned, corrupt flesh unhealed, the poor ignored, in order that he might maintain his purity and status. Woe, I say, unto that man in the day of judgment!

``But what will I say in that day? I will say with humility, `many errors have I made, O God, many sins have I committed, for which I ask your mercy. But I have seen the One whom you sent, and I have seen what it is to live a life of goodness and mercy, and while I may have failed, I have tried to follow in the footsteps of He that you sent. I beg your forgiveness.' Will I be saved? I believe so, but until *that day* none of us can truly know what will happen.

``You ask me of my preaching. It is very simple. I will summarize for you.

``Throughout the ages, men have come who have seen the plan of God. I am sure this is the same in Rome as it is in Greece and as it is in Judea. It is to our credit that while we have generally despised such men, we have listened to them.

``God sends these men to tell us his plan and to make the world a better place, in the same way that the Emperor sends governors to the provinces to regulate their affairs.

``But the prophets in Judea do not come with political power, or with prestige, or with wealth. They are poor men, who wander the deserts and the wilderness preaching what they know to whoever will listen. Since those who most want to hear the message are the poor and the needy, large groups follow such men. Men with the symbols of this world are understandably afraid of such followings, thinking that surely revolution will follow in their wake.

``In our time, one came amongst us who had all the properties of the old-fashioned prophet, but with one added feature: he came directly from God to send us a `final notice of eviction'. God's message was this: `wise up now or face the final judgment unprepared'. And that judgment is coming now.

``Of this man the powerful and privileged were afraid. I shudder to say it, but I was one of those men. I persecuted his followers when they came to Antioch where I lived at the time. And by plotting against him - as these men now plot against me - they were able to convince Pontius Pilate to crucify him!

``But God could not tolerate that his Great Messenger should be done to death! And God reached into that lonely tomb and raised him up alive! And not just alive, alive in his own body!

``And in this body of resurrection he appeared to many who had known him before his crucifixion - and others, as myself, who had not personally known him. And those who believed, believed with all their heart, that this man was sent by God as his personal messenger were changed! In a heartbeat, as they saw the reality that was God's Truth, all these men were infused with the Holy Spirit.

``And in that heartbeat, your entire outlook changes. Petty concerns - for status, wealth or power - all seem bankrupt before the grand vision of God's design. You have no choice but to give up such feeble pursuits - the hoarding of wealth; the jealous guarding of power - and move on out into the world to preach the coming Kingdom of God and the need for all men to repent *now*, while there is still time, to give up their wealth, power and prestige, and to accept with humility the instruction of God.

``And since that day ...''

``Enough!'' snapped Felix, obviously agitated, in part on his own account, but more so on the effect he saw in his wife's face. ``This trial is adjourned again. You are to be placed under house arrest with Philip, a known member of your Jesus-sect in this city and to be available at any moment to return here for further investigation.

``I am clear in my own mind that you are not unreasonably plotting against the Empire - and cannot find you guilty of Hostis - but I fear this new doctrine which you preach. I will consider and gather further evidence.

``Adjourned!!''

20. Philip

AD56 Caesarea

23 years after the crucifixion

At least Paul was out of the prison cell.

As was normal with Roman justice, Paul, as a well-to-do citizen of some standing, was not confined to the public cells while on remand, but was lodged with a reputable member of society, in this case Philip. Officially, Philip was responsible for Paul's confinement - and also his welfare - but in practice the system worked not by relying on any kind of force or restraint, but by depending on the desire of the incarcerated individual to protect the reputation of his `patron' - the man who stood up for him in court.

There was no requirement for such a remanded man to earn a living - he was forbidden to leave the house after all - but for Paul the idea of being a burden on a family of limited resources and dedicated to spreading the word of God was anathema. He insisted on picking up a trade and rapidly found out what work was being done in the brotherhood and had rapidly attached himself to a family of tentmakers responsible for kitting out the Syrian legions with marching tents. These two legions, facing the Parthians across the Euphrates, constituted about ten thousand men of all ranks and responsibilities. Each decury of ten men shared a tent, a grand total of a thousand tents, and not of any small size. Of these, usually a couple of hundred needed replacing in any given season, and others were brought in for repair. Much of the work was handled out of the main cities of Damascus and Antioch, but in line with the standard Imperial practice of trying to keep everybody in the Empire happy, work was spread out around the province.

Thus Paul was able to bring in a small income and pay Philip for his lodging. And he commented that, as prisons went, and he felt he was something of an expert, this was one of the best he had encountered.

For the first few weeks, I was elsewhere in the city; of course, as a doctor and not confined to Philip's house, I had no difficulty in plying my trade, earning a living and paying for my own lodging in order to avoid overcrowding Philip. During this time, Felix did not call Paul back to answer any more charges or to challenge him over his defence. The case had gone quiet, and, like so many others across the Empire, it seemed that it might just linger on until Paul died a natural death. Surprisingly, for a man who chafed at every delay in promulgating the Word, Paul seemed remarkably calm, as if in possession of the plan God had laid out for him.

One day I was at dinner at Philip's house, usually a riotous affair of preaching, glorifying God and prophesying. But on this occasion, it was relatively quiet and orderly. During a gap in the conversation, I ventured a personal question.

``Tell me, Philip, how did you become involved with the Way?''

``Well, now, that's a funny story, particularly with your friend Paul the Persecutor at the same table,'' he said and laughed. ``It actually all started when Jesus was preaching in the hill towns of Galilee. I was one of `the seventy' that he saw potential in and sent out through the towns announcing his presence in the fields and drawing out the crowds.

``Obviously, we preached the message he brought; not in the same way of course - what we had to say was a pale imitation of the drama he brought to the message on those hillsides, but even so, some of the miracles we saw happen! I remember one time as we were walking into a town a child fell and broke his leg. My partner - we always went around in pairs - just fell down to the ground, straightened it out, and raised him up! He did that in the full sight of the child's parents - well, you can imagine they came out to hear more!

``Then came that terrible week in Jerusalem. You can't imagine the fanfare we had drummed up by the time we entered the city! All the prophecies were fulfilled, and everybody knew that he was coming into the city and all the followers he had acquired over the previous months were there shouting `Hosanna!' and waving palm fronds they had hacked down off trees.

``Well, you can imagine how the Sanhedrin reacted. They went ballistic. I mean, this was passover week and the city was buzzing and then the rumours spread that Jesus was going to bring in the millenium right then and there in the Temple - he was going to sit in the Chair of David and the Kingdom of David would come and the Romans would be expelled ...

``The leaders of the Sanhedrin plotted together with the Roman guards to do away with him. Their plans nearly fell through when the Governor decided that, whatever he might be accused of, it was not really his intention to overthrow the legitimate Roman government.

``But then, of course, it really backfired when, after that miserable weekend when we all believed that Jesus was dead and the whole experience had been an illusion, he came among us at dinner that evening - alive!''

``You were there?'' I asked. I'd known when I met Peter and James that they had been there, but in the time I'd known Philip he'd not mentioned that he was a *genuine* eyewitness of the Risen Christ. Not that I really doubted that Paul had met Jesus, but somehow he always described it in such a way that it always felt more like a vision than a literal meeting. And so much time had elapsed by then.

``Yes, I was there. I wasn't there at the tomb when Mary and Mary went to finish the embalming that morning; and I wasn't there when the apostles met to decide what to do and Mary and Mary arrived just before he did; but then the word went out to all the followers who hadn't left Jerusalem that he had said he would be there for the evening meal. And he was!''

I was floored for questions to ask. What do you ask someone who's just told you that he was a contemporary eye-witness of the event that has come to define your life. All the more with Paul there, who had suffered so much because of that one event. What was there to say? I decided to move on.

``Then what happened?''

``We saw him a few more times over the next few weeks; he seemed to just come and go. And others saw him too: some recognized him; some didn't.

``And then he ascended. I'm sure you've heard the stories about that from Paul. He wasn't there of course - he was still in Antioch at the time, but he's heard all about it. One moment he was there, all shining and bright ... and then he was brighter ... and then he was gone, never to be seen again - except by Paul, here.''

And that story I knew. I wanted Philip's stories.

``Well, after that, we couldn't help but preach what we had seen and lived. I mean that literally; it would have been agony to try and resist the power of the Spirit. And that was contagious - you've probably felt the same yourself. When the word is inside you, you just have to let it out.

``And so, much as the authorities tried to put a lid on it and suppress it, the Word just grew and grew. They put Peter and James in prison for a while. But in the same way that the grave could not hold Jesus, the prison could not hold Peter and James - they literally just walked out one night!

``Well, you can imagine that after a while, you have a large community all working and living together, sharing all their material wealth and needs, and the senior group doing most of the work of preaching the Word and demonstrating the Way, there was a certain amount of discord about how this `shared' wealth was being distributed. And, time and again, issues came up to Peter and James that they felt they couldn't really deal with: they would quote Jesus' remark `who made me a judge among you?' and ask them to pray and sort it out.

``But by the time there were three or four thousand of us, that had passed the bounds of practicality. And somebody said to Peter that if *he* didn't want to deal with it, he should possibly find somebody - or somebodies - that did.

``And so they appointed seven of us to be `deacons' - judges if you will, or arbiters. The key point is that we were supposed to channel the Spirit not in the growth of the Way but in the harmony of the Way. And we did.

``One of the other deacons was my partner from our journeys around Galilee - Stephen was his name. A truly amazing man. And I'm sure you know his story too. Well, eventually, the rulers plotted against him, too, and I've heard Paul say that he was in on that plot, feeling that some of the pressure in Antioch would be reduced if the most visible leadership in Jerusalem were taken out.

``And so they arrested him, and stoned him.

``Paul was pleased, of course, and promptly moved on the converts in Antioch and then moved on to Damascus to try and deal with the growing strength of the Way there - and you know what happened with Ananias, the leader of the Way there.

``In Jerusalem, a veritable storm broke loose. Temple guards went around the city to the various houses we were living in, pulling people out in the middle of the night and locking them up. As now, they argued they were collaborating with the Romans, trying to avoid a revolution.

``We decided to scatter. The apostles stayed put; they felt that either they were above persecution or that they would be protected by their faith in Jesus. As deacons, we were instructed to take a segment of the faithful with us wherever we went and to guide them.

``I headed north, and wound up in Samaria. To this day, you can go there and find a group of the Way, living in peace and harmony, who will be able to trace their presence there to that persecution. They never returned of course; and they became the kernel of a great outpouring of faith and preaching in that part of the world.

``Again, on the one hand, the rulers managed to achieve the objective of breaking up the large, dangerous group of subversives in Jerusalem; but on the other, all they succeeded in doing was spreading them out across the whole of Judea and Samaria, and often further afield.

``And as they spread, they would win converts, and then the apostles would come, and preach, and show the wonder of the coming Kingdom of Heaven, and the Holy Spirit would come down and spread among the new communities. And so the Word spread over the whole of the country.

``And far from alleviating Paul's problems in Syria, many of the refugees fled there.

``But, of course, by then, Paul had changed sides.''

``I'd seen the light,'' corrected Paul.

``Of course,'' said Philip.

It was a couple of weeks later before I could hear the next instalment of Philip's story. My medical practice, much like the early Way, was growing rapidly and I felt I owed it to all those brothers with whom my wealth was shared to take all the work I could.

But one evening I was back at Philip's house and it was relatively quiet; most of the household had gone to bed and Philip and Paul were seated in the garden looking at the pool.

``So why did you leave Samaria?''

``The authorities were happy enough to let the Way flourish in a limited way; the threat came from our preachers and demonstrators who were actually making a difference. The potency of our preaching and demonstration showed up what a false religion the priests were now peddling - if there was ever any truth to it. They tell others what they have to do, and they make a living from their failure to do it. The undoubted holiness of our followers is its own defence, but for the preachers, how can we possibly avoid criticizing the sterility of the official cult?

``So they trumped up charges against me, and tried to arrest me. Then one evening, much like this, I was in my house in Samaria and an angel came to me and told me to head south to Gaza and I would meet a man who was looking for me.

``It was a bizarre experience, and it felt much like running away. How was I supposed to meet this man? It made no sense, but I had learnt that faith made all things possible - how often I have heard that; how often I have *said* that; and yet how hard it is to truly *live* it! But I did on that occasion.

``I started making my way south, and I made it to the main coast road, figuring that I might be able to find a good soul who would give me a lift down to Gaza.

``And I saw a chariot come up, obviously from a wealthy man, a leader from some nation, and I thought, it is quite impossible that this man would help an itinerant preacher on his journey. But the Spirit moved me and I ran up, determined to ask him.

``And as I approached, I saw he had a scroll in his hands, and I heard the words coming from his mouth as he read from the scroll. And I'm sure you're very familiar with the words.

`` `He was led as a sheep to the slaughter, and like a lamb silent before his shearer; he never opened his mouth. Humiliated, he was treated unjustly. And who will recount his story? For he was killed and taken away.'

``I was surprised, to be sure. One of the canonical prophecies about Jesus, coming from this man I felt impelled to approach. And then the Spirit opened my eyes and I saw: this *was* the man the Spirit wanted me to meet!

``And the right words just issued from my mouth without any conscious thought on my part: `You read the prophet Isaiah; do you understand what you read?'

`` `I don't know,' he replied. `Was the prophet writing about himself? Did he die this terrible death? Or was it somebody else for whom he predicted these things?'

``And so I told him. I told him how fortunate he was that he lived in this generation when all these prophecies had come true. And he listened, and the Holy Spirit spoke through me. And he believed.

``And as we went down to Gaza through the desert, he pointed to one of the reservoirs that the Romans had built, and said, `Is this not water? What is there to stop me being baptized? I see the error of my ways, and I hear the Good News of the Messiah.'

``And I baptized him there, and we went our separate ways.''

``And then?'' I asked.

``Many things,'' he smiled. ``But basically, I worked my way up the coast, preaching and healing until I came to Caesarea, and here I have stayed, preaching the Word and nurturing our community up to the current day.

``But if you want to know more, you should search out the others. I hear you've met Peter, but he is generally too busy to talk about the old days; he is mainly focused on the work. James is much the same.

``But if you go back to Jerusalem you can meet Mary and Mary, and hear about The First Day. And there are many others there who will tell you their stories of meeting Jesus; there are some quite spectacular stories of conversions - Mary's for a start!''

And the more I thought about it, the more I was determined to take his advice.

21. Jerusalem

AD57 Jerusalem

24 years after the crucifixion

It took me a while to make it there.

Paul continued to remain in custody, relatively pleasant though it was being under house arrest in Philip's house, working and preaching with the others.

But as one year rolled into the next I found the time to take the journey down to Jerusalem, remembering as I went the same journey Paul and I had taken the previous year - before he had been arrested.

Philip had provided me with basic background information about a number of people with whom he felt I should talk, and whose stories would be interesting to hear.

Top of this list - and apparently the most interesting of them all - was Mary from the Galilean hill town of Magdala. According to Philip, she had had a colourful reputation there before meeting Jesus, at which point her life changed direction.

It's a two day journey each way from Caesarea to Jerusalem, and I couldn't afford to be away too long, so I had about six days in Jerusalem to track down and talk to all the people I wanted to see. Fortunately, the year before I had learned some of the geography of the place and met a number of people that would be useful to me.

As I approached from the north, the mountain - Mount Zion - on which the city stands reared up before me. As a year before, I began the arduous climb up towards the summit.

Mary lived in a house on a narrow street not far from the temple with a number of other members of the Way. As with all members, work, money, food and preaching all overlapped each other. The house held six members and Mary was not at home when I arrived. I was shown up onto the roof terrace where there was a shaded sitting area and drank water with my hosts until she returned home.

I was immediately struck with both her grace and humility. This woman was one of the leaders of the Way in Jerusalem, but unlike Peter or Philip did not seem burdened by the responsibility of that role. It sat lightly on her, and when she smiled at me I felt the grace of God descend on me. I rose to greet her.

``Mary, your humble servant is Luke, associate of the evangelist Paul.''

``Why so formal, good man? Of course I know of you; I saw you last year with Peter and Paul at the Temple.''

But I had not noticed here; strange, since her presence now seemed hard to ignore.

``How can I be of assistance? I am told you come to me on Philip's recommendation?''

How to explain? I didn't really know myself, except that Philip's story had made me interested in knowing more about more of the people who had known Jesus - and maybe even to come closer to knowing Jesus himself. I did my best to put it into words.

``How delightful! You want to know how I converted from the heathen temptress to a servant of God! Well, it is a simple tale, and I'm sorry to say you'll be distressed at how boring it is by the time I've finished.

``But yes, I knew Jesus. As well as anyone else, I suppose - for much of his ministry I was with him, along with `the twelve'. A number of others accompanied him as well - you should probably talk to Susanna; Joanna has died now, of course.

``Unlike John, Jesus was never a `wild man'. He was, you might say, boringly normal, except in one regard: you couldn't even hope to keep a secret from him. Let's face it: in his presence, you couldn't even hope to keep a secret from yourself.

``He had these penetrating eyes. He would look at you and ... it would seem like he looked right through you. And when I met him, well, I'm sure you've heard that when I met him I was supporting myself the old-fashioned way, taking money for being with men. And I'd heard that this man was in the neighbourhood, so I thought I'd go and see what he was up to. I mean, holy men are generally like others, they have needs ...

``I was living in Magdala at the time. I grew up there, although I think I was born a little further north. But basically I lived there up until I met Jesus; then I followed him until he was crucified and then I settled here.

``But I'm getting ahead of myself. I had heard he was preaching nearby, so I went to hear him. And I was amazed. The things he had to say - well, they weren't the normal drivel you hear from these men. He *cared*. I don't know about you, but generally when you hear holy men, their first interest is in getting you to believe in whatever they have going on and only secondarily do their care about what you have going on.

``But Jesus was different. He would preach and tell stories, yes, but he would walk through the crowds that followed him and meet with each of them as individuals and greet them and talk to them and address their needs. When people came needing healing, he would heal them; when they came with problems, he would address them. When people asked for help, he would give it.

``But never for free. The price of meeting Jesus was change. And for some the price of change was too high and they would walk away, refusing the gifts he brought because of the price he charged. And such a one was I.

``I heard Jesus preach and I dismissed his words as words. They sounded fair and, as I say, he clearly cared. And then he came up to me and said, and I remember this to this day, `Much sin weighs you down, young lady, much sin. But, remember, you can at once put down that load and start again. Remember that any woman who wishes can be born again; born not of flesh seeking its end in flesh, but born of the spirit, seeking the Spirit!'

``As I'm sure you can imagine, nobody wants to hear *that* from a preacher. I felt unclean, judged, found wanting. And I stormed off home, and my `mother' asked me what was wrong, and I told her what had happened. She shrugged it off: there would always be do-gooders and I should just ignore them.

``And I did my best to do just that. And I moved on with my life and making my living as best I could. I was young then, and there was no shortage of men who would pay handsomely to be with me.

``And then one day I heard that Jesus was visiting with one of the esteemed Rabbis in Magdala. And I burst into tears.

``At that very moment it struck me: the thing that stood between me and what I actually wanted to be was my pride. My pride that he had humbled by showing me who I really was. And I gathered up my cloak and a jar of perfumed oil that I used to prepare myself for clients and went straight over to the Rabbi's house.

``How I made it past the doorman I don't now recall. Probably he had been a client at some point and thought that I would repay him for his generosity.

``Jesus was there at the table and I knew what I had to do; what I should have done when I first met him. I washed his feet and dried them with my hair; I took the perfume and applied it, right there at the table with the Rabbi looking on, horrified - he knew who I was, of course, and would have no dealings with me.

``Jesus looked at his expression and actually laughed. What a wonderful sound! Not a harsh, mocking laugh, but one that saw through everything in the situation and took us all with him.

`` `It's all very well to laugh, Jesus,' said the Rabbi. `But do you know who this is that is perfuming your body? And how she pays for that perfume?'

`` `But of course, I do,' he replied. `I met her the other day in the fields. You, I noticed, were not there with your flock. And I spoke to her and told her what she needed to do in order to obtain forgiveness of her sins, many though they may be.

`` `And at the time, she balked at my offer. Sins may be heavy to carry, but to lay them down can sometimes be even harder. But you see her now, sealing her bargain of repentance. You ask after the perfume; could she give any stronger token of her change of heart than that the essential tool of her trade - that which makes her desirable to others - she is giving away to a man who has no need of it?

`` `Consider this, if you will. My task here is not to congratulate those fortunate enough to be able to live lives of holiness, but rather to recall those who have sinned. It is much like a moneylender who has clients who are in debt and he knows cannot of their own volition repay the debts.

`` `If he has two clients, one of whom is just lightly in debt, while the other is heavily in debt, and he says to both of them that they are forgiven, how will they react?

`` `The one who is deeply in debt will shout for joy and fall at his feet and kiss him and promise him anything within his power; the other will be grateful to be sure, but will still have a secret thought that maybe, given a little more time, he could have repaid this debt.

`` `Such ingratitude can be a sore that never needs to be lanced but nevertheless continues to abrade.

`` `This woman has seen the weight of her sin, and has chosen to unload it. Her repentenance is forever and she has seen the Way of Truth.

`` `Have you?'

``The Rabbi was shocked. To see himself placed below me on a scale of holiness was beyond his ability to comprehend. But by the end of that evening, two souls had been saved and written into the book of life.

``If you want to meet those whom Jesus saved, you should certainly talk to Nicodemus.''

Certainly I should, but I was here to talk to Mary, and she was, allegedly, the person who had first seen Jesus alive and well after he had been first crucified and then resurrected - to Paul, the central act of his life.

``To Paul, it probably would be. To me, the central act of his life was when he looked at me, a woman beneath anyone's notice. And freely forgave me of all my sins. Compared to that, raising himself from the dead hardly seems to signify. I can see why others, who never had a personal experience of Jesus would see it differently.

``But yes, I was there that morning. I woke up early - truth be told, I'd really not slept either night after Mary (his mother) and I, along with Joseph, Nicodemus and the rest had placed his body in Joseph's grave. Anyway, when it started to hint at becoming light - the moment, in short, that it was acceptable to move - I went out and set off for the tomb.

``When I arrived, the sky was glowing but it wasn't quite dawn yet. Everything was misty and washed-out. I knew the way - I hadn't thought of really anything else for the past day and a half - and I walked there almost in a trance.

``All of which meant that when I arrived, I just couldn't immediately place what I was seeing. Some have said since then that I didn't see what I've said I saw - but I certainly know what I experienced.

``The last thing that we had done was to roll the stone across the entrance to the tomb. I wasn't so foolish as to think that I could move it by myself - it had taken all our combined strength to put it in place - but I was ready to wait until the others arrived. Since I hadn't been able to sleep, I knew I was early and expected to have to wait until the others arise. But when I was close enough, I realized that the stone had already been removed.

``I couldn't immediately imagine how that had been done - but it occurred to me that Joseph could have brought some help and they could have arrived before me. So I walked into the tomb to start working on the enbalming.

``But there was no body there!''

As she said it, I could see the expression on her face reflecting the inner turmoil she had felt as she relived the experience once again. For all Paul's preaching of the risen Christ - passionate as it seems when he's delivering it - it pales compared to the intense emotion this woman must have felt in the moment of the act's accomplishment. I was almost transported with her back to the site of the tomb. I made a mental note to visit the tomb myself - not that I expected to have the same emotionally transforming experience.

``I looked around, but I couldn't see Joseph either. Or anyone else. But the temporary linen graveclothes that we had wrapped Jesus in were lying there on the plinth. It made no sense.

``I stepped back outside and into the slowly dawning light. As I did, I saw Joanna arriving but I had no words. I just gestured into the tomb. She went in and came out again with the same look of shock on her face that I must have had. We hadn't even begun to figure out what to say to each other when the angels appeared and said that Jesus was risen and reminded us of the prophecies - some that he had made himself - that his journey to Jerusalem would end in death, but at the same time not end until all the world had heard his name.

``I can't claim that I understood everything in that moment, but I understood one thing very clearly: this story was not over in the way that I had been thinking it had been since he was crucified. In some sense - a sense not clear to me yet - he was still alive and at large in the world.

``I didn't know what to do, but fortunately Joanna had a clearer head. She said that while the apostles were still in hiding, she knew where Peter was at least - because he had spent the Sabbath in her house. We decided to go back there and seek his advice. You have to understand that at the time it was not clear what was going on - it wasn't the way it sounds when you know the whole story.

``Well, we went back to Joanna's house. I couldn't even begin to catalogue all the emotions that were running through me. On the one hand, I was elated - I couldn't really process what the angels had told me, but I was excited that the story might not be over; on the other hand, Jesus was gone and I had no idea where; then again, I had no idea what was going to happen next or how to make anybody believe me.

``When we arrived at Joanna's, it was fully dawn. We weren't the only ones who knew that Peter was there, and most of the disciples had gathered by that time. We made our report, and most of them just dismissed it as foolishness. But Peter seemed somehow struck dumb by what we had said, and then, in the middle of the hubbub and commotion, seemed to come to life.

`` `He is risen you say? In accordance with the prophecy? The tomb is open?'

``I nodded agreement to all these questions. And then before I could blink he was out of the door and running to the tomb to see for himself.

``He was much more sober when he returned. He walked in slowly, deep in thought. The other apostles looked at him questioningly.

`` `There can be no doubt that the tomb is open,' he said. `And I saw no evidence of Jesus inside other than the discarded graveclothes. No angels appeared to me, but they have delivered their message, so they probably have no need to remain.

``Jesus appeared to us that evening when we were at dinner.

``We had just sat down when there was a knock on the door. Not just any knock but an insistent knock. Cleopas and David were there, looking agitated.

`` `What is it?' Peter asked. `Have you heard that the tomb is empty? Do you know anything?'

`` `Of course the tomb is empty!' Cleopas exclaimed. `Jesus is risen! We saw him this morning!' And he told us his story - if you want to hear it, you should ask him for it - it is again a fascinating tale!

``But he was in the middle of this, and we were starting to break bread when there was a sudden hush, like an intake of breath, and all the candles fluttered. And then ... and then ... then, there he was! Jesus himself, in our midst!

``And he was there in his body - like Paul preaches - the bodily resurrection of Jesus was accomplished. And he sat down with us as he had so often before and shared our meal of bread and fish and honey. And then he explained everything to us - and everything he had ever said suddenly became clear, almost as if somebody had lifted a veil from over our eyes.

``And then he disappeared as mysteriously as he had appeared. And I think you know the rest.

``But that day will always stand out as the most amazing experience of my life - even compared to the day he healed me!''

22. Zaccheus

AD57 Jerusalem

24 years after the crucifixion

My list was growing.

Mary had pointed me to a number of other people I wanted to talk to, especially those who had been there on `the critical day'. While I had heard Paul preach, been baptised and received my portion of the Holy Spirit, I still had not physically met Jesus or had an out-of-body experience directly with him - in the way Paul had. To meet such people inspired me and filled me with awe; somehow they seemed more closely connected to the Way than I was. I wanted to meet them, hear their stories and, increasingly, *record* their stories.

From the time I had first starting collecting and recording Paul's stories of Jesus, the idea of a complete narrative of this remarkable passage of events had been growing. But now with Paul trapped in Caesarea and unable to continue his direct preaching, the written word seemed ever more important. Not a week went by without messages arriving from one church or another on some matter of doctrine, discipline or how to interact with the outside world and Paul was forever dictating responses, shepherding his various flocks in the Way.

But much as I wanted to meet Cleopas and hear of his walk with Jesus on the day of the resurrection, my next task was to follow up with the next lead that Philip had given me, an interesting man named Zaccheus.

Jesus had offended the establishment by any number of actions that he had taken, but one of the most serious was by failing to recognize the holiness of the established order and their superiority in this regard to the lower orders - in particular prostitutes such as Mary of Magdala and tax-collectors such as Zaccheus.

It was all but a given in Jesus' time that any cooperation with the Romans was betraying the people of Judea. And nothing raised more hackles than the taxation system. Not only were the taxes going to pay the oppressors to continue oppressing the people, but the way in which the taxes were collected - with the *publicani*, the tax collectors bidding for a certain sum from the Roman treasury and then actually collecting more than that to ensure they collected a substantial profit, and then enforcing that collection with the assistance of the selfsame Roman soldiers - was not only a violation of Jewish law, but caused direct resentment.

Zaccheus had been a tax collector, and one of the more notorious ones, extorting the people of Jericho whose taxes he was responsible for collecting and making a significant profit while ruining many reputable locals.

When Jesus had come to Jericho - shortly before his final entry into Jerusalem - he had been greeted with wild cheering in the streets. By this time, he had become famous and everybody wanted to see him. When the leaders of the local synagogues had heard he was coming, they prepared a delegation to meet him, but Jesus had apparently ignored this delegation and chosen to meet with Zaccheus instead. Philip had hinted that the story was deeper than that, and went ot Jesus' declared mission to rescue the lost sheep of Israel, and I wanted to hear his story first hand.

Philip had given me a letter of introduction and I had sent a messenger to arrange a convenient time for the meeting, so that is where I went next.

After completing the customary formalities, I asked after his story.

``You have to understand that, by this time, the word was that Jesus was going to Jerusalem in order to claim the kingdom of David his ancestor.

``And the assumption was, that the moment he did that, the country would rise up and the Romans would be expelled. And obviously, that would not be good for anybody who was found to be collaborating with the Romans. I naturally assumed that if Jesus were to rise up and throw off the Roman yoke, I would be killed in the revolution.

``Naturally, I wanted to see this man for myself: was he likely to be a revolutionary? Was he somebody with whom I could do a deal? Should I stop his planned revolution by plotting against him?

``It almost seems unreal thinking about it now. What was I thinking? I can hardly imagine. Probably you're used to Paul talking that way about his transformational experience - how can you relate to the person you were before that kind of experience? It changes you so fundamentally that even trying to imagine yourself back there takes all your creativity. How, you ask yourself, could anybody have been so ignorant and foolish?

``I obviously couldn't join the delegation of dignitaries; they were all holy people who had rank and prestige in the local community. On the contrary, I was hated and despised by all, even the poor. Or to be more precise, *especially* the poor, since many of them were poor precisely because of me.

``Likewise, I couldn't really just mingle with the crowds, because they largely hated me.

``But outside the windows of my house, there was a large tree - a sycamore, I think it was - and I was able to climb out into it. From there, I could look down on the crowds and the procession as it came into the town, and the big meeting as this would-be-King met with the high and mighty of Jericho.

``But it never happened. We had all imagined a well-ordered procession of pomp and glory coming into the city - the way the Greeks or Romans would do it. Come to that, probably the way the Maccabees would do it if they were around today. Certainly the way Herod would do it.

``Instead of that, a group of travellers came in through the city gates, almost surprised and apologetic that they were causing us trouble by being out in the streets on a hot day.

``You could tell instantly which one was Jesus, and he defied expectations as well. I'd been out to see John preaching, and he was all fire-and-brimstone, wild-eyed; a true doom-sayer.

``But Jesus wasn't like that. He was very calm, very self-contained, but stood out. You could not mistake him for anybody else.

``And he walked calmly down the street, acknowledging the crowd, but not really part of it, and certainly not playing the hero role they expected.

``And he walked up to the delegation and saw them, but ignored them and kept on walking. Somehow he seemed to walk *through* them, as if they were not there, but somehow without seeming to be rudely dismissing them. Almost as if there were irrelevant to what he was about.

``And he walked down the street to a certain sycamore tree, as if it were the most interesting thing in Jericho. And he stood underneath its shady branches and stopped. And only then did he look up, and he looked straight up and me and gazed straight into my eyes ... and spoke to me. Me!! There were all these other people there - all of them of more significance than me - but he stopped by me, looked at me and spoke to me.

`` `Zaccheus' - yes, he called me by name - `don't think that you every act and thought is not seen by God who creates everything. Come down, man, come down. Today it is ordained that I should stay at your house, for I am called to save the lost sheep of Israel.

`` `Consider this if you will. Imagine a man of high rank, a Herod maybe, who sails off to Rome to have a tetrachy foisted upon him. Do the people want that? Of course not! The mob want to govern themselves. So they send a delegation to Caesar as well, saying we do not want this man to be our Ethnarch. Whatever.

`` `In his absence, the man delegates the authority he already has. To this man he says, `do this', and to another `do that'.

`` `And when he returns, he examines them and judges them according to what they have. And some will have extorted and some will have robbed. Some will have ruled wisely, and some will have been popular with the people.

`` `And the ruler, when he returns, will reward those who have done good, and will punish those who have done evil.

`` `And each of you should ask, where will you be on that day? Will you be counted among the good or the evil? Will you be rewarded or sentenced to death; for you know well that those who will have opposed him having the kingdom he will put to death.

`` `My job is not to judge, or to sentence, or to put to death. I have one task and that one task is to rescue those who are doing evil and to put their feet on the right path.'

``And he looked up at me again. And with compassion that could melt ice, he said, `Come down, Zaccheus. It is you I have come to save from the judgment.'

``And I came down."

``I brought him into my house and he looked around at all the nice things that I had - the things that I had acquired through exploitation and deceit. And he looked at me and I will never forget what he said next.

`` `Never have I seen so clear a picture of the weight of sin on a man's soul.'

``And I burst into tears. He was right; he had not come to judge me. I was the judge. He had just opened my eyes to my sin. And all around me was, as he said, the evidence of that sin. I had been so proud of all the possessions I had acquired and in the blink of an eye he had made it all worthless - indeed, more than worthless.

``And before I could say anything; before I could really even know how I felt myself, he had grasped the change that had come over me, and it was so clear to him.

`` `Rejoice, Zaccheus, because right now you are saved! You are a descendant of Abraham, and today you have reclaimed that status!

`` `Worry not about what you have done or the evil you have accomplished! You know the Law, you know what God demands of you, and you know the evil you have committed. You are granted a long life that you may put that right.'

``And since then I have done the best I can to cure the evils I caused."

23. Joseph

AD57 Bethany

24 years after the crucifixion

Joseph had been on my list before Mary mentioned him.

Philip had said I needed to speak to Joseph for a number of reasons, but most importantly because he had been one of the `supporters' as the early financial and political backers of Jesus were known. The crucifixion was the end-game of many plots to remove Jesus from the political scene, but most of the others had been obstructed or defused by quiet political maneouvring behind the scenes.

Joseph had been one of the earliest such political operatives, supporting Jesus since he had heard him preach in the first weeks after his baptism by John on the banks of the Jordan.

By definition, such men were incredibly well connected, and Joseph was certainly that. He was a member of the Jewish High Council - the one that ultimately put Jesus to death, but Philip had told me that he had opposed that during the critical weeks when Jesus came closer to Jerusalem, and had been deliberately excluded from `the Passover Conference' when the members of the Sanhedrin who wanted Jesus dead met in secret so as to approach Pilate with a `unanimous' verdict of revolution and death from the Jewish authorities. Such a perspective from the inside seemed fascinating; but after Mary's tale I wasn't sure whether to be prepared for something even more amazing or to accept that I had passed the pinnacle and would now only hear lesser stories.

Joseph was now an old man, and lived outside the city, in a town called Bethany across the Kidron river. It was only a short walk from Jerusalem, so I set off early in the morning to meet him at midday.

There was a small, happy community of members of the Way in Bethany, based around the extended family of Lazarus, one of the other early supporters of Jesus.

We met in the quiet interior garden of his house, sitting against the south wall in the shade on an extremely hot day for the time of year. He offered me a cool drink of water, which I readily accepted and asked me why I'd come. I explained that I was interesting in piecing together the details of Jesus' life from those who'd actually met him and felt moved by his mission in a personal way, and I'd heard that he had been involved at a number of points in the story.

``True enough,'' he opened. ``I am what many Jews often call `those who are waiting'; my whole life, I had been waiting for the coming of the Kingdom of God. What Jesus made me realize was that being a `waiter' is only really an option for the rich; the poor have to keep on living their livesand try and be holy at the same time. What for me is an interesting challenge and a diversion is to them an almost insupportable burden. And it's not possible that God, who is good, could have possibly intended to burden so many people in such a way.

``But I'm telling you the story out of order. I gained, but I also lost. I lost the innocence of my youth. But let me start again. Excuse an old man rambling. It happens. Too long a lawyer ...

``When I was young, my father was one of the Temple lawyers and rose to be a member of the Temple Council. I suppose it was in many ways inevitable that I would follow suit, although there's no guarantee that I would rise as high.

``My father was just old enough to remember the conquest of Pompey. But that was his first memory - he was two or three years old at the time - and in many ways it defined him. He was violently opposed to the Roman occupation his entire life.

``He always told me that I was born in the year that Octavianus cemented his powers and took the name Augustus; and he told me that I was born as a balance to that, to oppose that.

``But I never saw it that way. How can you oppose the Romans? They are so powerful. They have all the weapons of this world! Violence? They have armies the like of which have never been seen before. Power? They have organization and discipline unmatched in human history. Money? Their Empire sucks all the gold from the four corners of the earth into the centre, Rome. Law? They define what laws are valid and if you protest, their Senate combines to crush you. What human weapons are there to oppose a Pompey, an Antonius or an Augustus? There are none.

``For a Jew, then, there is only one way out. Radical reliance on the God of Abraham. And in this day and age, that really means one thing, which is to expect him to act to bring in the promised age - the age of his Messiah, who, the prophets reliably tell us will sweep away the world we know and replace it with his own Kingdom; a Kingdom not of this world, ruled by men with power and laws, but a Kingdom of his devising, where all men are good and know him as he is.

``What then are the signs of this new Kingdom coming? It was to this that I devoted myself as a young man, searching the scriptures and looking for clues. I met with other young men - and some older men - who were on the same hunt. Over time, most fell away, absorbed with the cares of this world: Temple rituals, marriage, raising children. But some of us carried on in our search. And became convinced that this was the era in which our prayers would be answered.

``I was twenty-seven when I was called to the bedside of Simeon, one of the older members of our movement. Even older than my father, he remembered clear back to the days of the Maccabees and the freedom of Judea. He had been a young man when Pompey had come into the city and desecrated the Temple.

``And, there, on his deathbed, he told me a secret. He had seen the Lord's Christ, the one who had been sent to announce the coming of the Kingdom.

``It is to begin at last,'' he said. ``I recognized him the moment he was placed in my hands for the blessing. Do not seek him out, for he must have his youth to develop and grow, but this is the token you will take with you ... Christ is born and will come into his own in thirty years or so. And when he does, the sign by which you shall know him is this: he was presented in the Temple this day.

``I went to the Temple records and noted the names of all the infant boys who had been presented that day. They were twenty-two in number. I memorized their names and their parents' names. And I waited in earnest for the day when one of them came into their own, having faith but never *quite* knowing if Simeon had spoken truth, or if his desire to see the coming of the Lord within his lifetime had determined him to say that it *had* happened.

``And so I waited. From time to time, one would arise and preach of the coming Kingdom, and I would go and listen. And most of the time they said nothing new, but cobbled together words and phrases from the prophets, as any madman could, and I went home disappointed.

``Then, one day, I heard that a new man was preaching repentance of sins by the Jordan, baptizing those who chose to renew their lives and tormenting those who wanted easy answers. I naturally went out to see him, and hear what he had to say.

``The advice he gave was clear and obvious and within the parameters of the Law. But unlike most of the others I'd heard, his words were clearly inspired by God. When the crowds had drifted away at the end of the day, baptized or dejected, I approached him and asked if he was Christ.

`` `I?' he asked, amused. `Do I look like I have the power of the seven kingdoms in my hands? Do even sinners tremble before me? Can I cure any sickness? No, he that you seek will come after me. I am here to pick the low-hanging fruit, to call the sick to repentance. I wash the outside of the body, to cleanse away the outermost sins, but he will come and burn out your very soul with the power of God.

`` `And yet, even so, the Kingdom will not come, because he is not the Judge come into his Court, but still just the messenger calling all to repentance. But when you meet him, even you will repent of your sins.'

``Naturally I was affronted. What sins? I followed the law. I did my duties in the Temple. I stayed away from unclean things. While I did not violently oppose the Romans, I did my best to keep the country pure from their influence.

`` `This is the difference,' continued John, `between me and the Christ when he comes. He will not need to explain your sins to you. One glance from him, and you will know your flaws. And then you will repent. And now you see why so many do not choose baptism from me. Their arrogance and hardness of heart is too great.'

``I went away without understanding a word he had said. And waited for the one Simeon had promised. John could not be the one; I checked and he had been presented in the Temple more than a year before Simeon died.

``Finally, I heard of a man preaching the Kingdom up in the north, around the hills of Galilee. Why would God send his messenger there? Surely this could not be the man that was promised?

``But the more stories I heard about his preaching and teaching, the more they seemed to align with what John had said. There were stories of healings, miracles, and conversions of all strata of people. And then I heard his name and lineage: Jesus, born of Joseph and Mary, from the tribe of David, resident in Nazareth. Just as it had been written in the Temple records on the day that Simeon died. I dropped everything and went to hear him in the Countryside.

``I heard him preach all day, and he answered the people's questions, and healed many. But his answers were not like the answers of the lawyers, even when they came in the same form. He looked on each person with deep compassion and answered the questions they *really* wanted answered, not the ones they actually asked.

``As the day wore down, and many who had to make a living or had a long journey home drifted off, I approached him and asked him the question that was always on my mind.

`` `Pray, Lord, what must I do to see the consolation of Israel?'

`` `What does the Law say you must do?'

``The Law? I didn't immediately see the connection, but I quoted the summary Rabbi Hillel had made popular in my youth: `Love the Lord your God with all your heart, mind and soul, and love your neigbour as yourself.'

`` `Indeed so,' said Jesus. `Well summarized and memorized. I congratulate your teachers on telling you the truth.

`` `So now, *why don't you go and do it*?'

`` `But,' I protested, `these things I have done since I was a young man just learning the law.'

`` `Have you? Have you really loved your neighbours?' His eyes bore into me, and in that moment, I knew I was in the presence of the one John had predicted.

`` `Who is my neighbour?' I asked, prompted by I know not what force.

``He regarded me compassionately, in a way he hadn't up until that point and launched into a story. He told such wonderful stories; they sounded like children's fables: but then he reached the end of the story and suddenly you realized your life would never be the same again.

`` `Imagine a man walking between two towns, through the open countryside. There are bandits in the hills, you know, who might come down and rob him. And, left for dead, he can hardly help himself, can he? So imagine a party of priests heading through that country on their way to the Temple see him, and recognizing he is dying, judge him unclean and are careful to avoid him.

`` `A young man, apprenticing to be a priest, comes along, and sees him and recognizes that he is unclean. Well taught, he knows the commandment not to touch any unclean thing, and is again careful to avoid him.

`` `Then a local pig-farmer comes along from Samaria. He is ignorant of the Temple rituals and the Law. He sees a man dying by the side of the road and knows that he will probably be dead within the hour. Notwithstanding, he takes the water he has and gives it to the man. He pours vinegar on his wounds to clean them. And he wraps him up in his cloak to keep him alive.

`` `Then he runs to the nearest inn on the road, borrows a hand cart and a servant, returns to the body and carts it to the inn, paying from his own purse for the innkeeper to tend him until he should recover.

`` `You tell me who you think your neighbours are.'

``I couldn't. In that moment, my whole life was revealed for the fraud that it was, and I burst into tears and fell on the ground.

``By the time I could move again, he had gone. But I was no longer Joseph-who-waited-for-the-Kingdom but Joseph-for-whom-the-Kingdom-was-inside.

``That short encounter had healed me of my overweening pride.''

For a while after that, we talked of trivial incidents over the next couple of years, and how Jesus' ministry developed. From time to time complaints came from rural synagogues and leaders that Jesus was acting in ways that were disturbing `the peace'. When possible, he had acted within the council to demonstrate that the actions of Jesus were on the whole acting for good, and these disturbances were just the reaction of those who didn't like having their unholiness pointed out.

From time to time, he had been unable to defuse the situations, and messengers had been sent out to challenge Jesus. Many of them came back changed, like Joseph himself, but their encounters. Others, harder of heart, came back outraged by the simple fact that Jesus cared more about sinners of all stripes than he did about important Temple men. Within the council, outrage started to boil.

``It all came to head when we heard that Jesus was going to Jericho. Until that time, he had basically been in the north, and that was largely occupied by non-believers anyway. The preponderance of opinion was that anything that could be done to bring the Samaritans within the circle of Judaism was a benefit, even if we wouldn't want that kind of heresy spreading among proper Jews.

``But suddenly, Jesus' plans seem to change. We heard he was heading for Jericho and then planning to come on to Jerusalem for the Passover.

``I'm sure you know, but the big feasts are always a difficult time, politically. It was probably always that way, but certainly with the Romans here, all it takes is one fool to say `Down with Rome' or `Romans go home' and you have a riot in the streets. Because every proper Jew wants to celebrate the Passover in Jerusalem, the city is always utterly crowded at that time. And that kind of overcrowding combined with the spirit of celebration can often lead to unfortunate incidents.

``Well, the Sanhedrin decided that we needed to come to an accommodation with him before he descended on Jerusalem for the feast. They thought that if they made a big deal out of him being in Jericho, they could possibly deter him from coming on to Jerusalem, at least until the feast was over. For him to be preaching his particular brand of radical reliance on the God of Abraham at the Passover would probably set the spark to the kindling. The byplay could see Jerusalem destroyed.

``Oh, how they underestimated him! They went to Jericho in all their finery. And he wandered into Jericho and didn't even acknowledge them, but carried on with his normal routine: tax-collectors and prostitutes. I don't know how many souls were saved for the coming of the Kingdom in those few days that he was there, but quite apart from the snub that they felt, it convinced the Sanhedrin that he could not be allowed in the City for the Passover!

``Over the next couple of weeks, they tried everything to stop him coming to the City. But, as you know, none of it worked.

``But they didn't seem to learn from what happened in Jericho. When he came to Jerusalem, he behaved in just the same way he had at Jericho. The people went wild, welcoming him as the Messiah come among them, and he just ignored the people who were happy to see him and focused on the sinners and tax-collectors.

``And so it went all week. They were obsessed with trying to trap him, trick him, evict him or detain him before the Passover came. But nothing they tried worked.

``Then suddenly, one of his disciples came to Ananias - the High Priest - after the Passover meal had been eaten and said that Jesus had celebrated it in an idolatrous fashion, mixing in blood rituals from Greek and Roman practice, and he had been offended and could not stand it any longer, and if we gave him a couple of Temple guards, would arrange to capture him quietly without bloodshed.

``Well, you know the rest. Within a day, Jesus had been betrayed, captured, tried, sentenced and crucified. He had already been sentenced by the time I heard anything about it - Ananias knew that I would have opposed it.

``Immediately I heard, I went to Pilate and demanded an audience. He didn't know me that well, but we had met a few times in the course of our duties, and he respected me.

``I asked him to reverse his verdict, but he explained that he couldn't do that for me since it wasn't really his verdict but that of my superiors. `I did interview him,' he told me, 'but he didn't even seem interested in escaping his death sentence. I've never seen anybody quite as equanimious about dying.'

``I didn't know what to do. So I did the only thing I could think of and asked him for the body. All that afternoon, I stood out at Golgotha watching him die, and then as the sun was setting they took him down and placed him on the cart my servants had brought. We took him out to where my own tomb was, and did the minimum to prepare the body for burial and then retreated home for the Sabbath.

``On the morning of the first day of the week, we set off early to finish the enbalming. And when I arrived, Mary was there. I'd expected to see her, but what I didn't expect was that she'd opened the tomb! That's a heavy stone and it had taken all of us to close it the morning before. I didn't see how she could have done it herself.

``And then she told me the most fantastic story about how Jesus was not there, but angels had spoken to her. I went in to the tomb to look and it was true! The body was missing but the very linen garments we had put on him were there.

``I didn't know what to do. By this time Joanna was there and she said the Peter and some of the others were at her house, and Mary went there to tell them the news, such as it was, and I went to the Temple to pray for guidance.

``I didn't see Jesus that evening. I wasn't with the others when he appeared to them. But somehow I knew where to be on the final day, and I was there when he led us out here to Bethany and blessed us and ascended.

``And I thought as he arose that God would come in all his majesty and usher in the Kingdom, but that didn't happen.

``So here I am, ending my days as I began them, waiting for the coming of the Kingdom, but having at least met the one man who could make sense of it all.

``And like Simeon before me, I will be able to die in peace.''

24. The Tomb

AD57 Outside Jerusalem

24 years after the crucifixion

I finally found the Tomb.

I'd heard so much about the Tomb and the stone over the past few days, that I found myself wanting to see it for myself. In Paul's version of the story, the Tomb itself did not figure; indeed, Mary and Joseph hardly figured. What mattered was the symbolism presented by the fact that Jesus was crucified but that death could not hold him: and thus, the end times were upon us; the general resurrection would surely follow; we would all be judged; and thus the time for repentance was very short.

In the traditions I'd heard over the last few days, centred in and around Jerusalem, the actual event of the resurrection was not reduced to symbolism but was remembered for the event which it was in its own right. And that seemed to centre largely on the events of one Sunday morning at the Tomb.

I obviously couldn't go back in time to that Sunday morning and observe what happened myself, much as I would have liked to have been there; but I could visit the tomb. I'd asked my hosts where it was and they described it to me. It was, after all, Joseph's tomb and since Jesus had not taken up permanent residence, he planned again to use it for himself, having transcended the belief that a `fresh' tomb was somehow holier than one that had been used in the past.

I had been told that it might be difficult to find, and my hosts had offered to loan me a messenger as guide, but something in me had wanted to be there alone at the moment when I saw the tomb - much as Mary had been. After an hour of fruitless searching, though, I'd begun to wonder if the guide might not have been a good idea.

But once I found the tomb, all thoughts that I should have brought a guide vanished. It sat there, in a small hollow, easily missed in the overall landscape. So quiet and unassuming for a site that had seen the world's greatest mystery acted out. The round stone lay across the entrance to the cave, just as described by both Mary and Joseph. I walked up to it.

The grave had been resealed - presumably shortly after the resurrection - and the stone now blocked access into the tomb. I tried to roll it, but that was very much beyond me. It would have been beyond Mary or Joseph as well, as they'd described to me. That's why they'd brought a number of young servants with them that morning.

I sat down on a nearby rock in the shade and studied the Tomb, trying to see if I could make it reveal its secrets - or maybe waiting to see if an angel would appear and give me a message.

Nothing happened.

Eventually I stood up and walked back into the city. To paraphrase Elijah, `there was a tomb, but the Lord was not in the tomb'.

Maybe Paul was right not to focus on the event of the resurrection - what mattered was what we did with it.

25. Cleopas

AD 57 Jerusalem

24 years after the resurrection

If I couldn't draw any secrets from the Tomb, I could track down Jesus' actions after he left it.

Mary had told me about Cleopas and David, and I decided to try and track them down. It turned out that during the persecution David had fled to Alexandria. He might or might not still be there; he might, indeed, be dead. If I went to Alexandria, I might look for him there; but I wasn't about to make a special trip right now. Leaving Paul in Caesarea for a week to come to Jerusalem was one thing; Alexandria was a major trek.

But Cleopas had remained in Jerusalem, even during the persecution. When I met him, it became obvious why. Unlike many of the firebrand prophets and apostles, this was a quietly spoken man who considered everything before he tried to change the minds of others. He had probably never even come to the attention of the authorities as a troublemaker; even if he had, he would have probably engaged the sympathies of most judges.

He lived with a number of other members of the Way in one of their `common houses' spread around the city. Given what Mary had told me, he wasn't hard to find. When I met him, he was at his work desk doing what he had been doing for most of his adult life: writing. Cleopas was a scribe.

``When I was younger, I used to copy out the Law and the Prophets,'' he told me after I had introduced myself. ``But now I do a variety of tasks for many people. But always I try to do things that support the Way as best I can. And, as I'm sure you know, all the money that comes in is shared equally between all of us. Many devout Jews do not want to buy a copy of the Law from a man in a splinter faith.''

I could see that. While the persecution of which I'd heard had seemed to die out in Judea - and was certainly not to be compared to anything that Paul had suffered in Asia - under the surface there was still a considerable tension between those who followed God in the Way of Christ Jesus and those who did not: who believed the the Messiah was yet to come and the end times were not yet here.

``Paul did not do us any favours by coming to Jerusalem and stirring the pot again,'' he noted, but without any obvious acrimony: a statement of fact rather than opinion. ``His brand of the Way, with its divergence from following the Law, inflames passions in a fashion we haven't seen since the great persecutions. They cannot trust him, undermining the Law and mixing in idolatrous beliefs about the afterlife.''

I didn't really feel qualified to answer this. I was, of course, one of the `Gentile hangers-on' who didn't accept or obey the Law to whom he was obliquely objecting. Or noting others' objections to. And if Paul's trial did lead to a stirring-up of old passions, this harmless man might be caught up in a fresh persecution. It was understandable that he would be concerned. But, at the same time, Paul had an obligation - an obligation of the Spirit, no less - to preach the Word as he had received it, didn't he?

``He may well do,'' Cleopas accepted when I put this to him. ``And I, personally, have no objection to him doing that in Asia or Europe. But when he comes here, where the old ways are strongest, and stirs up a hornets' nest, all of us suffer. Did he need to come here? I'd heard he was appointed Apostle to the Diaspora. Whatever Jerusalem may be in these times, it is *not* part of the Diaspora.''

That I could not disagree with.

Eventually, I managed to steer the conversation where I wanted it to go.

``The day of the resurrection? Of course, I remember it as clearly as if it were yesterday.

``It was on the afternoon of the first day of the week - the day that Jesus rose from the dead, but of course we didn't know that at the time. David and I were heading back from the City having celebrated the Passover and the Sabbath and were going home to Emmaus - where we used to live in those days.

``It's about seven miles or so from here, but down and then up, so it ends up taking about half a day, particularly if the weather is hot - or rainy. And as we set off fairly early in the morning, there was only really one thing on our minds - what had been happening over the past few days.

``You have to understand, I was not one of Jesus' followers at that point. I'd heard about him - as I'd heard about John by the Jordan - but I hadn't gone out to see him preach. I was happy doing what I was doing and didn't see any need to upset the apple cart for someone who was probably just a rabble-rouser.

``And then he came to Jerusalem for Passover. Being only a few miles away, I would come up to Jerusalem every Passover, usually just for a couple of days. On this occasion, with Passover being the day before the Sabbath, I had to stay an extra day, so we arrived late on the Wednesday.

``The City was in uproar.

``Emmaus is a fairly sleepy town and while I'd heard about Jesus and had heard that he was planning on being in Jerusalem for the Passover, we'd not heard anything about the events in Jericho, where he managed to offend all the priests, let alone the near-riot that had followed his entrance into Jerusalem.

``By the time we arrived on the Wednesday, it seemed that almost nobody was talking about anything else. I'd thought that if he were to preach in the Temple grounds, I'd go and listen - he might have something interesting to say - but when I arrived on the Thursday morning the courts were packed and just about the only people that were talking were the Temple lawyers. They were asking him difficult points of law and trying to trip him up on all kinds of details. And the way he evaded them! It was a sight to see.

``Clearly, he knew the Law backwards. Whenever they asked him a specific question that involved a phrase such as `What is written in the Law?' or `How do you read Moses?' he gave them a word-for-word repetition of the clause or commandment they were looking for.

``And it was the same for the prophets. When someone asked him about the future of Jerusalem, he responded by citing `the judgment of Jeremiah on the city' and then quoted the relevant passages in full! I tell you, you might not have liked the man, or agreed with him, but he knew all the traditions of the people!

``But where he really set himself apart from any fool with a good memory was when they asked him some of the questions that they come up with in doctrinal school - or somewhere.

``I'll give you one example. They asked him about marriage. The Law says that if a woman marries a man, but he dies with her still barren, one of his brothers should marry her and bring up children `but in his brother's name'. Now, they suggested, imagine a whole slew of brothers, each of whom marries the same woman in turn and then dies, and at the end of the day, they are all dead and she is still without child. If you believe in the resurrection, they say, whose wife will she be?

``I remember the look on Jesus face. It wasn't quite contempt, but it was a look of supreme disconcern for the hypothetical woman's fate. `What is marriage', he asked rhetorically. `Is it not a material institution for the proper raising of children? But in the resurrection, who can be a child, `for they shall all know me even as I know them'. So what is the need of marriage? Each shall be their own individual, and not bound to another. They do not die, they do not give birth, they do not marry. Your question reveals your ignorance of much, not just the resurrection.'

``More than one of them were disconcerted at this answer and ceased from trying to entrap him. Then he turned the tables on them.

`` `Let me ask you this,' he said, 'on the subject of marriage. If a man is married, is it lawful for him to commit adultery with another woman and still serve as a priest?'

``And he walked forward and looked one of the doctors of the law in eye and repeated `Well? Is it?'. The man turned purple, stood up and fled from the Temple, pushing others out of his way, in his hurry to leave.

`` `Beware of false lawyers!' he proclaimed to the people. `They may enjoy walking around in long robes. They may love people bowing to them in public. They enjoy the privileges and honours. But are they better men? I doubt it. Look not on the outward appearance! It is what is on the inside that will be judged on Judgment day!' "

Cleopas had remained in Jerusalem for the Passover and the day of the crucifixion; although he had not been present at any of the key events involving Jesus, he had heard about them and had a fair knowledge of all that had happened. By the time he left Jerusalem, there was almost nothing else he wanted to talk about.

``As we walked down to the Kidron, we were discussing the things we'd heard him say. And it seemed to us that he had done nothing to commit blasphemy, which is what they appeared to have accused him of.

``I was convinced that he was a genuinely good man. I wouldn't have said at that moment that he *was* the Messiah, but I don't think I would have been able to deny it either.

``But surely if he had been the Messiah, God would not have permitted him to die. And I was just saying this when we came up to a man sitting on a rock by the wayside. We stopped and asked if he needed anything - water, or food.

`` `You would share with me?' he asked.

`` `Gladly,' I replied. `We have plenty and to spare for this walk; we are only going to Emmaus.'

`` `Then I will take what I value most,' he replied. `Your company.'

``And we walked the rest of the way together.

`` `You were talking most earnestly when you came along,' he offered. `What were you discussing?'

`` `About Jesus and his death.'

`` `Who is that? What happened?'

`` `How can you have been in Jerusalem and not heard all about the Jesus business.'

`` `I may have heard something,' he said, cryptically. `But why don't you tell me all about it, since you clearly know so much.'

`` `There was a man, called Jesus, who had come from Nazareth. He had been preaching for years in the hill towns around Galilee. But a few weeks ago he caused a stir by showing up the priests in Jericho and preferring the company of tax collectors and prostitutes. And then he came to Jerusalem for the passover. We heard him on Thursday.'

`` `And what did he have to say? What was his preaching?'

`` `He was very strong on the Law and Prophets. Never have I heard anyone speak so strongly, so clearly and so effortlessly - as if he had truly internalized them, not just memorized them.

`` `And his opinions on other matters - on difficult questions surrounding the law and the contrary views - he cut through them with the grace and wisdom of a Hillel. Often it seemed that he was quoting Hillel's judgments - it would not be too surprising if he had learnt those as well - but often he came up with new, clear and riveting opinions of his own.

`` `And he was so unafraid of the authorities. He even chased one of the lawyers from the Temple, accusing him of adultery. On what grounds, I do not know, except that the lawyer's own reaction convicted him.

`` `But then we heard that he was betrayed by one of his own and handed over to the authorities for a closed trial; after which he was handed to the Roman Procurator and sentenced to death.

`` `We didn't see any of that firsthand, we were with family at the time, still celebrating the Passover.

`` `And then this morning, just before we left, we heard a rumour that the grave in which he had been placed was empty! So many oddities, so hard to explain.

`` `But the question that burns in my soul is `Was he the Messiah?' and, if he was, `Why would God let him die?'

`` `Why is that the question that burns in your soul?' the stranger asked. `Would a better question not be, how can I repent and be certain of my place in the judgment?'

``I had to accept that that was a better question, but it seemed somehow less immediate. If this man had seen what I had seen, he might have understood.

``But then he starting talking about the Messiah, and pointing out that in the Law, and in the Prophets, everything came together to make it clear that the life of the Messiah would not be an easy one.

`` `And Zechariah says that the false shepherd must be killed by his own parents,' he was saying as we walked through the gates of Emmaus shortly after midday.

`` `And only after death can the judgment be delivered,' he said. `Until death, all men are alike, as with weeds growing alongside the grain. After death, it is possible to judge a man's life as a whole and decide if he should be cast into the fire or saved through the resurrection.

`` `And how could it be otherwise for the Messiah? Surely he needed to die in order that he could be judged?'

``And at this point we were in the village, and I asked him if he was coming here or elsewhere and he answered very cryptically, `Where I go is my business, but your business is also mine' so I invited him to come with us and share a light meal.

``And we were there at the table when it happened. He took a loaf of bread and said `Let this loaf be the symbol of knowledge. And Father, when I break it, let their eyes be opened. And then he broke apart the loaf, and as he passed some bread to me my eyes were opened and I recognized him. It was Jesus. I opened my mouth to greet him ... and he passed from my sight. I don't know, to this day, if he left normally and I just passed out, or if he vanished.

``David and I looked at each other and knew that the rumour was true. Jesus had defied death and risen from the grave.

``We immediately stood up and hurried back to the city. We sought out his disciples and told them what we had seen and heard.

``They were all in consternation already, with so many different stories and rumours going on. And nobody seemed to know the truth.

``And then, while we were all standing there, he appeared again.

`` `Why are you so slow to believe the thing that had to happen? I tried to tell you what would happen in Jerusalem, but you were all so fearful you could not believe.'

``And we all fell down and worshipped him as the risen Christ.''

26. Nicodemus

AD57 Jerusalem

24 years after the crucifixion

I met Nicodemus at the Temple.

Not in the inner courts of course; I was not allowed there. We met in the Court of the Gentiles, near the Great Gate where Paul had been arrested the previous year.

Nicodemus was now retired, but had been one of the senior members of the Sanhedrin and an early critic of Jesus in his ministry in Galilee. He had gone there to try and determine whether Jesus was indeed a prophet or just a rabble-rousing revolutionary.

He had come away changed.

``I thought I was going to meet a fraud,'' he told me that sunny afternoon before I was due to head back to Caesarea.

``I'd heard such stories about him - the clarity of his teaching and judgments; the healings; the huge crowds that followed him - that I figured it had to be made up by his surrogates to make him seem important. Surely nobody could be that perfect.

``Nobody apart from the Messiah, of course, but I don't think - even if I'd heard it suggested that he could be the Messiah - that I'd considered that possibility seriously. He might be a teacher; he might be a zealot; he might even just be a lunatic who was convincing enough to fool the simple people of Galilee.

``I had a friend in Capernaum, so I went and visited him, and while I was there I made contact with Jesus through some of his associates known to my friend and invited him to join us for dinner. He agreed readily enough, which surprised me at the time, but I later learnt that he had a number of influential backers and possibly thought that I might want to join them. And a free meal is a free meal.

``When he arrived, I greeted him. Not, it has to be said, as a superior, but as what he was: an itinerant preacher. And we sat down to eat.

``At first, the conversation was of no consequence. We discussed the usual topics: the weather, the prospects for the harvest, and the Roman occupation. None of these things are causes for dissent among the people.

``Even so, all his answers were both guarded and cryptic. It was not like a normal conversation with ordinary folk.

``But then the conversation turned to his mission and his preaching. And I asked him about the life that he was said to live, associating with prostitutes, drunkards and *publicani*.

`` `What of it?' he responded. `Consider John, if you will. He wanders the wilderness, surviving on water from the Jordan, locust beans and anything else he can find. And what do men say of him? That he is mad. He may be holy, but he is insane.

`` `And I come along, wandering among the towns where people are, preaching to the lost sheep of Israel - the poor, the hungry, the dispossessed - and to those who avoid those fates by doing what they have to to survive - collect taxes or sell their bodies - and they criticize me saying ``he is himself a drunkard, a glutton and an adulterer.''

`` `Tell me this, how then should I behave? To whom should I preach the word of repentance? To the rich and holy? Would they listen? Do they feel the need of repentance?'

``I had nothing really to say to that, so I said nothing.

`` `Indeed, consider yourself. Would you listen to my preaching? Do you feel the need to repent?'

``I had to admit that I did not. I knew of nothing for which I had need of repentance.

``We looked at each other for a few moments. And then the most remarkable thing happened. Somehow, a woman had managed to barge her way past the door guards and into the dining room we were using. I didn't know her, as such, but I knew her type: she was obviously a prostitute.

``And she had brought with her the tools of her trade: a large box of perfume was in her hands. And she knelt down behind Jesus, and burst into tears. And she used that to wash his feet, and then dried them with her hair. And then she went on to put the unclean perfume on his feet.

``And all the while, Jesus just stared at me, defying me to say something. And I looked back at him, knowing what kind of woman this was. And I knew he knew, but he did not care. It made no sense.

``And then she stopped, and just placed her head on the floor and carried on crying. Not wailing like they do at funerals, but just a gentle sobbing as if she had suffered a great loss or hurt.

``And Jesus turned to me and asked me what seemed a very simple question.

`` `Imagine if you will, a creditor with two debtors. One owes a fortune, while the other a debt so small he hardly notices it. One day the creditor tells both of them that since it is the year of Jubilees, they are both forgiven. How will they react?'

``I continued to look at him for a few more moments before answering.

`` `I am sure they will both be glad,' I replied. `But the one who is forgiven a fortune will be ecstatic and fall down on his knees, while the other will probably just shake his hand and thank him.'

`` `Indeed so,' countered Jesus. `You do actually *see* this woman, I take it? You think of her sins, and to you they seem many, an unbearable burden. And so it is. No amount of preaching of the Law will lift those sins from her, with her life as it is.

`` `But the grace of God can wash away sins, even as John does by the Jordan. Her sins, many as they are, have been forgiven.' And he turned and gently pulled the woman up from the floor. `My dear,' he said, `all your sins are forgiven by the Lord; you have been washed clean and given a fresh start. Go in peace, and sin no more.'

``I couldn't believe what I had seen. It seemed to me that Jesus literally viewed this woman as being better than me. A woman who was a prostitute of more value that a Temple Priest? He must be out of his mind.

``I've heard many people who have talked about their conversions say it all happened in a moment. Maybe it did for me, but I certainly didn't realize it at the time. Rather, it dawned on me slowly how insular I had been; how hierarchical, viewing the kingdom of God as surely being organized much as the kingdoms of this world.

``But in time my eyes were opened and I saw Jesus as he really was: God's Messiah.''

27. Festus

AD58 Caesarea

25 years after the resurrection

Paul stood in front of the new governor and the tetrach, Herod.

For a little over two years, Paul had been remanded to Philip's house; many had seen him there, and many had been converted. His fame had spread, and many of the Way who had doubted his motives had come to understand the challenges of spreading the Word amongst the Gentiles and that Paul - in himself - was completely honest and following the Law in every detail. The Jewish leaders, on the other hand, remained implacably opposed to his preaching.

Felix had been hoping that either Paul would bribe him to be released or that the leaders of the Jews would bribe him to sentence him to death. In both he was disappointed.

But as with all things Roman, eventually Felix was recalled and his replacement - Lucius Porcius Festus - arrived to take over. A fastidious man, he could not stand the thought of cases hanging on for two or more years and set about deciding the outstanding backlog of cases.

In Judea, most of these were at Jerusalem, so shortly after his arrival, he went on to Jerusalem to hear the cases that were there, and then returned to Caesarea.

The leaders of the Jews had wished to have Paul tried in Jerusalem, probably so that they could attempt to kill him en route as they had planned before. But Festus refused, arguing that he had many cases to hear in Jerusalem but that the centre of Roman government in Judea was at Caesarea and it made no sense to send the prisoner there. Instead, he insisted, the Jews must make sure that there prosecutors were in place in Caesarea when the trial commenced.

``But,'' they argued, ``this concerns matters of the Temple, which you are not competent to judge. We require the judgment of the High Priest.''

``Do not tell me what I am competent to do,'' replied Festus. ``I am the representative of the Emperor here. My word is as law. Bring your prosecutors and we will have the trial in Caesarea. But I tell you what I will do to calm your fears: King Agrippa will join me on the bench. He understands the matters of your law, and I can rely on his judgment.''

Obviously the leaders of the Jews were not happy at this - they could not count of Agrippa to take their side - but they were unable to argue with a solution that addressed the concerns that they had actually verbalized.

So, when Festus had returned to Caesarea, he had found a day when Agrippa and his wife Berenice were available to come to Caesarea and hear the case. The prosecutors had arrived and were frustrated by the day until Agrippa could arrive, especially since he would not add value to their case.

When the trial had opened, they had put forward their best arguments and called their witnesses to condemn Paul for desecration of the Temple. Festus had heard them out without asking any questions.

He had then turned to Paul and asked him for his defence.

28. Defence

AD58 Caesarea

25 years after the resurrection

``Exalted Governor, Lucius Porcius Festus, your highness, King Agrippa, and your Ladyship, Queen Berenice. I am grateful for the opportunity you have given me to present my case in the only court competent to consider the fates of members of the Roman Empire.

``It is well known that I am a Citizen of Tarsus in Asia. It is well known to all the Jews there that I am a Pharisee of no mean standing, and that my father and his father were Jews, Citizens and Pharisees!

``It is also well known that from my youth I have known the Law, recited the Law, studied the Law, taught the Law, practiced the Law. Nobody can truthfully bring against me a charge of acting contrary to the Law. As for this charge today, I say it is *not* truthful. It is a total fabrication.

``Why then am I on trial, if it is not for defiling the Temple by bringing Gentiles into it? Very simply, it is for socializing with Gentiles at all! It is well known also that Jews believe themselves to be superior to other races - including Romans! - because they are descended from Abraham, with whom God entered into direct dialogue and promised this land to his seed for ever.

``And descent from Abraham then becomes a gift most precious! Only through descent from Abraham can any man be admitted to the coming Kingdom of Heaven! And in order to qualify, a man must be without sin. And what is the definition of sin? Well, you need to know the law and obey all its commandments. And they are many. Some, like Hillel, manage to reduce it to two - continually love God and always love your fellow man - many offer a ten-commandment summary from the Torah as summarizing the Law, but the truth is that there are over five hundred commands in the Law, and to be free of sin a man must obey all of them for his entire life!

``Is this even possible, I ask you? Some of these commandments seem from time to time to conflict with each other, and doctors of the Law can spend weeks or months arguing about the minutiae of the Law.

``To take but one example: the Sabbath is a day of rest. I am sure that you are well aware of this, even in your short time here. But where does rest end and indolence begin? There are lawyers who discuss the exact number of steps you can take on the Sabbath. Cooking is work, and so cooking is not allowed on the Sabbath; on the other hand, eating is allowed, provided the food was prepared the day before.

``Some consider looking after children to be work - which should not be done on the Sabbath - but how can it be avoided? The children must be fed and clothed - they cannot do this for themselves.

``We are commanded to honour our parents - but what if our parents deviate from the Law? Should we still honour them? Should we honour their deviance from the Law? Or, should we take them to task for their sins, which is also a requirement of the Law?

``So many lived under the Law, and many died under the Law. But what happens after death? Some say that once dead, there is nothing more. Some say that after death we will all be recalled in the Spirit. And some say we will be resurrected with our bodies restored and transformed.

``These men that you see before you who accuse me of defiling the Temple are Sadducees. They do not believe that there is *any* resurrection of the dead. As a Pharisee, I believe in the bodily resurrection and the final judgment. And it is for this they hound me and pursue me. If you find me guilty today, you do not find me guilty of the crime of defiling the Temple - they know as well as I do that I did not do that - but you find that I am wrong about the resurrection. But that is not a criminal matter.

``Why then, do they pursue me with these deadly charges, and plot against me to kill me? Because I preach the Truth, which is that one has already been raised from the dead, and this denies everything that they believe: how can there be no resurrection if one has already been raised from the dead?

``The life of Jesus, called Christ, is a matter of public record. His death is also a matter of public record, since it was in the time of the Governor Pontius Pilate that he was crucified. He was crucified after the plotting of the leaders of the Jews. Why did they plot against him? Because he taught that the Law was to be superseded by a new covenant between God and men to replace the covenant agreed with Abraham. In this new covenant, all men could participate - not just the Jews. But first, he insisted, it was important to preach the word to all the lost sheep of Israel: the descendants of Abraham who could not follow the Law because its demands were too onerous.

``And so God sent Jesus to preach a new Way forward: that the new qualification for the resurrection was to *literally* follow the formula of Hillel: in all things to love God and follow his Way; and to live this in daily life by loving all men.

``If you see those who follow the Way in Judea - or indeed, those I have converted in Asia and Greece - they live in communities together, not competitively but collaboratively. They earn what they can individually, but they share it among all their neighbours.

``This man came and preached that salvation was within reach of all - it was not a hard obligation which only the rich and indolent could achieve, but a simple matter of living simply and sharing God's bounty with neighbours - and he overturned the established order. He said that those with power and influence were not superior to any others in the eyes of God. And he made friends with beggars, thieves and prostitutes and shunned the company of the rich and the priests.

``And so they plotted to disgrace him and, when that failed, they plotted to kill him. They tried many things to trick him and sent many of the clever doctors of the Law to ask him difficult questions, but always he evaded their traps and gave answers that were wise beyond consideration.

``I was not one of the plotters. But that was simply because I was not in Jerusalem but in Antioch. I heard of these things at first vaguely and from afar. It was probably a year or two before the first of the followers of the Way came to Antioch and preached the obsolescence of the Law. I was outraged! The Law, the very pathway to holiness and eternal life, obsolete? What hope did I have of the resurrection if the Law had been outdated? And by such as flimsy construction! `Love your neighbour'. As if we did not do this every day.

``You see, without meeting the man, without hearing his teaching, without the deeper sense of the way in which he instructed his followers to `love their neighbour' the command seemed empty and hollow.

``And so, I opposed these men. In the synagogues I disputed with them; I argued with them; I showed them irrefutable proofs of the sole validity of the Law! Yes, I argued all the same things that my prosecutors argue today to show that I am in the wrong.

``But the trump card is the bodily resurrection of Jesus. When I first heard this advanced, I thought the men who argued it were either desperate, lying or mad. Or all three. That God should raise a man from the dead - ludicrous! That he should do it without the kind of fanfare that would make everybody pay attention - even more ludicrous! I called them out in their preaching for their madness.

``And after I had done away with them in Antioch - by fair means or foul - I petitioned the leaders of the synagogues in Antioch that I should be sent to Damascus, because some of these followers of the Jesus Cult had fled there from the persecutions in Jerusalem and Antioch. And they agreed and sent me.

``The leader of the Way in Damascus was, I had heard, a man named Ananias. And I went specifically to argue with him and, if all else failed, to arrest him on charges of blasphemy - that the Law had passed away; much the same charge with which I am accused today.

``But I never made it to Damascus. At least, the person that I was then never made it. When I was nearly there, there was suddenly a bright light in the sky and I was blinded. And a voice called out to me `Why, Paul, why? Why do you try to persecute me? The harder you push, the harder it will be for you?'

``And I was stunned and I could not fathom what was happening so I called out, `Who, Lord? Who am I persecuting? And how? What shall I do?'

``And he said, `you know you are persecuting, Paul. I am Jesus, from Nazareth. Now stand up and walk, for I have chosen you as a special messenger - you are to take my message to the Gentiles and the lands of the Gentiles and you are to preach to them in Asia and Greece and Rome!'

``But when I stood again, I found I could not see. I had been blinded by the bright light and had to be led by the hand of my companions. And when I came to Damascus, the very man whom I had gone to persecute - Ananias - came and found me, and healed me of my blindness!

``Thus, since that time, I have not been able to sit still but have travelled across Asia and Greece preaching what I myself have learned - that Jesus is God's Christ, that he was unjustly killed by the leaders of the Jews in collaboration with the Roman governor, that he rose again from the dead, and that by accepting his death as a token for the remission of our own sins, we are freed from the Law and can partake in the bodily resurrection ourselves! We are free, I say!''

29. Festus

AD58 Caesarea

25 years after the crucifixion

``Are you raving mad, Paul?'' interrupted Festus. ``Have your years of imprisonment addled your brains? Or have you always been like this? Should I execute you, or should I send you to a colony for the insane?''

``Rather, I would ask,'' Agrippa interjected smoothly, ``are you trying to defend yourself against the charges brought against you, or are you trying to convert us to being members of this Way of yours?''

``If I had to choose,'' replied Paul, ``I would choose that one man should be saved than that I should be set free. But, no, obviously I am defending myself against these obviously trumped-up charges.

``The only reason that I stand here today is because I believe in the resurrection and they do not! It is for this that they wish to kill me - because I am an eye-witness to the bodily Jesus, resurrected! And thus my defence is that while I was once like them, now I am saved through the intercession of Jesus. And this is what I tell you - it is my defence. The only possible defence against disbelief.''

``None of this interests me,'' said Festus. ``None of this has anything to do with the business of the Roman Government. I suggest that this whole proceeding be moved back to the religious court where it originated and the punishment that they mete out be binding.''

``But sir,'' argued the prosecutor. ``We cannot sentence a citizen of Tarsus to death without their consent or yours. Yet what this man has done is, by our laws, worthy of death.''

``That cannot be my concern,'' said Festus. ``You may think him deserving of death, but as Romans we abhor human sacrifice and other killings in the name of the Gods. Unless you have some charge that you can make stick in this court, you can only punish him according to the limits of religious tolerance established by the Senate.''

``What of the riots he has caused from one end of Asia to the other?'' the prosecutor asked, temporizing.

``What concern is that of yours?'' asked Festus. ``That would be within the jurisdiction of courts in Asia, not here. Do you wish me to remand him back to Tarsus to face charges there? If indeed, there is anyone there that would prosecute him?''

``No,'' replied the prosecutor. ``I wish to press the charges here. We have the witnesses we need.''

``I tell you, it is out of the jurisdiction of this court. We cannot try that here.''

``I appeal to the Senate and to Caesar!'' exclaimed Paul. ``I am innocent of all charges, but there is only one court that can exonerate me and that is in Rome!

``I demand that you either release me or send me for trial at the highest court in the Empire, presided over by Caesar!''

Festus looked at Agrippa, and then at the prosecutors before nodding consent. ``So noted,'' he agreed. ``You will be transported to Rome in the custody of Roman soldiers. In Rome you will be held in custody until such time as a trial can be arranged. You will bear all the costs of transportation and incarceration; and I want you to be aware that these can be no small costs: I hope you have adequate funds.

``The prosecution will need to make sure that they are available for the court on the chosen day. Again, you will bear all the costs for your own transportation and accomodation in Rome. Failure to appear will obviously prejudice your case.

``Dismissed.''

30. Shipwrecked

AD58 The Mediterranean

25 years after the crucifixion

The storm was unremitting.

Everything had gone smoothly until we had reached Crete, when the storm had come rushing out of the north-east, blowing over the island and rushing us out to sea.

Festus had been as efficient in his dispositions as he had been in his judgment. The day after the judgment, a centurion was detailed to take the prisoner, along with two slaves - myself and Timothy were chosen - to Rome. By that evening, the four of us, together with a bodyguard of two decuries - a further sixteen soldiers and four slaves - were on board a ship running from Caesarea up the coast which was sailing to Myra in Lycia.

But from the moment we had left Sidon, our first stop, everything had started to go against us. The wind was blowing in our faces for much of the time, forcing us to go further north than we had wished and follow the coast of Asia, before attempting to cross over and use the coastline of Cyprus to avoid the direct wind and garner the spilloff to drive us westwards.

Eventually we had made it to Myra, and we debated waiting until the spring trading season opened up and the winds would be more predictably westward. But Julius, the centurion, managed to find a captain from Alexandria who was planning on making a final corn run to Rome and agreed to take us. At least, we had joked, we would not be short of food on this trip.

We sailed as far as Cnidus without incident, although slowly and the wind continued to be against us. Here we debated once again waiting for spring, but the captain said that we should be able to run south easily enough and make Crete. From there, we could either winter in Phoenix easily enough or continue on our journey depending on the winds.

The leg southwards had gone smoothly enough and we made it to Crete without incident, but when we turned westwards, we again struggled to beat against the headwinds. We reached a small port called Fair Havens, which the captain judged unsuitable to wait out until the spring brought new weather conditions.

Paul had argued vigorously that he had foreseen doom and shipwreck should we continue past Fair Havens, but since another day would see us safe in the snug harbour at Phoenix, the captain - and the centurion - were disinclined to accept his viewpoint: after all, he was just a prisoner.

But it was during that day that the storm had suddenly blown up; coming from the land as it had, we had had no recourse to attempt to make any harbour but were swept uncontrollably southwards.

The captain had immediately ordered the sails struck, but the storm had been so fierce that much of the tackle had been damaged or destroyed and was swinging around the deck in wild gyrations and had to be cut loose and sent overboard.

As the waves had grown, they threatened to swamp the heavily-laden vessel and sink us. The experienced crew knew the only remedy: lighten the ship by any expedient. First the ballast, then the valuable cargo went overboard, and soon the only weight on the ship was the passengers and essential supplies - along with the water we tried desperately to bail out day and night.

We had now been in this state for over a week.

With the rain lashing down and the wind blowing, Paul walked to the main mast, now cracked in two places. Holding onto it with all his strength, he called out in that voice which those who had heard his preaching knew so well: not the voice of Paul the man, but the voice of Paul the divinely inspired messenger of God.

``Listen, well, oh valiant sailors. I have word from God. The God who made the heavens and the earth, the God who made the seas. Listen, for he has sent his word to me and it is this I tell you now.

``Surely this ship will be lost. I have seen it shipwrecked on an island. But in my vision, one thing above all was clear: the cargo has been lost, the ship will yet die, but not one of us will be harmed or lose life in the tragedy!

``Stand firm and trust in the power of the Lord! The God who made all things, who raised his Christ from the grave has promised this much! We will all stand on dry land again after the destruction of this ship!

``Listen to the words of God: God requires that I should testify of him before Caesar. God requires that I should be in Rome, and thus, as a measure of his power, all of our lives are saved. God is just and merciful, and to all here mercy is shown.''

Understandably, this speech amazed all those on board. Nobody could quite believe either the certainty with which he spoke or the arrogance to assume that their lives were subordinate to a god's desire to save a mere prisoner.

Nevertheless, as the next few days passed, and the ship remained afloat in spite of having become almost a complete wreck, the words, and the conviction with which they were spoken - together with Paul's continuing positive attitude - the crew started to believe that maybe some divine agency had chosen them to live.

When the storm finally released us, we drifted for a number of days. The crew attempted to effect repairs, but the mast was too badly damaged to carry the driving force of the wind needed to move the ship forward. But Paul remained adamant that we would be saved.

Finally, overnight one of the sailors on `lookout' shouted that he could smell land. It's a funny thing, but when you are on land, you can smell the salt tang of the sea; but when you have been at sea for a few weeks, it is land that has the noticeable smell.

The captain immediately called out for soundings, and found the bottom to be shoaling at twenty fathoms; a turn later, it was fifteen. He promptly ordered that all the remaining anchors be thrown out and grasp the ship where it was.

At daybreak, the land appeared in the rising light. None of us aboard recognized it, but we had no hope of going anywhere else. There was a current sucking us in, so we released the anchors and drifted inwards as slowly as we could manage.

When we were nearly ashore, the ship ran aground on a shoal. After weeks of torment at sea, the ship had lost the integrity needed to have its bows held fast in the sandbar while the current and wind battered the stern: it started to break apart. The crew began to desert the ship, but the soldiers planned to kill we three prisoners. Julius, however, had by this time believed what Paul had said, and felt that by killing any of us - especially Paul - that he would be endangering everybody's lives.

Instead, he organized the remaining crew, soldiers and prisoners into teams to ensure that as many as possible reached the land. All Roman soldiers, since the time of Gaius Marius, had been expected to know how to swim, and they were put in charge of the teams. Using broken parts of the ship, they created floats for those who could not swim, and ensured that in each team an appropriate balance of swimmers and non-swimmers could assist each other for the half-mile trip to the island.

Nobody died. Whether this was because of God's intervention or the careful organization of the Roman centurion, I could not say. I believed in both implicitly.

When we came ashore, we were tired, wet and cold. More than that, we were exhausted from our two week ordeal at sea. Fortunately for us, we were not the first ship to have wrecked on that coastline and the locals, having seen our ship in distress since dawn, had prepared for us coming ashore: they had gathered wood for a fire, brought bread and meat and sent a runner to the governor, who owned the estate near where we had landed.

As Paul came up to the fire, to warm himself and to dry out his sodden clothes, a snake came hissing out at him - presumably it had been collected with the logs making up the fire - and sank its teeth into his hand. He immediately cried out, but then shook his hand, releasing it and it slithered away.

``Neither this snake nor I will see any hurt this day,'' he declared. ``God, who is a God of Love and not hatred, will not cause harm to any of us gathered hear today.'' And so saying, he took some of the bread that the locals had brought and, in his characteristic fashion, looked up, gave thanks for our deliverance, and broke the bread.

By now, not just the crew but the locals as well believed that something miraculous was happening among them. This man was not just brave, he was clearly inspired by some divine power. Some even said that he was a god himself.

The following day the governor himself sent for us. He had been told of our arrival and wanted to find out our business. When he found that the party was not just civilians but contained a military delegation, he promptly arranged to house us himself, attached to his own regiment.

We walked over to his residence, a journey of over ten miles, and no mean feat for a group of men who had been exhausted and shipwrecked. But Paul preached and declaimed the whole way, and not one of the men failed to make the journey.

When we arrived, we were greeted by the governor in his purple-bordered toga. He showed us into his state dining room and made dispositions for the crew and guards.

``So you are Paul, citizen of Tarsus?'' he opened. ``I have heard a lot about you, one way and another. I was in Athens when you preached there, if you remember. It caused quite a stir.''

``You were the governor of Greece?'' enquired Paul. ``I don't remember you.''

``No, I was not the governor,'' he replied. ``It is only now I have been appointed a governor, and not of a province, either, but only of this miserable rock, strategically important as it may be.

``No, I was in Athens studying rhetoric from the great teachers. And we had heard that there was a man in the city claiming to have seen the dead walking and to be announcing two new gods. And then you were called for inquisition before the city council on the Areopagus. Do you remember?''

``That I remember very well,'' admitted Paul. ``But still, I do not remember you. I take it you were there.''

``As I say, I was studying rhetoric in Athens. My teachers felt that it would be a good opportunity to learn by evaluating your performance from a rhetorical standpoint. I have to say, you were a disappointment.''

The shock on Paul's face was self-evident. He was not used to this reaction. Some people understood, were converted, repented of their sins and joined the brotherhood. Others were outraged, felt threatened, lashed out and tried to stone him, beat him, arrest him or kill him.

But `a disappointment'?

``You clearly had not studied even the basic rhetorical forms,'' the governor continued. ``You had passion and drive, it is true. I will even accept that you believed what you so passionately declared. But there was no skill there. To a Greek or Roman, you lacked the polish that makes for a convincing argument.''

Paul remained taken aback. It was a few moments before he regrouped.

``So you judge a man not on whether he speaks the truth but on how many rhetorical flourishes he can manage?'' Paul exclaimed. ``That is madness! But no wonder I failed in Athens. Corinth with its stews was much more receptive.''

``It is not a matter of truth or not-truth,'' replied the governor. ``We all know that there are many truths and many philosophies. Clearly, then, how you express them is as important as any alleged truth you may possess.''

``But God himself has intervened in the world. He has overcome death itself and proclaimed the start of the end times through the bodily resurrection of Jesus Christ - ''

The governor held up his hand. Not a rhetorical flourish as such, but a gesture Paul could ignore only at his peril.

``If you have proof, proof you can show me, then that is a separate matter. But in the meantime, do not burden me with your poor rhetoric.''

Proof? What is proof?

The conversation continued with Julius giving a detailed account of our trip. He explained his reasoning for sailing from Crete, and the governor approved his logic. He agreed to write a note to his commander exonerating him for the loss of the ship and, further, agreed to compensate the ship's captain from his stategic fund.

We were discussing the nature of storms in the Mediterranean when a servant came in and whispered to the governor.

``I'm sorry,'' he said, ``but my father is sick and may be dying. I must go and see him.''

``I am a doctor,'' I said, ``may I come with you?''

He generously allowed Paul to come along as well. If nothing else, he said, it might be pleasant to pass his last few hours listening to our adventures.

We walked into the sick chamber and the smell was that of death: I knew it well. I went up to the patient and examined him. But Paul cried out:

``The mercy of God through Jesus in the resurrection is extended to this man! It has been said that none involved in the shipwreck shall die, and I say that this man is involved! He will not die.''

And immediately Paul knelt by the beside, placed his hands on the man's head and prayed.

When he released him, the governor's father sat up, stood up and came and joined us for dinner.

By the time we left three months later, we left a significant community of believers behind us.

31. The Three Taverns Inn

AD59 Three Taverns Inn, near Rome

26 years after the crucifixion

``Hear the new agreement which God in his mercy has given us and nothing can daunt us. We aren't in the business of using no hocus-pocus or clever tricks; we don't manipulate the Word of God for our human benefit. All we do is speak the plain truth. It's been suggested that our Gospel is `veiled', that it is somehow hidden and secret. I don't see how. If there is such a `veil', then it must be in the minds of those who aren't listening. Perhaps the `spirit' of this world has blindfolded the minds of those who do not believe, and thus prevents the broad day light of the glorious Gospel of Christ, the image of God, from shining on them.

``What do we preach? Do we glorify ourselves? Far from it. What we preach is Christ Jesus the Lord. I his service, I am your servant for his sake. The same God, who first ordered 'light to shine in darkness', has latterly flooded our hearts with his light, and we share that light to enlighten men only by sharing the knowledge of the glory of God.

``We don't hold up a fancy precious container and say `this holds the source of all goodness', but rather we keep this priceless treasure in an everyday earthenware jar. Why? Because the splendid power of it belongs to God and not to us.

``We may be handicapped in our work on all sides, but we are never frustrated; we are puzzled at the resistance of this world, but we never despair; we have been persecuted, but we never have to endure that alone; we may be knocked down from time to time, but we cannot be never knocked out! Each and every day we experience some part of the death of the Lord Jesus, but that only means that we also come to know the power of the life of Jesus in these bodies of ours. Yes, we who are living are always being exposed to death for Jesus' sake, so that the life of Jesus may be plainly seen in our mortal lives. We are always facing death, but this means that you know more and more of life. Our faith is like that mentioned in the scripture: `I believed and therefore I spoke'.

``It's true: we believe, and because we believe and we see the truth that it is there for the taking by all men, we cannot but speak out and share the truths that we have received. And remember this: we know for certain that he who raised the Lord Jesus from death shall also by him raise us.

``And we shall all stand together in that day with Jesus before God.

``The more you see how this is working out for your benefit - how the more grace God gives, the more thanksgiving will redound to his glory - the more strength you will have in the Lord. This is the reason why we never collapse. It does seem that the `outward' man suffers wear and tear, but at the same time the `inward' man receives fresh strength.

``These little troubles which, lets face it, are really so transitory are the means by which we become able to win a much more permanent, glorious and genuine reward - one that is out of all proportion to our pain. Why? Because instead of paying attention to all those little niggling things that continually press us for our acknowledgment, we concentrate on the so-called `invisible' things that come from our understanding of the Lord.

``And the truth, my friends? It is these so-called `invisible' things which are actually real and eternal, not the gross things of our everyday existence.

``Consider if you will, the transition we know as death. Imagine taking down a tent in the morning after you have slept in it. Is that the end of the sleeper? Hardly! We still have a permanent home that we will return to. It is the same with the body! If the body is `taken down', we know, that we can return to our permanent house in Heaven; not a mortal body made by mortal means, but a permanent body made by God.

``Right now, we feel that deep longing for our heavenly home, but at the same time, we don't want our current home to `collapse' because we would feel unprotected against the elements. And we have that fear of change: it's not that we don't want to be at one with God, but we fear to lose the body that we know on a daily basis and fear being left homeless.

``And God has planned ahead and knows what we want and has a plan to enable us to get there. And because he sees the fear that comes from our uncertainty, he has given us his Spirit as a guarantee of its truth. This makes us confident, whatever happens. We realise that while we continue to see ourselves as living in the body we cannot be fully present with the Lord, and so if we want to be fully with him, we must trust in him without seeing him. We are so sure of this that we would really rather leave the body through death and thus come to be living with the Lord.

``Since it is our aim to please God, whether we are `at home' or `in our tent'. Remember that each and every one of us will on that day have to stand without pretence before Christ our judge, and we shall be rewarded for what we did when we lived in our bodies, whether it was good or bad.

``What we are is utterly plain to God - just as what each of us is individually is clear to that individual throught his conscience. The very spring of our actions is the love of Christ. We look at it like this: if one died for all men then, in a sense, they all died, and his purpose in dying for them is that their lives should now be no longer lived for themselves but for him who died and rose again for them.

``All of this means that while we think we know men based on their outward lives, this isn't really valid. When a man is baptised into Christ he becomes a new person altogether - he is `born again'; born of the spirit and not of the flesh - and his past is finished and gone; everything becomes fresh and new. All this is God's doing, for he has reconciled us to himself through Jesus Christ; and he has made us agents of the reconciliation. God was in Christ personally reconciling the world to himself - not counting their sins against them - and has commissioned us with the message of reconciliation. We are now Christ's ambassadors, as though God were appealing direct to you through us. As his personal representatives we say, `Make your peace with God.' For God caused Christ, who himself knew nothing of sin, actually to be sin for our sakes, so that in Christ we might be made good with the goodness of God.

``As co-operators with God himself we beg you then, not to fail to accept the grace of God. For God's word is - `In an acceptable time I have heard you, and in the day of salvation I have helped you'. And when is the `acceptable time'? I'll tell you: it's right now. This very day is the `day of salvation' that God was talking about.

``As far as we are concerned we do not wish to stand in anyone's way, nor do we wish to bring discredit on the ministry God has given us. Indeed we want to prove ourselves genuine ministers of God whatever we have to go through - patient endurance of troubles or even disasters, being flogged or imprisoned; being mobbed, having to work like slaves, having to go without food or sleep. All this we want to meet with sincerity, with insight and patience; by sheer kindness and the Holy Spirit; with genuine love, speaking the plain truth, and living by the power of God. Our sole defence, our only weapon, is a life of integrity, whether we meet honour or dishonour, praise or blame. Even when we are called `impostors' we must be honest and forthright; when called `nobodies' we must be in the public eye. We are never far from death, but while we are here, we are alive, always `going through it' yet never being `milled under'. We know sorrow in our daily lives, yet our inner joy is inextinguishable. We have `nothing to bless ourselves with' yet we bless many others with true riches. We are penniless, but we have everything worth having.

``We are hiding nothing from you and our hearts are absolutely open to you. Don't link up with unbelievers and try to work with them. What common interest can there be between goodness and evil? How can light and darkness share life together? How can there be harmony between Christ and the devil? What business can a believer have with an unbeliever? What common ground can idols hold with the temple of God? For we, remember, are ourselves living temples of the living God, as God has said: 'I will dwell in them and walk among them. I will be their God, and they shall be my people'.

``Wherefore: `Come out from among them and be separate, says the Lord. Do not touch what is unclean, and I will receive you'. `I will be a father to you, and you shall be my sons and daughters, says the Lord Almighty'.

``With these promises ringing in our ears, dear friends, let us keep clear of anything that smirches body or soul. Let us prove reverence for God by consecrating ourselves to him completely.

``My friends, let us live our lives with that certainty of faith which enables us to overcome everything. I may be a prisoner; I may yet be condemned for telling the truth; but I have no fear because of the promise that is in Christ Jesus.''

32. Rome

AD59 Rome

26 years after the crucifixion

Paul's reception by the brothers of Rome was rapturous.

We had spent over three months on Malta, waiting for the seasons to turn.

In the Spring, another Alexandrian ship had arrived in Malta to reprovision and we were able to obtain passage from there we sailed to Sicily, Rhegium and finally Puteoli. We stayed there a week before walking the rest of the way up the famed Via Appia.

Word had obviously reached Rome ahead of us that we were on our way, and many of the brothers walked down the Appian Way and met us at the Three Taverns Inn outside the city limits. There Paul greeted them and preached to them the word of the Lord as he received it himself.

Ever since Malta, Julius had become a firm believer in the Word of Paul and when we reached Rome offered to accomodate Paul and personally guarantee his safety and that he would not be able to evade justice.

Roman justice can move quickly or slowly - as we had seen with Felix and Festus in Judea. When they wanted to, the magistrates could move a trial along very quickly and make a resolution within days. On the other hand, when a judge was not interested in a case, or when he hoped for some gain by slowing it down - as Felix had - it was possible for the proceedings to be dragged out for months or years.

Paul - by appealing to the emperor - had only one option which was to wait for the emperor to hear his case. Nero had many other distractions - including his beautiful wife, Poppaea - and hearing a difficult and complex case from far-off Judea was, to say the least, a long way down his priorities.

In the meantime, while Paul was held in custody at Julius' house, he was not otherwise denied contact with his peers, and every day saw a large number of brothers gathering in Julius' peristyle in the middle of his house to hear Paul preach.

We had retained as a lawyer in Rome a Senator who was sympathetic to the cause of the Way. Lucullus had not been converted to the Way but had known Priscilla and Aquila for many years and had been their patron. Lucullus came to see us frequently and to bring us what he optimistically called `updates' on the case.

``The truth is,'' he said, ``that the emperor is not really interested in doing any of the job of governing. He is only really interested in entertainment and personal diversion. On the upside, this means that he is generally not causing any problems in the running of the Empire - and thus the administrators are able to do their work with little interference from the supreme authority. On the downside, any actions that really do involve the personal involvement of the emperor are often delayed for years. And your case is one such. I fear that, unless the emperor comes to feel that somehow hearing your case will achieve something for his own benefit, you could be left to languish here for years - possibly even the rest of your life.''

``What can we do then?'' I asked, frightened. This clear miscarriage of justice seemed to have entrapped Paul through the vitals and was threatening to crush out his very existence through terminal inefficiency.

``Not very much,'' he admitted. ``Obviously I will do everything I can to work through my contacts to see if I can convince anybody to speed things along. But equally obviously, we can't push too hard, or it will be held against us. In the meantime, I suggest you do the same and work with anybody you know who may have influence to try and get a summary dismissal or else get the case heard. Whatever we can do to apply pressure.

``But at least in the meantime, you are free to meet people and to continue your preaching; you may want to consider who you preach to though - it would probably go against you if you were to start any riots here in Rome.

``And while you are holed up here, it probably wouldn't hurt to try and prepare your defence: why do you do what you do, what's the history behind it, and what is your story about the various incidents that you know are going to come up at trial.''

``Why?'' I asked, confused.

``Roman justice is very thorough. You have appealed to Caesar. Caesar will not want to deal with your case. Instead, he will send an army of bureaucrats to look into it and then tell him what the right thing to do is. And bureaucrats don't want to have to dig out all the evidence. They want to have it given to them on a plate - or more likely in a book bucket.''

``So give them all of our evidence in written form and make it as exculpatory as possible?''

``And entertaining if you can manage it. And emphasize your loyalty to the emperor.''

And he left.

As he said, one of the big advantages of the Roman system of house arrest pending trial was that the supposed-guilty party could continue in their business provided it could be reasonably done from their home.

Paul invited all the local Jewish elders to come and talk to him a couple of days after his arrival. Not all of them came of course, but a significant number did. Paul was not entirely unknown, but he was not an easily recognized figure in Rome. A number of members of the Way had come here over the years, and some had preached Jesus crucified and resurrected - and Paul himself had written to the brothers in Rome while he had been in Macedonia just before leaving on his fateful trip to Jerusalem. He had said in that letter that he hoped to come and see them soon - but probably had not anticipated the sequence of events that would lead to that coming to pass.

``I am grateful that you could make it here today,'' he began. ``I have come here at the whim of the emperor, but even so he is directed by the one God, and it is only through his power and authority that anything moves on this earth. It is by his power that we are created, and have life. He controls our actions and our passage through this life.

``Many of you will have heard the preaching of the Way already, and I am sure it is a matter of some discussion and dissent in the various synagogues of the city. But I feel that something has been missing in the messengers who have come before me - a real sense of the urgency with which we are facing the future.

``The promises which came to Abraham were promises to him for his seed. The promise included a future revelation that would come to his children one day and would bring about the final judgment and rapture when men had had a chance for repentance.

``And today that time has come! Those are among us who have seen it with their own eyes, and others - myself included - who have experienced the descent of the Holy Spirit through their own souls. And those of us who have encountered this Spirit know it for what it is - the Holy One of God, his Christ.

``The prophet Isaiah prophesied that one was going to come,

`` `To bind up the broken-hearten `` `To set at liberty them that are bruised.

``And I say unto you today that *this has happened*. Jesus, sent from God, born under the law and who lived without sin, was unjustly tried and crucified, not for his sins, but that our sins might be washed clean.

``And if that were not enough, God could not stand that Jesus should be so crucified and acted to restore him to life - bringing his body back from the grave as the first evidence of the coming bodily resurrection. This, my brothers, is what will happen to all of us in the day of glory. We shall all be judged and all those who are found innocent in the Lord will be restored in their perfect bodies *in just the same way as Jesus was restored*.

``And in this future we have all the hope of our eternal life and our bodily resurrection. This *is* the promise which was given to our father Abraham - that we should call God `Father' and he would know us as his perfect children.

``So *now*, and I mean *right now* is the time for all of us to repent of our sins, and to accept the word of God for what it is and what it means - not a dead creed of formulaic rituals and behaviours, but a living well of guidance, as was foretold by Jeremiah:

`` `In that day,' - meaning today - `I shall write my laws in their inward parts, and they shall all know me from the least of them to the greatest.'

``And this is the test by which you can measure your true repentance and acceptance of God - when you have truly repented and accepted God, you will receive the Holy Spirit, and you will know the feeling of oneness with God through his chosen intermediary - Jesus his Christ.''

It takes a lot to stop Paul in full flight, but there were considerable murmurings running through the crowd by this point, and one of the Elders stood up and challenged him:

``We *are* the sons of Abraham. What are you saying? That we need this Jesus to enable us to follow the Law? I have been studying the Law since I was a child and I can assure you it is written in *my* inward parts already.

``I say you are preaching a false schism to defraud the children of Abraham from their inheritance by attempting to deny the Law. The Law is my guide and can be the only guide to eternal salvation. Deny this at your peril!''

Pandemonium broke out, as it so often had during Paul's preaching career. Strong opinions on both sides ruled the day, with moderate voices in the middle - on either side or none - ruthlessly crushed.

``We have a problem,'' Lucullus said the following day as we met before dawn at Julius' house. ``If you continue to preach in this way, inflaming the passions of the local Jews, you will create incidents in the public record here at Rome that will count against you when the Emperor finally does hear your case. Indeed, if an incident like yesterday's were to get out of hand, you could find yourself the recipient of a summary judgment without so much as a hearing before the Emperor.''